

A CYBERPUNK FILMOGRAPHY

Just in case you ran out of books...

Blade Runner

Max Headroom

Terminator 1 & 2

Alien/Aliens

Liquid Sky

Overdrawn at the Memory Bank

Mad Max

The Road Warrior

Thunderdome

Cyborg

Total Recall

Robocop 1 & 2

can be given assignments from a "higher power", or the entire group can be faced with a problem which requires co-operation to solve. The group stays together or it dies. Simple.

We've given you a number of Teams which might naturally evolve in the *Cyberpunk* world. Each proposes a good mix of character roles and offers many ways in which all the players can become equally involved.

Corporate Teams: Corporate teams are groups that are oriented around a specific corporation, working together to accomplish the company's goals. The main base of operations is the corporation's offices or security areas. A good corporate team might consist of one or more Corps (an executive and an assistant), a Netrunner (who runs the team's intrusion and computer systems), a Fixer (who deals with the team's Street contacts), a Tech (either medical or mechanical), and two to three Solos (who handle the combat).

Bands: Bands are any group of Rockerboys who have gotten together to play music. The band travels from place to place, getting into trouble at each new gig, holding concerts and raising hell. The main base of operations can be a practice hall, a club, or a road bus. There may be any number of Rockers in the band itself (although three to four is considered best). In addition, there will be at least one Fixer (who acts as manager), a possible Techie (to handle equipment needs), and several Solos (who are both bodyguards and roadies). Various other slots such as groupies and tour personnel can be Nomads, Corporates (playing record execs), and Medias (as rock-reporters or reviewers).

Trauma Teams: Trauma Teams are groups of licensed paramedics who patrol the city looking for accident victims. They operate from an AV-4 Urban Assault Vehicle, redesigned into an ambulance configuration and armed with a belly mounted minigun. A typical Trauma Team would include a driver (Corporate, Fixer or Solo, although Nomad is best), one or more Medtechies, and two or more Solos acting as "security". The team may also have a Dispatcher (Corp or Fixer) in charge of sending them on their missions. A Media might also tag along with the team, writing stories about their adventures.

Mercenaries: Mercs are often hired throughout the *Cyberpunk* world. A typical merc group could include at least one Fixer (to handle

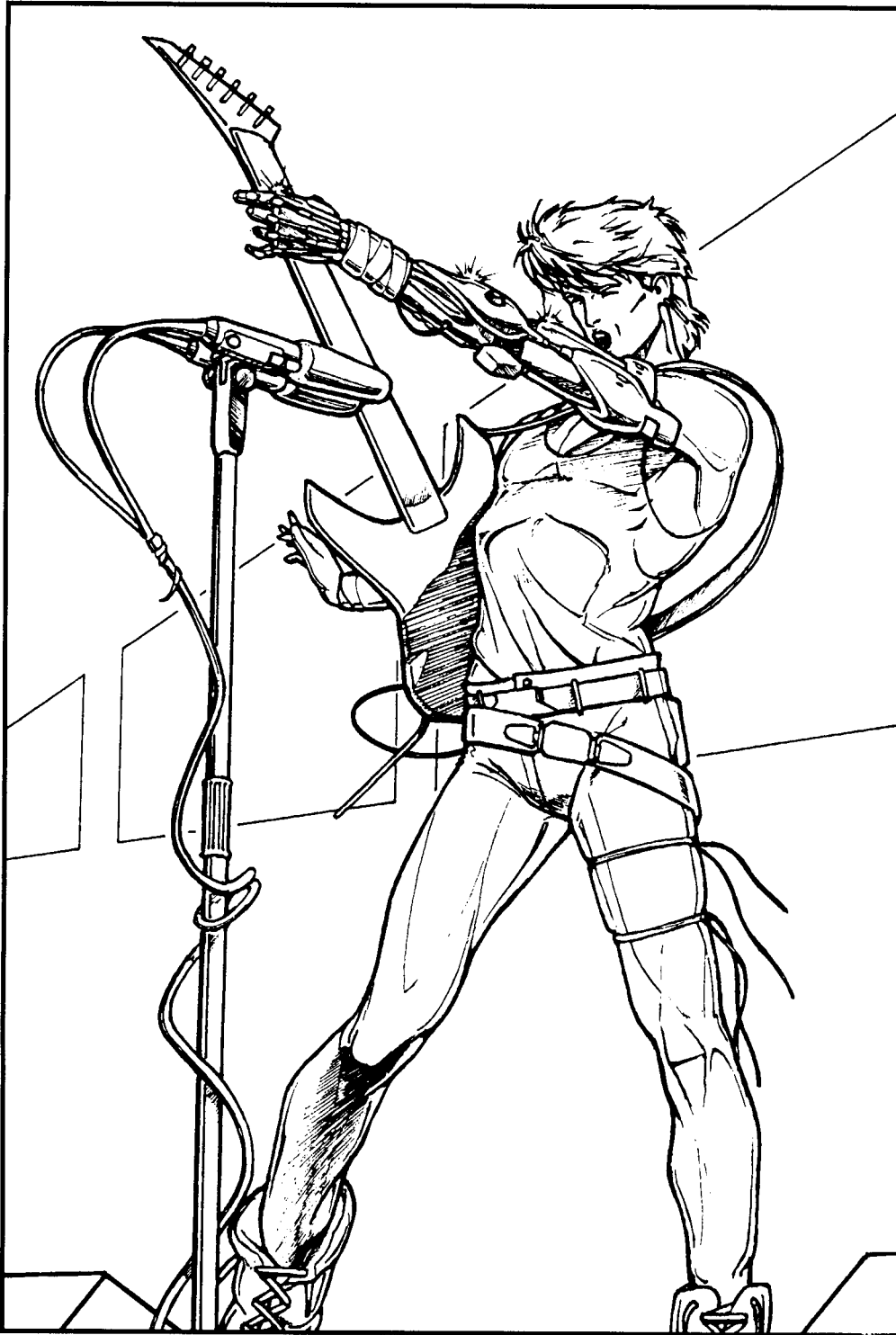
contracts), one Netrunner (to handle security systems, computer assault, etc.), one Techie (for weapons), one Medtechie (for wounded), and any combination of Solos or Nomads (as grunt soldiers). It wouldn't be out of line to have a Media there, writing as a war correspondent. A merc group could operate out of a club, a bar, or a well-hidden paramilitary base camp.

Gangs: Gangs and countergangs are usually the enemy in *Cyberpunk*. But why not turn the tables? Gangs can also be created for positive purposes—neighborhood defense, to stop other more violent gangs, or to resist a major invasion by Government or the Corps. In this context, you could look at Robin Hood or the WWII Resistance as gangs. A typical Gang would have lots of Solos, Nomads and Fixers. There might be a Medtechie or Techie around, and possibly even a Corporate if the gang is one of those controlled by a covert organization. A Media could be covering the gang from the Street angle. Gangs operate out of clubs, bars and deserted buildings.

Nomad Packs: Nomad packs are natural teams—they are already together in one group, and everyone knows each other. A good Nomad pack could include a few Fixers (to handle in-town negotiations), a Netrunner (who handles the pack's intelligence work), a mixture of Techies and Medtechies, and any number of Nomads and Solos. The pack operates from the Caravan—an assemblage of RV's, trailers, buses and cars moving across the blasted landscape of freeway America. The pack members could travel with the main caravan, or as scouts traveling ahead in their own vehicles.

Cops: The Cop team operates out of a seedy, heavily-fortified police station. They might include a few Fixers on the Vice Squad, a Netrunner on Counter Intelligence, a Captain (Corporate) who handles connections with the City Government, and a large number of grunt Cops. Don't forget a few maddened Solos on the Psycho Squad. Cop teams are better than most, as they allow the Referee to break the team into smaller groups of "partners" if needed. A Media might also choose to follow the Cop team, looking for hot stories on the crime beat.

Media Teams: Media teams go anywhere, do anything to get the story. A Media team can operate out of a TV or radio station, a newspaper office, or even a major network news bureau. A good Media team might include two or three Medias (as hard-hitting reporters), a Netrunner (running communications, information gathering, and computer snooping), a



Techie for the equipment, and a couple Solos or Nomads to provide muscle and protection. A good newsroom also will have at least one harried Corporate who has to cover the team with the bosses upstairs.

Don't Give Up Your Day Job

Any one of these Teams can fit a character role that isn't described. A low-level Rocker-

boy could moonlight as a Trauma Teamer while waiting for that big score. A Netrunner might do a little time with a Corporate team, while sneaking into the Company mainframe at night. A Nomad might do almost anything to earn money while his pack is in town. In these cases, the main character role should be treated as an interest, which may become more important to the team as time passes.

*"Sixteen and
sixteen hundred/
Wired with the
max processor
edge.
Never die and
never breaking/
Throw my self
over the ledge.*

*Have you ever
seen the
sunlight/
Screaming fast
and mean and
low?*

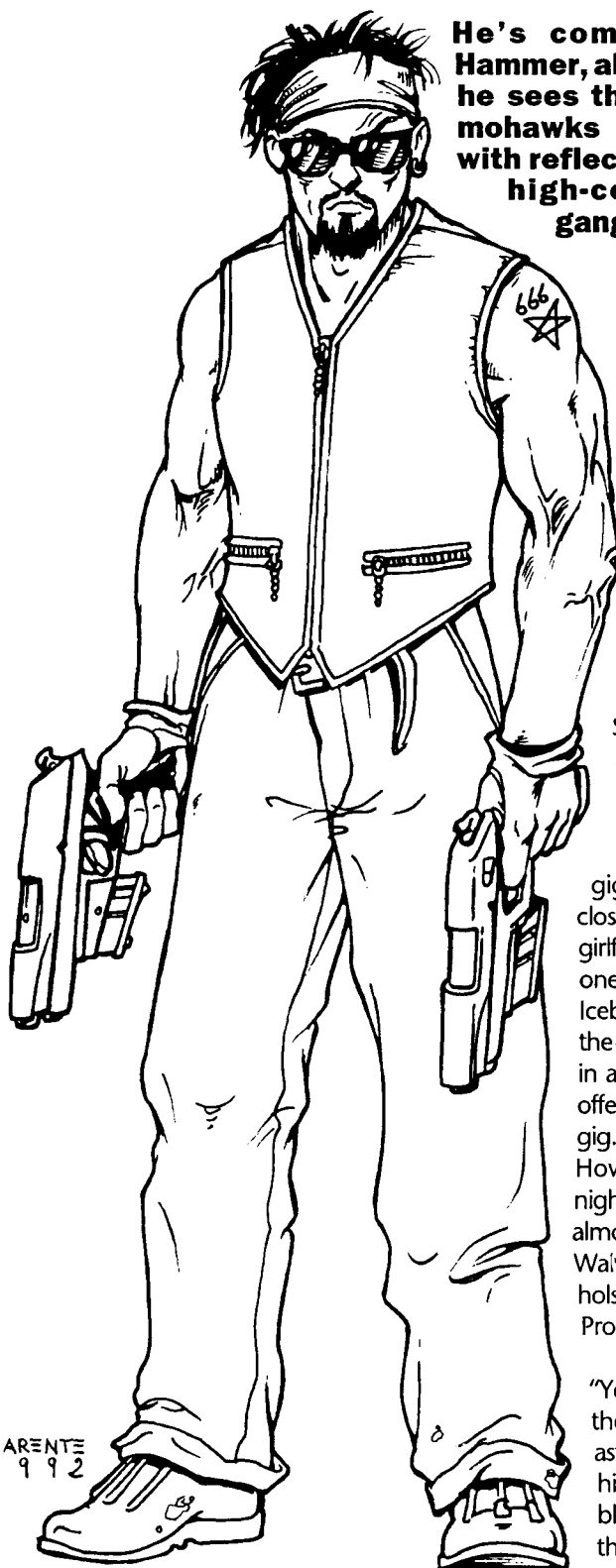
*Get your self
illuminated/
Get yourself that
cyber glow.*

*Made of steel
and hard
emotion/
Give my love
and face the
day/
In your face and
here to party.
Never gonna
fade away"*

*—Johnny Silverhand
Never Fade Away*

SECTION

13 NEVER FADE AWAY



He's coming out of the Hammer, about midnight, and he sees them. Three punks, mohawks bright and bristly with reflected neon, wearing high-collared jackets; gang colors.

"Yo! Rockerboy!" one of them yells, "Good show! Good noise!" Johnny Silverhand waves absently. Fans. They're right; the gig was good. He'd rarely been better. But the show's over.

They start walking towards him. One waves a bottle; the light strikes oily yellow tequila sloshing to and fro. "Yo, Silver-rocker!" he says. The smaller one, with the face scarred in African tribal tattoos. "Join us! Share some! Fair price for a good gig, eh?" The distance is closing; Johnny steers Alt, his girlfriend, to his bad side. The one without the Hand. "Hey, Icebrothers," he says, noting the gang's colors and speaking in a temporizing tone. "Your offer's solid, but it's been a long gig. I'm nearly flatlined as it is. How 'bout a replay, next night?" By that time, they're almost on him. He lets the 9mm Walther drop from the spring holster, settling into the Hand. Probably nothing, he thinks.

"Yeah. Replay next night!," the big one says enthusiastically, and that's when they hit him. This fast, they're a blur. The Walther booms in the close confines of the

alley; whines as spent rounds ricochet off into nowhere. There is a metallic "snick" as the smaller punk brings up his arm—light reflects off the fistfull of razors that pretends to be a hand; then an excruciating impact lifts Johnny off the ground. Blood sprays over wet concrete. Silverhand hits with a bone wrenching impact. His pale eyes stare blankly at the sky. Alt's terrified screams recede swiftly into the dark. Sixty to zero in eight seconds flat.



Johnny comes to. There's something like broken glass in his guts. Red fire blots out the cool blue neon. He rolls over in a pool of something greasy. Blood. His.

A cat topples off the dumpster, picking a cautious pattern around his body. No fool, this cat. A survivor. Not going to get involved. It's eyes are tiny red LEDs moving upalley; Johnny watches it. Smug bastard, he thinks. And closes his eyes.

Behind his eyelids, red digitals feebly clock out his remaining moments. Bio-clock running down. Cars whispering past on the filthy, rain-wet street beyond. A Trauma Team ambulance in the distance, siren screaming. But not for him. He's checking out.

He balls the Hand that is his trademark into a chromed fist, servos clicking in one by one.

He stares blankly up at the flat black ceiling of the city. Overhead, there's the shimmer of distant heat lightning interacting with the pink actinic glow of the City lights. The stars look painted in. A VTOL passes overhead, giant propblades thrashing the night. Johnny tries reaching up to it. He can see the Hand etched against the sky; slick, superchrome winking back at him. He balls the Hand that is his trademark into a

chromed fist, servos clicking in one by one. He thrusts it into the gaping belly wound, gasping at the shocking pain. Somehow, he gets to his feet; staggers to the alleyway. He leans his feverish face against the cool, wet bricks. He makes a decision. He's not going to die. *They're* going to die. Closing his eyes, he pitches forward into the streak of passing traffic blur.

Something stops him. Hands firmly grapple him, holding him up. Silverhand has just enough strength to open his eyes. There's a face looking intently at him, thin, bearded. "Lord Almighty", the face says. "They really *did* you, didn't they?"

Fade to black.

TRAUMA WARD

Something is screaming when Johnny wakes up. Fine. Just as long as it isn't him. He must have missed the ambulance ride to the hospital, but here in the trauma ward he can hear the sound of jet engines. That's the screaming. It mounts higher and higher, while the ward fills with warm air and the smell of ozone. From his stretcher, he can see the bulky AV-4 vehicle spin on it's fans and hurtle upwards. The din dies down and he can hear screaming for real all around him; casualties of the regular firefights around the City.

The doctor puts him back together. The same doctor who did his transparent Kiroshi eyes; his trademark silver hand. The same doctor who "plugged" him for interface and installed the software chips in the back of his skull. Johnny considers taking out a service contract.

Microsurgical waldoes ripcut through the perforated guts, swabbing, tying off, prepping. The doctor stitches in three feet of glistening wet, tank-grown intestine; plugs the punch holes with synthetic skin and muscle. Airhypothes inject the area with speeddrugs, fasthealers, endorphins and antibacterials. Microscopic stitches hum off the serrated teeth of a mini-closer,

bonding flesh together almost as well as the original. In a month or two, there won't even be a scar. Let's hear it for newtech.

The doctor's hands are quick and sure. He has done this a thousand times. He has a German accent. "Ach...Johnny..Johnny" he says, over and over as he works. Over his head, the sterilizer lamps glitter like an insect's multifaceted eyes. "Johnny...When are you going to give this up?" says the doctor.

When it ends, thinks Silverhand, from the fog of the dorpha and general anesthetics. "Johnny," says the doctor sadly. Silverhand is a second son to him. His first son was Johnny's best friend. His first son was killed in an inter-corporate war eight years ago. No man should lose more than one son in a lifetime.

Thanks, thinks Johnny. *I owe you one, again.*

His alleyway benefactor is named Thompson; a thin, reedy type, wearing an armor jack trenchcoat three sizes too large. He packs no visible hardware. But a minicam mount straddles his head like an oversized headphone; a mike loops in front of his mouth, the camera itself coming around the right side of his skull and hardwiring into a startlingly bright green cyberoptic. He's a Media; a one man team of cameraman and reporter, direct feeding to some mediacorp downline. "Hey, Rocker", he says, leaning over the table as Silverhand recovers under the sterilizer beams.

"Ready for a little vengeance?"

THE NAMING OF NAMES

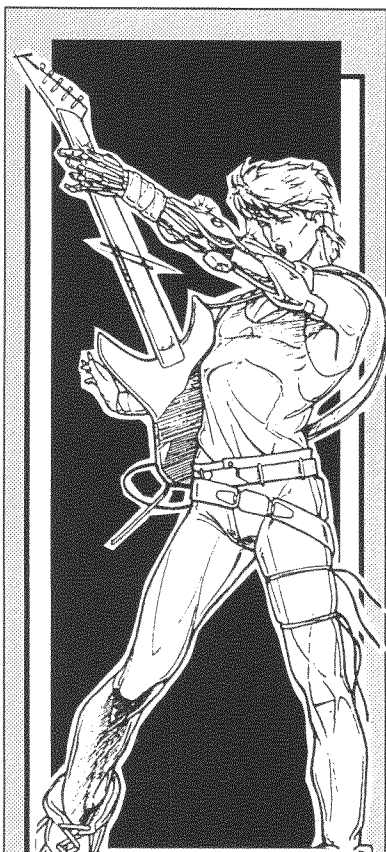
Johnny pulls on a red T-shirt. The shirt has the logo of his last band, *Samurai*. The shirt drags over the freshly stapled wound; hangs up on the bandages. He curses in Japanese. He pulls an armor jacket over his shoulders.

ABOUT THE STORY

Never Fade Away is the story of twenty four hours in the life of Johnny Silverhand, a famous Rockerboy suddenly catapulted into a deadly game of cat and mouse with a sinister Corporate foe. As the cyberpunk genre is mostly literary, it seems fitting we introduce you to *Cyberpunk* roleplaying the same way.

Never Fade Away is primarily a story; but we've made it easy to run as an adventure as well. In these sidebars, you'll find notes on key characters, maps of important locations, data on weapons and combat, and ideas for using the story as a springboard to the adventure.

We suggest you begin your players as characters in the upcoming scene in the *Atlantis*, hired by Johnny to help him get his girlfriend Alt back. Or your players may want to play one of the NPCs from the story.



JOHNNY SILVERHAND

Ex-Central American vet, now Rockerboy, Johnny is the leader of a top band called *Samurai*. He's known for his musical skill, his compelling songs, and a history of trashed relationships.

Stats

INT 7 REF 8 CL 8
MA 7 BODY 7

Cybernetics

Chromed cyberarm with recorder. Sandevistan boost. Two cyberoptics with IR, Low Lite, Enhancement.

Skills

Charismatic Leader +10, Handgun +6, Rifle +4, Guitar +9, Perform +7, Notice +6, Seduction +8.

Possessions

Heavy Armor Jacket, Light Helmet. H&K MPK-11, Arasaka Rapid Assault.

He pulls the autoshotgun out of his battered bedroom dresser, checking the load and weight. He slips it carefully into the worn under-arm holster, under the jacket. He stuffs shiriken into pockets on the outside of the jacket. He picks up the heavy H & K smartgun and slides it into his back holster. There is a fury behind glittering pale eyes.

"So," he says. "Tell me."

Thompson leans back into the wall, body bracing against Johnny's intensity. He grins; takes a slug of Silverhand's tequila. "They didn't want you. They wanted her. She's an extraction. Business as usual."

Johnny's eyes are blank. "No surprise", he comments shortly. He gathers up a ragged handful of shells and begins to stuff-load the H&K's spare clip. Only the trembling of his hand—the meat hand—betrays any emotion. "So why'd they do me?" he asks.

"I let you take it, because I knew it would take at least five minutes for you to bleed yourself dry..."

"You was home", grins Thompson. It's an old line. They both smile like friendly sharks. Thompson stops smiling. "They wanted you flatlined so it'd look like a gang job. Boostergang sees the high and mighty Mister John Silverhand out strolling with his input; decides to slash him a bit. You go down, they grab her; they're gone like vapor. Real convenient when the cops find her body in an alley 'bout a week later. They'll have motives—lots of ugly motives, but they'll be those of high-powered boosters, not pros."

"Pros." Silverhand finishes loading the second clip. He stuffs the remaining shells in the armorjack's pockets. You can never have enough ammo.

"Yeah, pros," repeats Thompson. "You got shredded for fine, bro. At least a clean ten thousand Eurobucks of hardware on those boys. The speed they hit you with took maybe a seventy percent reflex boost, and

those were custom rippers. The type that fold out along the fists. That sort of hardware isn't something you pick up on the Street."

"You saw them on me?"

Thompson's eyes are cold, slate-like. You could write anything you wanted in them. "Get real," he grates. "These were pros. If I'd jumped in, we'd both be dead." The eyes appraise him. "You've been off the Street too long, Rocker. You think everyone has a nice agent, a couple Solos covering their butts, and a comfy apartment like this somewhere. I let you take it, because I knew it would take at least five minutes for you to bleed yourself dry. I waited for them to move on, then used my Trauma Card." There is a longish silence. Then, "Look, Rocker. You want to guilt-loop, or you want to get your girl back?"

"So name names," says Johnny. He sits down on the edge of the bed, favoring his stapled side. He reaches out for the tequila and takes a slug.

"Good news/bad news," says Thompson. He's unlimbered the cybercam unit from around his head and set it down on the table between them—the only indication of hardware is the silvermounted skull plug drilled through his right temple. The cam's cellular link through the NET is off. Thompson says, "Good news is, it isn't one of the really big guys, like Eurobusiness Machines. "Fair enough," says Silverhand, taking another swig from the bottle.

"Bad news is, it's Arasaka."

"Jesus H. Christ!" explodes Johnny. The Hand, resting on the edge of the table, convulses. There's a rending noise and splinters fly in all directions.

"Your input was playing with hotdeck materials, rocker. You know she ran for ITS, right?"

"Yeah. So you gotta work somewhere. Alt didn't talk much about her work."

"True. But your Alt was ITS's pet netrunner. She moved info up and down the NET and

handled their security as well. She made a lot of classy software just for them." Long pause. "She built *Soulkiller*, you know. Or maybe you didn't. Like you said, she didn't talk much about her work."

Johnny sits back on the couch, the bottle halfway to his lips. Even the normally disconnected Silverhand has heard of *Soul-killer*, the legendary black program that sucks the very soul from it's Netrunner victims. *Soulkiller*. What a joke. *Soulkiller* is a 2,000,000 meg AI super routine that can track an intruding Netrunners's cyberlink faster than a boostergang snorts drugs. It tears out the cyberpirate's brain with brutal force, recreating it in a frozen storage matrix inside the mainframe. The word is on the Street that *Soulkiller* may be the closest thing to Hell on earth, and in these days, that's saying a lot.

And Alt made that? Johnny bites down a momentary wave of revulsion, superimposed over Alt's big green eyes, tousled mane of hair. "No wonder she didn't talk about her work," he says finally.

"I was following her, Rocker," says Thompson. "Word's out that Arasaka is working on it's own version of *Soulkiller*. Something that can walk the NET freely, getting up close and personal with people Arasaka doesn't like."

"A black program assassin for a security company?" Johnny is up and pacing now. He knows where this is going, and he doesn't like it.

"You probably believe in Santa Claus too," says Thompson, reclaiming the dregs of the bottle. "Your Alt is the missing link. I figured they'd have to recruit her sooner or later, whether free or forced. *Soulkiller*'s main programming is buried in her head somewhere. So I followed her."

"Thanks for the concern."

"You don't get it, Rockerboy. I want Arasaka. I want them bad. I'll put anyone and anything on the line to get them. Even myself—if I have to broadcast this story from the grave, I'll do it. They're mine. You get in my way, you're flatlined. You go with me..." Thompson lets it trail out.

Johnny stops pacing. The room goes still. Only the Hand moves, like something alive; silver metal joints clicking, takeup reels whirring, tiny pistons shooting in and out in simulation of a pulse. The Hand turns Johnny to face the mediaman. It makes him say, "How long do we have?"

Thompson reaches down to his feet; draws up a long black, nylon bag. "FN-FAL assault," he says, standing up. "I was in the War. I like lead. Lots of lead."

Thompson smiles lopsided. "How long will it take your input to rewrite *Soulkiller*? A day? Two?"

"Yeah." Johnny turns, scoops up the keys to the Porsche. "You chipped for a smartgun?" he says. Thompson reaches down to his feet; draws up a long black, nylon bag. "FN-FAL assault," he says, standing up. "I was in the War. I like lead. Lots of lead."

Rain runs down the front of the speeder. A wall of Corporate glass and steel looms to either side as they pull out into the downtown traffic. The Porsche whistles slightly in the chill air, it's methanol powerplant throwing it against the City night. "So where are we going, Rocker?" says Thompson.

Johnny grits his teeth. "I've got a marker I have to pull in," he says.

ROGUE & SANTIAGO

Rogue hates the Atlantis. But she goes there because the contacts are good, and the pickings easy. Corporates looking for a fast freelance assassination. Medias and 'Runners looking to trade information. Fixers with guns, armor and smuggling jobs. But the place has bad memories. She only comes here because Santiago insists on it.



THOMPSON

A top reporter for World News Service, Thompson has a running feud with the infamous Arasaka Corporation, whom he suspects of having murdered his wife. He will do anything to get the elusive security firm—anything. Thompson also served in the Wars as a correspondent, and is fond of heavy weapons.

Stats

INT 8 REF 8 CL 7
MA 8 BODY 8

Cybernetics

One cyberoptic with IR, Low Lite, Targeting scope. Cyberaudio with radio splice, scrambler, chip recording.

Skills

Credibility +8, Rifle +6, Interview +9, Composition +7, Athletics +6, Notice +6, Intimidate +5.

Possessions

Med. Armor Jacket, Light Helmet. FN-RAL Hvy. Assault Rifle.



ROGUE

Rogue and her partner Santiago, are hit men and bodyguards. The word on the Street is that they're the best. Rogue's one weak spot is Johnny Silverhand, her ex-lover. Their violent, passionate relationship disintegrated in a massive blowup a year ago, but the scars haven't healed yet for this hardbitten Solo.

Stats

INT 7 REF 12 CL 9
MA 10 BODY 8

Cybernetics

Two cyberoptics with IR, Low Lite, Targeting scope, Sandevistan boost, Karate chipped to +3.

Skills

Combat Sense +9, Hand-gun +10, Brawling +9, Drive +7, Rifle +10, Melee +6, Athletics +9, Notice +8, Seduction +8.

Possessions

Med Armor Jacket, Light Helmet. Armalite 44 Very Heavy Pistol.

"You don't let personal caca get in the way of business," he says. A lot he knows.

Her back is to the wall of the booth—her mirrorshaded eyes scan the room like monitor cameras. What she can't see is covered by her partner, Santiago, from the opposite side of the booth. His burly shoulders bulk the heavy armor jacket—he looks like scowling mountain. He's not her type. But he wants her. Somehow, they've managed to work this out—the way they worked out a combat style; the division of spoils. But he keeps hoping. Stupid Nomad.

Then she finds herself facing what she's dreaded for the last two years; the reason she hates this crummy bar; hates this crummy town. Johnny Silverhand walks into the Atlantis.

He still has the moves, she thinks, as he strides through the big brass doors. Head held high, a cocky light in his pale glass eyes. After all this time, Rogue still can't decide whether she wants him, or just wants to kill him. He looks like he owns the place as he crosses the room towards her; a comment to an old friend here, smiling at a fan there, a narrowed glance at a potential troublemaker; then he's standing in front of her. "Rogue," he says. Like nothing'd ever happened. "I need your help, Rogue." His voice is urgent, magnetic.

"You can go to hell," she replies levelly. On the other side of the booth, there's a faint sound as Santiago slides one hand over the Mac 10 in his lap.

Johnny leans closer. "Look," he says, "I'm sorry. I know how you feel. I wouldn't do this if I had any other choice. He pulls up a chair and straddles it, staring at her. "Tough." she shoots back acidly. She hopes her voice sounds steadier than she feels.

"You owe me one," he says, his voice taking an edge. "For Chicago. You owe me one at least. And it's not like I won't pay you. I've got euro."

"How much?" interjects Santiago. Johnny turns to face him. "Word on the Street is you're pulling five grand a night. I'll match and double it. "

Santiago's eyes grin in his swarthy face. He scratches his chin with his free hand. His partner has a real mad on about this guy. But he's a Face—he's got credit; that pulls weight in Santiago's world. "How long?"

"Two days max. I need an extraction. I won't haze you—it's Arasaka." A long pause. "I'll understand if you think it's too much for you."

Rogue reacts, her chipped reflexes kicking into overdrive. Her hand is a blur as it stabs up off the table, the bunched knuckles smashing the Solo's nose back into his face. He's dead before he hits the floor...

Santiago's eyes narrow. On the Street, their team is known as the best. Who does this choob think he is? Then the nomad realizes he's being baited. Silverhand's already figured the score between the two partners. If Santiago backs up on this, it'll be all over the Street tomorrow. If he goes with it, Rogue's going to have to back his play. Rogue's right—Silverhand is a bastard. Santiago grins. He can take this punk with one hand behind his back. "It's going to cost you thirty thou, Rocker."

"Done."

Santiago grins and raises the stakes. "And you come with us," he finishes. From her side of the booth, Rogue's eyes smolder at her partner. She'd object, but the rule of the game is, "You don't let personal caca get in the way of business". When Johnny pulled out his wallet, as far as Santiago was concerned, it became business.

"Done" says Johnny. He is reaching out across the table to match grips with the big Nomad when one long shadow falls over the table, then another.

"Ah, Mister Silverhand," the bigger shadow says, leaning close. You can see red LED light scrolling behind his optics, forming crosshairs as he brings the smartgun up.

Rogue reacts, her chipped reflexes kicking

into overdrive. Her hand is a blur as it stabs up off the table, the bunched knuckles smashing the Solo's nose back into his face. He's dead before he hits the floor, but spasmed muscles tighten on the trigger of the big Beretta. There's a deafening BOOM! in a very small space, but Johnny's boosted reflexes have already thrown him up and over. There's a scream as the slug rips through the back of the booth and blows through the chest of a Corp sitting on the other side of the thin wall. Rogue's other hand fires the silenced Automag from under the table, ripping the smaller solo in half.

Santiago rolls, hitting the floor. Over by the bar, three figures in armorjackets stand up, weapons in hand; Santiago's MAC 10 hammers a short burst. The figures go flat; one staggers back into the window and falls through in a shattering sound like a hundred dropped chandeliers. Thompson brings up the FN-FAL with studied nonchalance, covering the two remaining, prone figures. "Gotcha," he says.

Johnny hits the bar floor; gun high and eyes scanning the corners. Patrons keep their hands away from weapons—everyone plays cool. The disemboweled Solo on the floor whimpers. Back to back, the four of them edge out of the bar.

RUNAWAY

"We are seriously tagged," gasps Rogue as they hit the sidewalk. "They must have tracked my Trauma Card," grunts Thompson. "Guess they wanted to finish the job. You know some nice people, Rocker."

They reach the Porsche just in time to see the shadow of an unmarked AV-4 sweep over it. Garbage, oil, and filthy water explode into steam as the jet exhausts hit the pavement. Rogue is already down, drawing a bead on the cockpit with her .44. Above her head, Santiago's MAC 10 roars in deafening staccatto. The tiny red spot of her laser scope pinpoints the AV-4 pilot's forehead, even as she sees the minigun sweep around towards them. She's not going to make it. The canopy's got to be armored. She doesn't even have time to watch her life flash before her eyes.

Then the laserdot is eclipsed by a screaming WHHHHHOOOOMMMMMPPP! as something slams into the AV-4. The entire canopy—the entire front of the aircraft bells out in a horrible slow-mo inferno—a rancid smell of hot metal, melted plastic and



NOMAD SANTIAGO

Santiago is a Nomad who runs with the Aldecaldos Pack; displaced farmers thrown off their land by the Corporations. Santiago is a simple guy—he likes girls, guns, and fast cyberbikes. He teams with Rogue mostly because she's the one girl he hasn't been able to score with yet.

Stats

INT 5 REF 11 CL 9
MA 10 BODY 10

Cybernetics

Two cyberoptics with IR, Low Lite, Targeting scope, Kerenzikov boost, Cyberarm with Kevlar armor, 9mm SMG. Cyberleg with 9mm pistol in thigh holster.

Skills

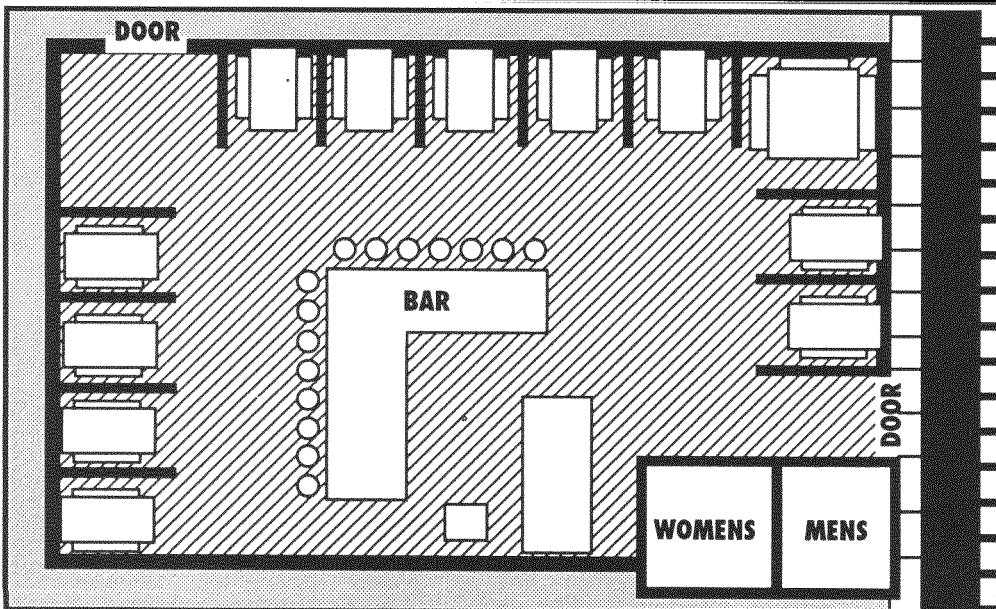
Family +8, Handgun +9, Judo +9, Drive +7, Rifle +9, Melee +9, Athletics +9, Notice +8, Seduction +8.

Possessions

Heavy Armor Jacket, Light Helmet. AKR Medium Assault Rifle, Bimoda Cyberbike.

THE ATLANTIS

It's your turn to tackle the *Atlantis Firefight*. Start with the Basic Goons on page 186. They've just walked in to the front door. Pick a place where your party is sitting. It's time to rock and roll!





seared flesh gusts against her as the AV tilts to one side and drunkenly impacts the street. A fireball shatters the night. "Love those grenade launchers," smirks Thompson, lowering his steaming FN-FAL.

Santiago's MAC 10 hammers a short burst. The figures go flat; one staggers back into the window and falls through in a shattering sound like a hundred dropped chandeliers.

"We gotta get out of here," grits Johnny from behind a parked car. Rogue looks into his eyes—she can see the faint red etching of a targeting pattern flickering in their pale depths. "Right," she says, already up and moving. Her breath catches ragged in her throat as they run back into the shadows.

Santiago takes point; he knows all the best boltholes in the area. Thompson is next, the big FN-FAL sweeping their way like a flashlight. Johnny keeps his H&K close to his body; his nerves are tingling with booster effects; he's running like he's on speed. Alleyways streak by as blurs—he compensates his time sense. Rogue is covering the rear, and he can hear her breathing behind him. He says over his shoulder to the breathing dark shadow, "I'm sorry, Rache."

Her voice is flat. "Never call me that," she says. "Never again." He keeps running. "Okay," he says finally. "fair enough."

She stops running. She says, "Why Johnny? Why now? Couldn't you have gotten anyone else?" She can hear him slow ahead of her. He says, "I needed the best. And you're still the best, Rogue."

The best. Damn him.

ALT

She wakes with her mouth full of cotton wool. She's smart enough to keep her eyes closed; to stifle any urge to scream. Boosterboys like it when you scream. They like

it so much, they'll do anything to make you scream over and over again.

Alt silently triggers commands to redline her senses to maximum. She's relieved to find herself still clothed and relatively unharmed. Not typical Booster, but she won't complain. Her enhanced hearing picks up breathing nearby; the click of glasses and ice, computer terminals. Definitely not Boosters. Alt takes a chance and opens her eyes, spits out the gag.

A slender, Asian-looking man is watching her. Neat, well-tailored suit. A glass of real Scotch in one hand, which he offers towards her. "Welcome, Ms. Cunningham", he says, his mouth smiling and his eyes frozen. "I am Toshiro." He gestures towards another man; a hulking presence lounging by the bar. "This is Akira", he says.

Alt sits up slowly, cautiously, her boosted senses giving her clues. The comforting weight of her plastic autogun is missing. But she still has her cybered arm. "Can I get a drink of that?" she says, gesturing towards the glass in Toshiro's hand. "Certainly" he says. A gesture to Akira, and the hulk turns obediently to mix a drink. Alt is surprised at the grace of the big man's hands. He moves like an athlete. He moves like a professional killer. Akira brings her the drink, and Alt doesn't even think about making a break for it.

"Thanks." The drink cools the pounding flame in her head.

"Certainly. It is the least we can do for a promising new associate."

Bingo! she thinks. She's been grabbed by corporate headhunters. Fine. Great. She can deal with it. Just learn the rules, play the game, and go to work. After a week, it'll be just like checking into work at the ITS offices. "So..." she says cautiously. "What kind of work do you have lined up for your new...um...employee?"

Toshiro leans forward, setting the drink down on the couch. He says, "So." He says, smiling, "Ms. Cunningham. I wish you to tell me all about the program you call...*Soulkiller*."

Her blood freezes like a silenced scream



BASIC GOONS

These are the type of disposable cannon fodder that often shows up on the Street. They're just what your players need to get themselves blooded and ready for tougher challenges.

Stats

INT 5 REF 10 CL 5
MA 6 BODY 9

Cybernetics

One cyberoptic with IR, Targeting scope, Karate chipped to +3, Rippers.

Skills

Combat Sense +5, Handgun +5, Brawling +5, Drive +7, Rifle +5, Melee +5, Athletics +5.

Possessions

Med Armor Jacket, Light Helmet. Sternmeyer Type 35 Heavy Pistol.

A GATHERING OF HOSTS

"So this means we've gotta punch into the main offices of the most rabidly paranoid security company in the universe," considers Santiago. "Homeboy, you pick some great places to lose your women."

"Stuff it," cuts in Rogue. "Here's the plan."

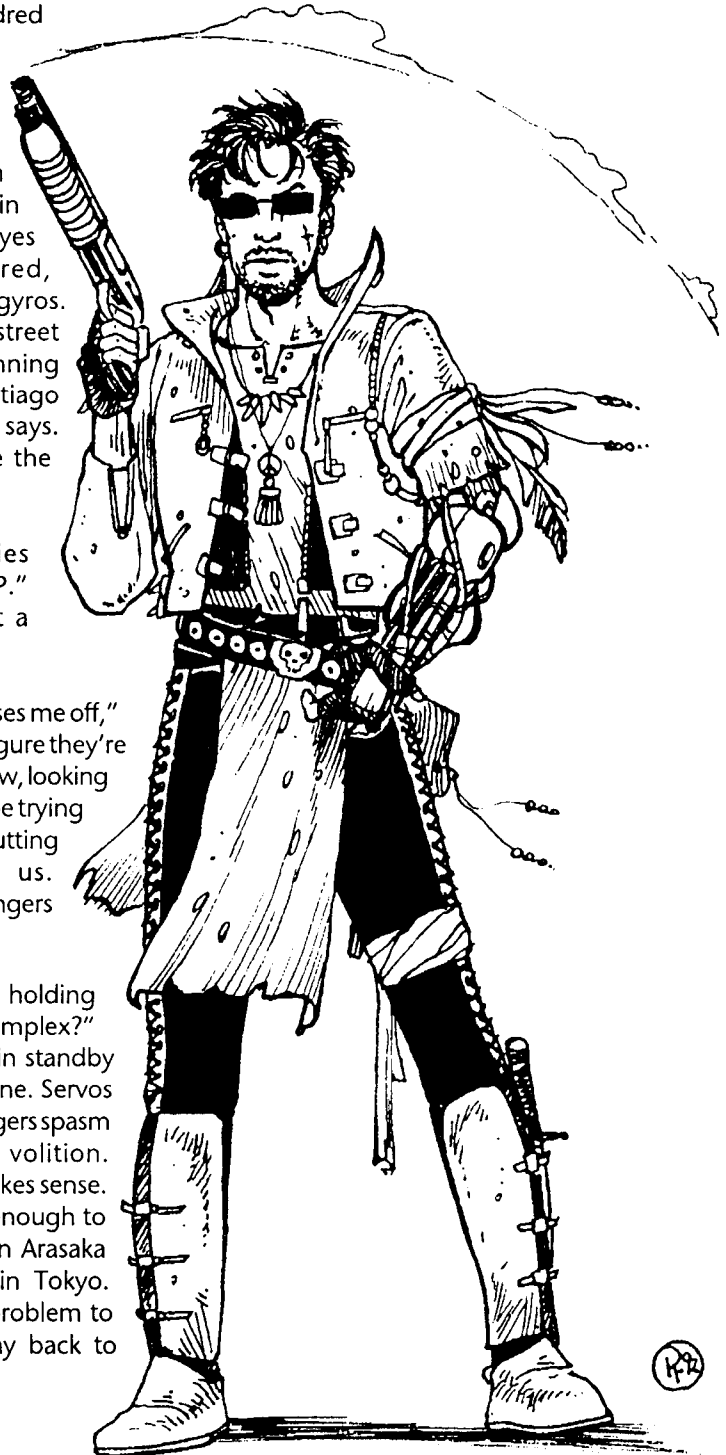
Johnny, Santiago, Thompson and Rogue. They are perched two hundred feet in the air on a rusting fire escape. From their vantage point on the blackened brick side of the old Mark Luxor Hilton they can see ten blocks in any direction. Rogue's eyes are switched to infrared, scanning for AV's and airogyros. Johnny is watching the street below. Thompson is scanning the radio chatter and Santiago is talking. "We go in," he says. It's been two hours since the firefight.

"Fair enough," replies Rogue. "But we do it ASAP." Santiago grins. "You got a reason?"

"Getting shot at always pisses me off," she grins back. "Besides, I figure they're combing the Street right now, looking for us. They'll expect us to be trying to ditch them—they'll be putting their best out to find us. Meanwhile, the second stringers are guarding the offices."

"How you figure they're holding her in the Arasaka office complex?" says Johnny. The Hand is in standby mode, running a test routine. Servos click and whirr and silver fingers spasm and flex of their own volition. Thompson speaks up. "Makes sense. The only mainframe big enough to run *Soulkiller* is in the main Arasaka building. Either that, or in Tokyo. We're not a big enough problem to rate flying her all the way back to Japan."

"Thanks."



INTERFACE THE MUSIC

Headfirst in the Net, Alt weaves magic.

They've studded her into the Arasaka mainframe, given her room to run, hemmed in only by three Arasaka netrunners who watch her every move. Her body lies comatose on a contour couch, linked by cables to a cybermodem. She's pulling down subroutines, crunching the compilers, getting comfy with the CPU's. From memory and notes, she's recreating *Soulkiller*, the eater of minds.

Soulkiller is a stationary program, locked to a part of the system architecture. The challenge Toshiro has given her is to give it movement—the ability to navigate the Net on it's own.

It's a subtle problem—navigation data and decision subroutines take up a huge amount of memory; the reason freeroaming programs are so limited in scope. *Soulkiller* already eats a lot of megabytes, to make it freerunning will take more memory than any normal computer can handle. The problem excites her professionalism even as the creation revolts her humanity.

God, they know her so well.

The original *Soulkiller* started as a matrix to contain artificial personalities. She'd studied the concept, worked out the parameters for creating a storage matrix. She'd been fascinated and awed to discover that the same matrix could contain living engrams; transfer them from computer to body and even back again. It was immortality.

ITS had taken it from her to build a killer. And she hadn't known how to stop them.

Now Alt looks over her options. If she doesn't build Arasaka's monster, they'll torture or kill her. If she builds their horror, they'll keep her alive. But.

But once it's built, they'll put her into it.

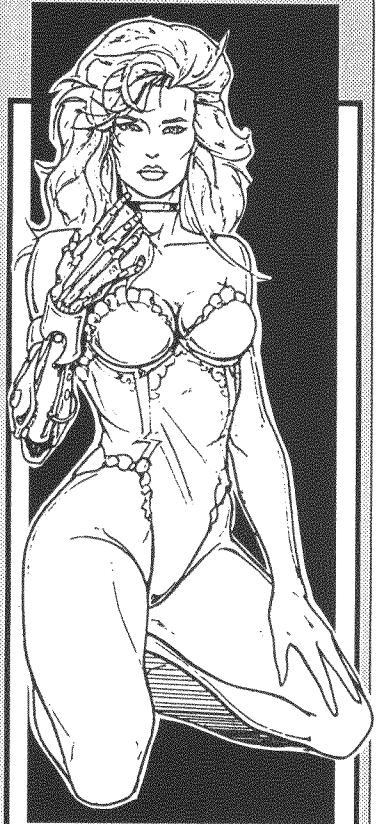
WAR PARTY

A plan hinges on strange elements.

Rogue leaves their motel bolthole at nine. She moves fast, travels light, moving from place to place. Here, she picks up five pounds of plastic explosives; there, flash-bombs, timers and tripwires. Santiago covers her. He picks up more explosives, a combat assault cyberdeck, and a long, bulky black sniper rifle.

Johnny's on the cellular, working the connections. He pulls his bandmates in from around the City, carefully dodging the phone taps, shadowers and snoops. He sets the time and place and the gig is on.

Thompson is on the Street, working hard. A phone call here, a tip to the screamsheets



ALT

Johnny's new girlfriend, Alt has a history he hardly suspects. A hotshot programmer and Net whiz, she's written an incredibly deadly program that can suck your mind out and eat it. But Alt is no helpless heroine, as Toshio learns to his undoing.

Stats

INT10 REF 7 CL 9
MA 6 BODY 6

Cybernetics

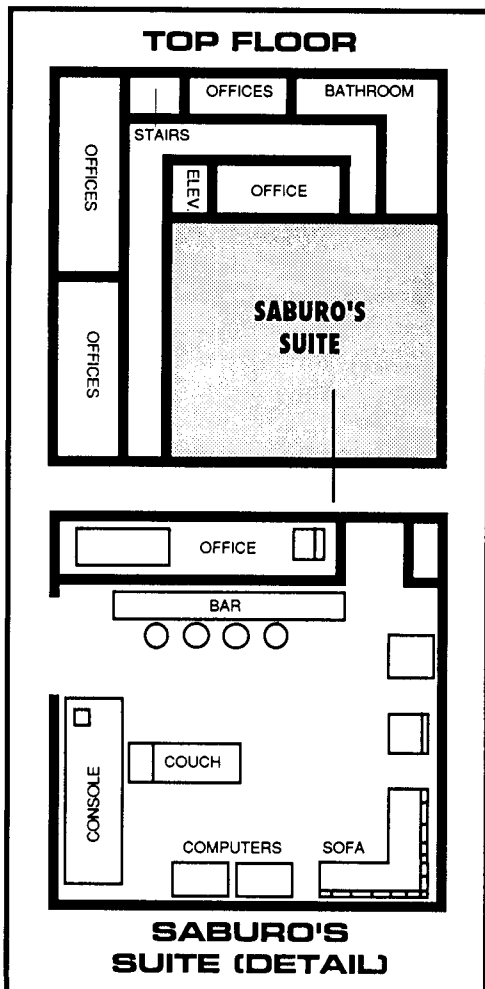
Interface plugs. Gold cyberarm with hidden compartment.

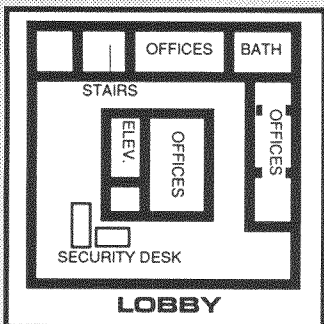
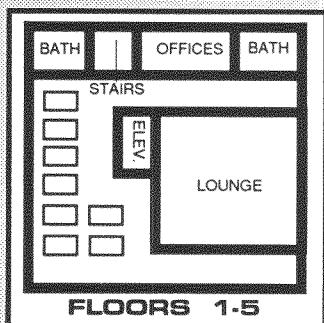
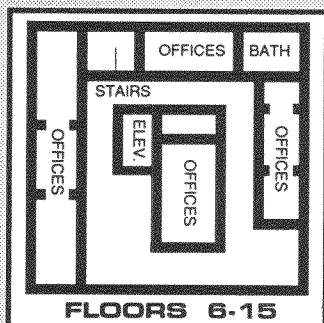
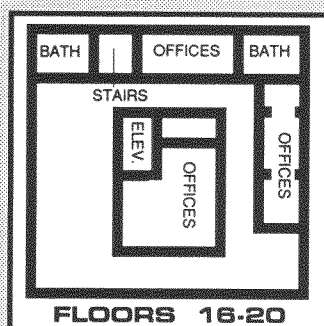
Skills

Interface +10, Handgun +2, Drive +4, Athletics +5, Notice +8, Seduction +7.

Possessions

Light Armor Jacket, monoknife, Federated Arms X-22 pistol.





THE ARASAKA FLOOR PLAN

Here's the internal layout of the Arasaka Tower. Place your players at the front door, about to enter the Security Desk area. At the start of the attack, the guards have been overwhelmed by the mob rampaging through the lobby, and may not attack the players for three rounds.

there. A Fixer picks up a little euro on the side, and passes the word down. By ten a.m., the Street knows there's going to be a party. By noon, the word is all over the Street—the band is Samurai, the time is sundown, and the Smash is free.

By one, the Street knows the party is going to be on the edge of town at Industrial Park.

Arasaka's twenty two story office compound faces Industrial Park.

Like a single, hungry thing, the mob converges.

SORCEROR'S APPRENTICE

7.29 p.m.

The twisting construct spins, a blazing pillar of white fire, sparkshowers of stars. A glowing DNA chain, a whirling dervish takes shape and form, in the construct reality of the interface, towering above her, looming like fear itself. Dazzling, it exudes the palpable scent of terror. It speaks in a voice like crystal, and momentarily Alt's breath is taken by it's perfect, murderous beauty. "I am." it sings triumphantly to the cold stars.

"I am your Controller." Alt replies. "You will follow my commands." A slight hesitation in her voice.

"As always," it says, as though doubt had never existed in the universe. "What is your bidding, Mistress?"

Alt lets out a long, exhausted breath. She's gotten the Controller override past her watchdogs. Now she has a chance.

"This is what I want you to do," she begins.

PARTY HARD

Seicho Harada is second in command of Security for the Arasaka complex at Industrial Park. Seicho is afraid. Since early afternoon, the people have been pouring into

the large, grassy park opposite his guard position; at first a trickle, then a stream, then a torrent. He can't figure it out. They don't do things like this in Tokyo. In Tokyo, people are consistent. They make sense. Here, people are animals. He thinks about calling the City Cops, but that would reflect badly on Arasaka. The world's largest security corporation calling for help? What a loss of face. But there are six thousand people crammed into the tableau in front of him.

Up on the makeshift stage, acting as though invulnerable, struts Johnny Silverhand, working the crowd up. Seicho wants him. He wants him dead. But Silverhand might as well be on Luna as far as Arasaka is concerned. A single gunshot could trigger a riot of unbelievable proportions. Seicho can feel the tension building. So can Johnny. An invisible thread binds them as adversaries, eye to eye over a battlefield of unwitting bodies.

Johnny smiles. He's got them, so far. The crowd is paranoid—they expect to be thrown out at any minute. He's been pumping them for the last hour with chromatic and metal rock, getting them edgy and irritable; in a party mood to scream and shout, kick some tail. The first uniformed bozo who interrupts their party is going to get himself hosed.

*Got the chrome in the bloodstream
Got a metal soul,
I'm out looking for action,
Guess I'm on a roll*

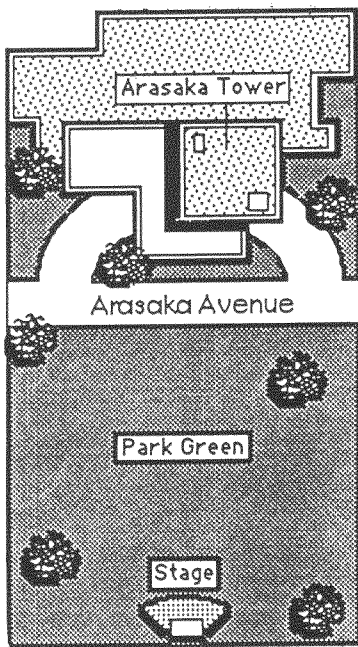
It's like driving the freeway at two hundred miles per hour. The crowd swells and breathes as the first verse goes down, taking on the cohesiveness of a living thing. The bass player picks up the back beat and the two of them slam into the next turn of the song, dragging the crowd with them.

*Got the old mega violence,
When I boost, it's for real,
The capacitors roarin' inside my brain
You know just how I feel*

*Cold chrome, molten lead
Can't be hurt cuz I'm already dead
Ain't no time as real as realtime
I'm chipping in
Chippin in.*

THE ARASAKA TOWER

Here's the story. The group that Johnny is leading numbers about 100 people. There are twenty guards facing the park. Each turn, roll 1D6 for the Arasaka side and remove that many people. Then, roll 1D10 for the crowd and remove that many people. When the guards get down to four men, they'll break and run. Meanwhile, you and your group should use the crowd as cover to get into the building. Good luck, chomba.



Johnny's eyes scan the perimeter of the park. To one edge, he can see Santiago in position on the rooftop opposite of the Arasaka complex. Deep in the crowd, Thompson and Rogue are poised, ready to make the break. All he has to do is give them the chance; the diversion.

All he has to do is turn around and lead six thousand people right into a wall of weapons.

*Chippin in (got my head to the wall)
Chippin in (can ya hear me call)
Chippin in (I'm the man of steel)
Chippin in (Is that how ya feel?)
Well, comon!*

The moment freezes, hanging in air like a death. Punching his battered Telecaster

guitar over to "remote", Johnny leaps off the stage, pushing his way through the crowd. His voice holds solid over the radio mike; powerful, pleading, entreating, seducing, and the huge crowd turns with him; surges around him, swallows him. It's knifeedge balanced—six thousand people teetering on the edge, chanting, singing. At the perimeter of the park, Arasaka police stand guard nervously, their eyes riveted on the mob. Silverhand starts towards them, and they choke on the decision—twenty guards facing down a wall of humanity, centered on one man whose voice holds them, binds them. An assault rifle comes up, and the crowd, like an irritable dog, notices the small army facing them down. The scene is set; the guards distracted, and on the rooftop, Santiago takes aim...

It's like driving the freeway at two hundred miles per hour. The crowd swells and breathes as the first verse goes down, taking on the cohesiveness of a living thing.

Then it goes wrong. One of the faceless guards loses his nerve. The staccatto sound of gunfire splits the air. But Johnny is already gone, faded back into a mob that howls like a wounded thing, then surges forward, shattering like surf against armored bodies, lobby doors, massed vehicles, guns. Screams. Gunfire. The strobe flash of the mob tearing a guard apart with vampire teeth, and ripper claws. The sound of a sniper rifle high above the melee, as Santiago methodically picks out guards and blows them away with his Walther WA-2000 rifle. The lobby doors explode inwards as six thousand bodies slam against them.

Rogue is already in—in when Santiago took out the pair of guards by the main doors. She's on the floor and rolling, a fast dazzle bomb palmed over the top of the security desk to fry the optics of the monitor team, followed by a frag grenade a second later. The deafening explosion goes unnoticed in the typhoon roar of the mob. Thompson's right behind her, his video rig and FN-FAL sweeping everything in his path. Both wear armor jacks with the colors of the infamous Iron Sights boostergang, a known Arasaka hit group.

ADVANCED GOONS

These are Arasaka's front line defense; the guards covering the inside of the Tower. Use an equal number of goons as you have players. At the start of the attack on the Tower, the Arasaka guys will be in the Lobby. Remember; if it get's too hot for your players, use Rogue and Santiago to bail them out.

Stats

INT 5 REF 11 CL 5
MA 6 BODY 10

Cybernetics

One cyberoptic with IR, Targeting scope, Karate chipped to +3, Rippers.

Skills

Combat Sense +7, Handgun +7, Brawling +5, Drive +7, Submachinegun +5, Melee +5, Athletics +6.

Possessions

Medium Armor Jacket, Light Helmet. Sternmeyer Type 35 Heavy Pistol or Minami 10 submachinegun.

AKIRA: SUPERGOON FROM HELL

Hmm. Wouldn't it be chill if Alt flubbed the play and Akira was still up and round when the players burst into Toshiro's office. Sure it would. Everyone should have a chance to battle the Hulk from Hell.

Stats

INT2 REF 12 CL 3
MA 8 BODY 12

Cybernetics

One cyberoptic with IR, Targeting scope, Body plated.

Skills

Combat Sense +9, Handgun +10, Karate +9, Submachinegun +8, Melee +8, Athletics +9.

Possessions

Medium Armor Jacket, Minami 10 submachinegun, Bad Attitude.

LASER DEFENSE SYSTEM

Powered by building current, the laser can hit any point in the room, causing 5D6 damage. It hits on a roll of 7 or higher on 1D10.

There are four lasers, one in each corner, and each has 10 SDP.

Rogue skids around the corner towards the elevator bank, moments ahead of the crowd. Rapidly, she opens each car, spraypaints the monitor lens, punches a destination, then ducks out. The last car in line, she places a shaped charge explosive on the ceiling, wired to a microtransmitter. This one she sends to the twenty-second floor; the executive office suites. Then the rampaging mob hits and carries her along in the swell.

She's on the floor and rolling, a fast dazzle bomb palmed over the top of the security desk to fry the optics of the monitor team, followed by a frag grenade a second later.

Thompson is waiting for her by the stairwell. Moments later, Johnny shows up wearing an Arasaka company jacket he's pulled off a guard's body. The name tag reads Harada.

OPTIONS

Akira turns from the security board. "It has started," he announces. "Instructions, Toshiro-sama?" Toshiro considers. It was a masterstroke for Silverhand to raise a literal army of fans against him. Toshiro is checkmated—Arasaka cannot gun down the crowd with impunity. But he does have options. He turns to Akira. "Send teams to the elevators. Guard the top and bottom of the stairwells, and kill anything in the elevator cars." He looks over at Alt's dormant form. "We have the program," he says. "If we do not have her body, there is no evidence."

Seemingly oblivious, the plugged in Alt permits herself a brief smile. A lot he knows.

Elevators chime open on floors ten, eighteen and five. The fire teams on ten and eighteen throw a hail of lead through the doors. The elevators are empty. The team on five is warned, and opens the doors with greater caution. Empty. "It's a trick!" shouts the team leader. "To the stairwell!"

On floor six, a panting Johnny and Thompson reach the stairwell landing, crack

open the firedoors and scout the hall. They can hear other doors slamming open as the fire teams converge; they bolt for the elevator bank. Prying the doors open, they can see the top of the car on floor five. They drop down to it's top. Thompson hotwires the motor, and they start up.

Rogue can hear running feet behind her. She pauses from her vantage point on floor seven and fires a quick burst down the stairwell. How much time? she thinks. She judges the breathing and the heavy booted tread, and punches six seconds on the timer, then rolls out of the seventh floor firedoor. She is halfway down the hall when the first of the charges go off, collapsing the stairwell in on itself and burying the pursuing fire teams. Jamming open the elevator doors with her gun butt, she drops down onto the rising car.

• • •

"Hold her", says Toshiro. Dimly, through the interface, Alt can feel Akira's hands pressing her into the seat. She struggles as the techs strip her plug guards off and hold her wrists. "Can the program be run?" Toshiro demands. His techs nod. Helpless in the grip of the interface, Alt can only sense Toshiro jacking himself into the cyberdeck, giving the command to RUN.

Then her mind is ripped away.

• • •

The elevator streaks upwards, the shaft echoing to either side. They can hear explosions; the sound of running feet, the hammer of machinegun fire. They pass the burned out husks of the cars on floors ten and eighteen. At the twentieth floor, the elevator starts to slow. Just above them, they can see the bottom of the express elevator on the twenty second.

She is halfway down the hall when the first of the charges go off, collapsing the stairwell in on itself and burying the pursuing fire teams.

"Duck and cover!" yells Rogue. She taps the transmitter button on her collar and the world blows up.

ANGEL HEAVEN

She floats naked in a sea of stars. Around her swirls the matrix of Soukkiller, towering into measureless space. Alt reaches out with her enhanced mentality, shaping and forming. A brief flare of thought, and Soukkiller sucks away the minds of her three guardian techs, letting their bodies drop.

From the mind of the head techie, she pulls out the access codes to the mainframe's inner levels. She strips the memory of data, downloading it to her hidden files throughout the Net. Twenty million dollars vanishes from Accounting, to reappear in a subaccount under her name. Pulling Toshiro's signature from his checking account file, she signs his name with a flourish.

Using the access codes, she activates the room monitor. She can see the three techs slumped senseless in their chairs; her own unconscious body limply sprawled across the central console. Akira moves towards it. Alt triggers the room lasers and cuts him in two; his body hits the floor with a steaming thud.

Toshiro's eyes widen in shock, then narrow as he realizes what has happened. "Congratulations, Ms. Cunningham," he says with mock formality. "It seems you have found a way to escape your demise."

"You zaibatsu bastard," she says through the interface, a tiny voice in his ear. "You're going to sit right here with your hands on the table, where I can watch them. You move, and you're laser meat." She tracks the defense system onto him, locking it to fire at the slightest position change. Then she turns back into the Soukkiller construct, wrapping it's power around her, gathering herself to transfer back into her body.

The room staggers; lurches, as five pounds of plastique explosive slams through the ceiling of the elevator, creating an instant fireball. The lasers go wild, spilling a maze of ruby light in every direction. Toshiro throws himself flat, toppling the cyberdeck and breaking Alt's connections. She flails wildly

with the Construct—too little, too late.

Three figures burst into the room, smartguns laying down a pattern of fire though the maelstrom. IR suppressed, enhanced vision on, Johnny spots Alt's still form slumped over a contour couch. He bend down her, taking her in his arms, trembling. Across the room, Rogue looks away.

Silverhand raises the big black gun. A red pinpoint centers on Toshiro's forehead. "Bang." says Johnny. The Hand convulses. "Bang" says the gun.

"Well, well, well," says Thompson, striding across the wrecked room towards the corporate head. "What do we have here? Looks like kidnapping and maybe murder. They're going to put you away for a long, long time, Toshiro-chan." His green cyberoptic winks bright as he transmits live and direct to his news net; his head swivels right to left with practiced ease as he subvocalizes the opening to his story; the story he will use to break Arasaka in Night City.

Johnny stares a long time at Alt's almost lifeless body. There is a feeble pulse. But Alt—Alt is gone; lost in the machine; trapped behind crystal. Lost forever. Gone.

He stands away from the couch. "Cut transmission," he says to Thompson. The green cyberoptic goes dark. Silverhand's own eyes are featureless white marbles. The Hand convulses in fury by his side, locking onto the H&K in it's lowslung hip rig. The metal fingers lock to the butt, scrabble-clicking along the parkerized grip.

He just doesn't care anymore. He's dead inside. To hell with it.

Silverhand raises the big black gun. A red pinpoint centers on Toshiro's forehead. "Bang." says Johnny. The Hand convulses.

"Bang" says the gun.

Silverhand turns to gather up her still warm body in his arms. Behind the wall of monitors, a disembodied Alt screams to him.

But he can't hear her as he walks away. ■

"Of course I work for the Corporations. You think I'm crazy?

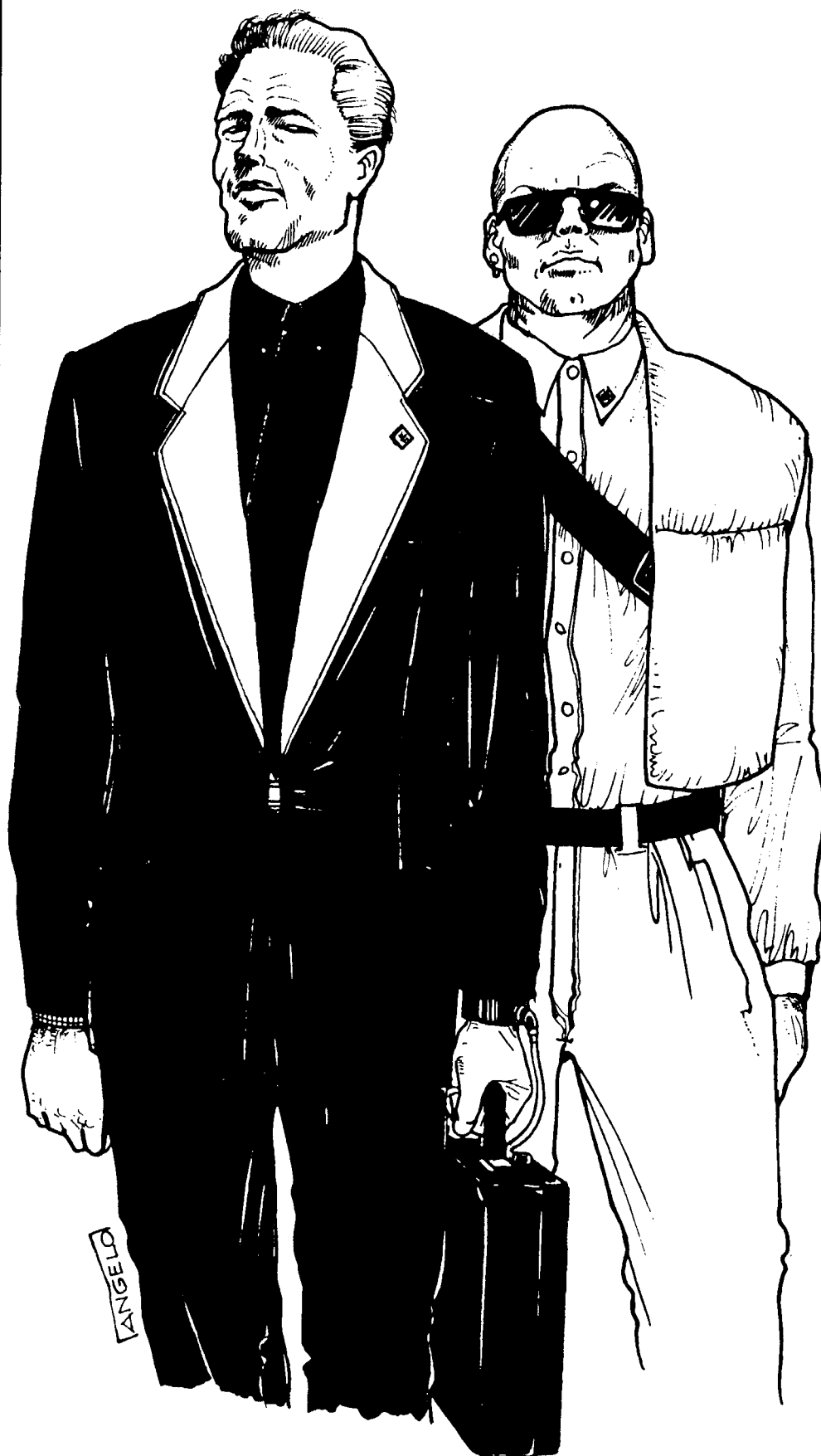
Look, you have to be realistic. Appraise your options. There's nothing but grunt jobs on the Street.

Most of the good jobs out there are managerial; you're bossing a bunch of AIs and robots. To score that kind of work, you need an MBA minimum these days.

"So once you've put in six, seven years, you want to maximize that investment. And the Corporation makes that possible. Health care when everyone else is festering on the streetcorner because doctors cost 200 eb an hour. Company sponsored housing, because the average two bedroom home comes in at 500,000.eb. Perks, like an office, a secretary, and a bodyguard.

"So of course I'm a Corporate Man. Only an idiot wouldn't be."

—Dave Whindam



SECTION

14

MEGACORPS
2020

Corporate Life

It's Big Business As Usual in the 2000's

The modern corporations of 2020 are much like the corporations of the late 20th century, only much larger and more fully autonomous. They are very nearly nations in themselves, with their own laws, cities, factories and armies. Most corporations in 2020 are multinational; i.e., they have branches and operations all over the world. These branches may be as small as a research facility or sales office, or as large as a major manufacturing facility and security center.

There are two types of corporations: public and privately held. A public corporation can and does sell stock to the public. The stock is for sale in any of the offices of the World Stock Exchange, and anyone with enough money can buy it. Privately held corporations are more like family businesses. All stock (and thus all power) is concentrated in the hands of a very few—usually partners, relatives, or one extremely powerful individual (Howard Hughes would be a good example).

Most corporations are manufacturers—they produce some kind of commodity for sale on the open market. Oil, steel, automobiles, aircraft, weapons, computers, cybernetics, biotechnologies; these are only a few of the literally millions of corporate operations. Many corporations have several commodities on the market—they may control chemical plants in Europe, computer factories in Japan, and steelmaking operations in the United States.

Mediacorporations

One type of corporation that deserves special attention is the mediacorp. These huge conglomerates grew out of a trend in the late 1980's, in which certain firms bought up TV networks, film companies, record companies, radio stations, and book, magazine, and even comic publishers; effectively centralizing the media under the control of a very few people.

Entertainment has become generic and bland. Print material has a "sameness" as a hundred magazines are produced by the same company. Dissenting opinions and independent productions are usually buried under an avalanche of media hype, or worse, co-opted or destroyed by the vicious competitive practices of the major mediacorps. Still worse is the effect on news and information. Political candidates have realized that the right connections to the right mediacorp exec can win elections—only a short step to where the media corporations actually select, package and sell their own candidates. While no major government is yet directly controlled by a mediacorporation, most socioanalysts suspect that it is only a matter of time.

Agricorps

The Age of the Family Farm came to an end somewhere in the 1990s. The United States has always been the world's foremost producer of raw food stock. Coupled with the increasing need for grain and bulk crops to create alcohol fuels and organic plastics, agribusiness became one of the most powerful forces of the post-crash U.S.

"Most people who don't know anything think being a Corporate is a sellout; you'd lick the bottoms of Ulf Grünwald's shoes for a safe desk and a computer terminal. But you can actually do some good in the Corporate arena, because working for a Corporation gives you a lot of power."

"Not all Corps are bad guys. Take my bunch. Last year, we bought up 23,000 acres of Amazon rainforest and set it aside as a bio-preserve. Some people say we did it for selfish reasons; we make biotech animals, and buying up that environment just puts a little more Nature in our pockets."

"But I see it another way. That's 23,000 acres that won't be cut down to make furniture. That's a dozen endangered species that will exist somewhere else besides a gene bank..."

*—Lyle Harrison
Staff Biologist,
Biosystems LTD.*

Agricorporations now control (directly or indirectly) nearly 65% of all of the farmland in the United States, feeding roughly a third of the world's population and supplying organic fuels and plastics to nearly two thirds. As the technological world underwent crash conversion from its dwindling petroleum reserves over to advanced forms of methanol, ethanol and meta-alcohol, many of the leading oil producers bought up agricultural lands and shifted their refineries to organic fuel production. As a result, a list of most major agricorps reads like a Who's Who of energy corporations.

Corporate Powerbrokering

The modern corporation is usually organized as a vast hierarchy, with a President and Board of Directors at the top, and a huge sea of workers at the bottom. In the middle of this, one finds the realm of the corporate executive, a struggling middle class overachiever, usually with the singleminded goal of grabbing as much power and privilege as possible. The average corporate begins as a junior executive, "bossing" a particular project or group of people. At the next level, he becomes a Manager, controlling a specific department or production area. The major infighting begins here—only very successful Managers get elevated to the position of Assistant Vice President, where they control entire factories or other operations. They are, in turn, bossed by Vice Presidents, who control entire divisions of the company. Near the top is the Executive Vice President, who effectively runs the corporation. His boss is the President, who answers only to the Board of Directors (major stockholders) and the Chairman of the Board.

Theoretically, corporate advancement is based on merit. In reality, the corporate world is rife with nepotism, deal making, brown nosing, cheating, lying and credit stealing. Extortion, blackmail and frameups are common.

One of the most disturbing factors in this web of corporate powerbrokering is the role of organized crime. Realizing

in the early '90s that the new megacorps represented an unprecedented new field of opportunity, the powerful families of the Mafia and other crime groups began to offer their services as bodyguards, hitmen, and general corporate enforcers. This pattern had previously been established among the zaibatsu (corporate families) of Japan, who routinely hired both ninja (assassin) and yakuza (gangster) clans for their covert operations. In some cases, the retainers remain faithful—at least to the people who pay the most. In other more unfortunate cases, the hired guns have taken direct control of the corporations themselves, leading to a new age of intercorporate infighting unchecked by even a sham of legality.

Employment Contracts

In the savage world of Big Business, it's not unusual for an executive to jump from firm to firm, looking for a big success. To prevent this, most Corporations require their employees to sign Employment Contracts, specifying how long they must work for the firm until they can quit. Contracts may run from a year for a low-level executive, to an entire lifetime for a key researcher or company president.

The penalties for breaking Employment contracts are extremely severe; ranging from garnishment of wages, lawsuits, and loss of licenses (in the case of lawyers or physicians). Corporations have also been known to use sabotage software and deadly booby traps to ensure loyalty. Blackmail is common. Assassination and kidnapping are expected.

This makes Corporate "headhunting" (hiring away another company's staff for use by your own company) a deadly game of cat and mouse. Most Corporations have their own "extraction teams" of Solos, who, like the KGB or CIA, arrange "defections" of key personnel from one side to the other. Headhunting can be especially lethal, as most corporations will use any and

all means to stop a rival extraction team.

Corporations & Governments

Since the Crash of '96, the governments of the world have been in the uncomfortable position of having to let the multinational corporations do pretty much as they please. Paying lip service to pollution control, product safety and minimum wage rules, the modern multinational usually strikes a bargain with the local government. Sometimes this may be as simple as a bribe to the right places, or military support for the local dictator. In the more sophisticated United States, corporations tread lightly, going out of their way to hide their more illegal operations, and making sure to toe the line in their more visible ones. On the local level it's often a case of trading power, influence or money with the right leaders; a judge or police chief here, a senator or congressman there.

One major exception to corporate domination is the Soviet Union. Although interested in acquiring the technologies of the West, the Soviets have successfully kept most corporations from gaining any political foothold within its borders.

Most corporate offices now hold a status roughly equivalent to a national embassy, with employees carrying corporate-issued international passports and identification cards (better, by far, than almost anything national governments can produce). Since the unfortunate *Yasubisu Affair* of 1997 (in which guards of Tokyo-based Arasaka Corp killed 24 French policemen who attempted to storm Arasaka's Paris offices to arrest an executive charged with rape), most corporate foreign branches maintain a policy of shipping criminal employees back to the company's home office. Company negotiators then arrange

to extradite the felon back to the nation where the crime took place.

The World Stock Exchange

The modern corporation rests on its stock. Stock is essentially a “share” in the company’s assets, which can be traded and sold much like property cards in Monopoly. Corporations sell stock to outsiders in exchange for hard cash, which the corporation can then use to finance its activities. As a stockholder, you are gambling that the stock you hold (which is a percentage of the total value of the company) will increase in value as the company’s assets increase in value. For example, if in 1975, Cyber Computer was worth a grand total of \$100.00, and you owned 20% of this, your stock would be worth \$20.00. Eight years later, when Cyber is worth two million dollars, that same 20% is now worth \$400,000.00! On the other hand, if Cyber goes bust, that stock is worth nothing.

The more stock you have, the more control you have over the assets and activities of the corporation. One reason for this is that each share you hold is equal to a vote concerning what is done with the company. As a general rule, if you own more than 50 percent of the stock of a corporation, you have the majority vote. This vote can be used to fire or choose the leadership of the corporation, direct corporate decisions, and even force the corporation to merge with another company.

The basic form of corporate stock holding is little changed from the early stock exchanges (places where people go to buy, sell or trade stock in companies) of the 20th century. What has changed is the scale of operations. The stock exchanges of London, Tokyo, New York and other major cities were merged into a gigantic World Stock Exchange late in the 1990’s. A generic exchange rate (known as the Eurodollar) had been

established, and a system of trading imposed over the various subexchanges worldwide.

While there are stockbrokerages all over the world, the major Exchange offices are located in London, Paris, Zurich, Tokyo, New York, Cairo, Rome and San Francisco. However, with the creation of the Net—the vast web of communications that blankets the planet—the ability to buy, sell and trade shares has been extended to almost anyone. Investors can now use their phone nets to contact their brokers at any time or from any place, even the remotest jungles. Never before has the business of making millions on the “market” been so universal. And never before has the Market been balanced on such a razor’s edge between incredible wealth and worldwide economic disaster.

Corporate Espionage & Covert Activity

In the 2000’s, almost every corporation employs at least one force of highly trained covert operatives, specializing in espionage, counter-espionage, sabotage, and counter-terrorism. In extreme cases, measures such as assassination and terrorism are not unknown, whether against other corporations or within the corporate structure itself.

This is not an entirely new phenomenon. For many years, the powerful Japanese industrial combines, or *zaibatsu*, were known to secretly employ ninja clans in many of their covert operations. These connections stretched back into the distant past, when many of the same clans served the feudal ancestors of the *zaibatsu* rulers. Less covert operations requiring muscle and a lack of subtlety were often delegated to various Japanese gangster mobs, many of whom had full or partial interests in the corporations themselves. As Western corporations

began to adopt various methods of Japanese management and production, it was a simple step for these companies to adopt or create their own “ninja” forces. This historical reference may be one reason why hired corporate killers and spies are known on the street by colorful terms such as *ninja*, *samurai*, *ronin* and *yakuza*.

A corporate covert operations arm usually is made up of weapons specialists, computer technicians, and various “hired guns”. Almost all of these covert forces are cyberenhanced with the best technology available. Covert action arms frequently search the deadzones and arcologies for promising young criminals to recruit, promising them high pay, the best enhancements, and a life of glamor and adventure.

Corporate Wars

While most aspects of corporate competition remain on the economic level, there are instances where it moves into the arena of actual warfare. While these are not declared wars, per-se, they have all the aspects of the real thing, as missiles, armored vehicles, jet aircraft and cyberenhanced ground troops are brought into play.

By its very nature, a corporate war must be covert—very few nations are willing to allow two companies to “duke it out” on their soil. Early on, most corporations hired actual terrorist groups to strike at enemy targets. As these groups became more undependable, the companies began to actually create battle forces disguised to resemble terrorists. Many terrorist groups such as the infamous *Red Flag Army* and the *New Aryan Sons* are actually fully equipped corporate strike forces, whose seemingly random attacks on rival offices and strongholds are part of larger covert warfare actions.

A corporate war never lasts longer than necessary—if combat activity becomes noticeable, there is too great a chance of government intervention. While no corporate army is yet powerful enough

to challenge a major government directly, there are already reports of smaller nations who have capitulated to the power of the business armies.

The Corporate City

In the 1960's thru '70s, social unrest and upheaval tore through the central cities of America, leaving burned out tenements, deserted factories, and dying businesses in it's wake. Most major corporations soon moved their operations to safer suburban business parks and malls.

But as real estate prices began to rise, and the suburbs became more crowded, the major companies began to reconsider their strategies. By the middle 1980's, corporations working with city governments began to rehabilitate the inner city. The corporations provided the money for new buildings, shopping malls and model community areas, while the government provided tax incentives, inexpensive land, and police protection. By 1989, many inner city areas across the U.S. including New York, San Francisco, Baltimore and Boston had undergone this "gentrification" process.

The human cost of this restructuring was the displacement of the "undesirables" of the urban dead zone. Poor, drug dealers, pimps, gangs and street people were all pushed out from the city center, creating a region bounded on one side by affluent suburbs and on the other by the now showcase central city. This "doughnut" effect had a further impact on the community—by shoving the dead zone inhabitants between the two areas, crime rates on both sides of the line began to skyrocket. Street gangs routinely shuttled between the middle class suburbs and the model inner city to prey on new victims.

By the mid 80's, corporations routinely hired guard patrols to supplement already overloaded city police forces.

These corporate police were well paid and had access to the best equipment available. As police services began to collapse throughout the U.S., many cities took to hiring corporate forces outright, deputizing them and turning city law enforcement over to them.

The corporations were equal to the task. Ruthlessly, they equipped their teams with the best weapons and armor. When an arrest was made, they made the best use of their considerable legal talent and influence to ensure the severest penalties. When an arrest wasn't possible, they often resorted to the harshest of policies. Entire gangs would be decimated in a single night by heavy weapons teams and armored vehicles. The bodies would summarily end up in the landfill, and the legal staff would quietly arrange to cover the incident over.

In the 2000's, the corporations usually control both the inner city and a large portion of the company owned suburban developments outside of the city. To facilitate their commuters, many of the megacorps have installed light rail and underground systems between the showcase inner city and the well-protected suburbs. Patrolled by corporate guards, monitored by cameras and the most sophisticated sensors, these railways are always clean, quiet and ominously crime free.

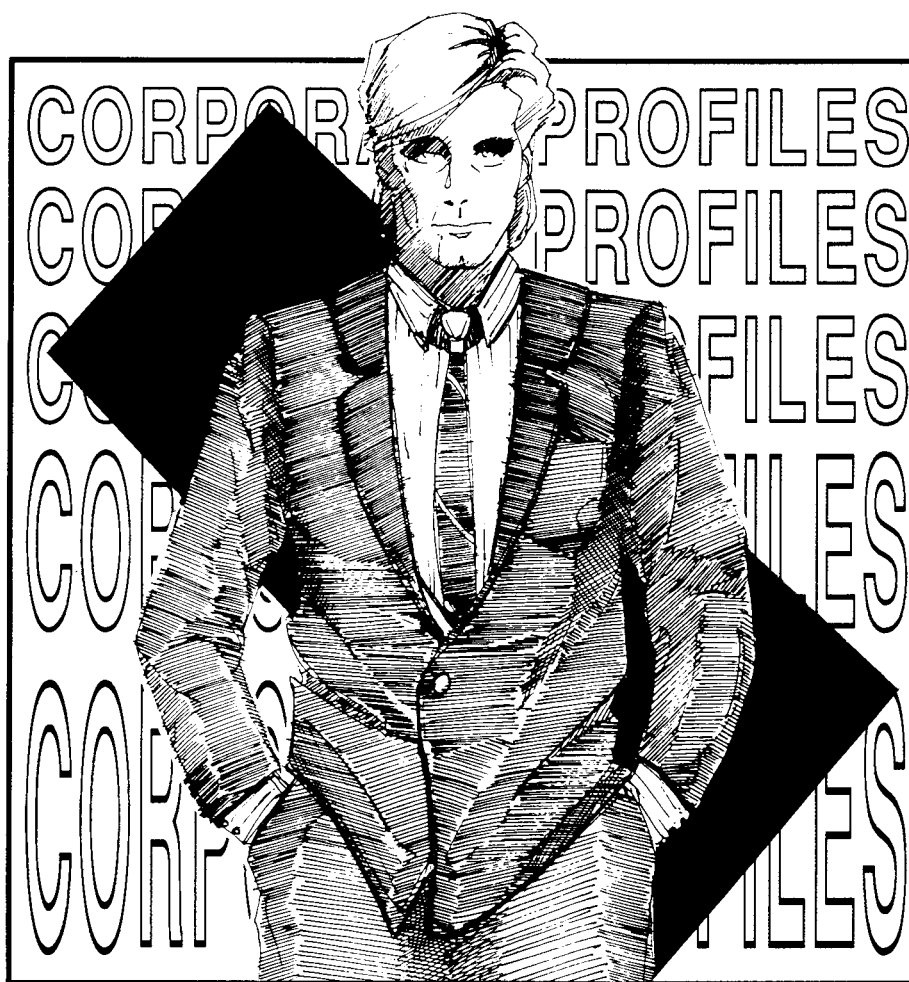
Corporate Suburbia

By 1990, a two bedroom house cost a median \$200,000.00; more than most families could hope to raise. As the corporations fought for skilled employees, they realized that an affordable home could easily become one of the many fringe benefits to offer a prospective worker. Soon, in the U.S. and abroad, corporations began



building or buying large tracts of housing, which were then offered at drastically reduced prices to company members.

A further stage of development was reached in 1995, when, in the historic *Tennicorp vs Davis* decision, the Supreme Court ruled that while a corporation could not restrict housing sales on the basis of race, creed or color, it did have the right to offer housing to its employees on a preferential basis. As a result, most areas of corporate suburbia are routinely comprised of upper middle-class execs and their families. While made up of widely varying races, religions and nationalities, all corporate communities share a common origin—the Company.



Corporate Profiles

The following report contains essential information and breakdowns on some of the 21st century's most prominent and powerful corporations. These profiles are intended to be used by the Referee as guidelines, not as inflexible parameters.

Head Office is the location of the firm's board of directors, usually, but not always, the largest and most important executive facility the corporation has. Offices are other manufacturing or executive sites owned by the corporation. Listed sites are major offices. A corporation may have small bureaus worldwide.

Stock is the total number of shares in existence for that corporation. Listed in

each profile is the name and location of residence of that company's major shareholder. This is the single person who wields the true power behind the company. Any person or organization (such as the board of directors) which holds over 50% of the total stock wields ultimate control over the corporation. Open Shares are the shares currently up for sale on the World Stock Exchange. Usually in the neighborhood of ten percent.

Troops represent the combined number of combat soldiers available to the corporation. Usually, troops are spread among the offices of the corporation, with heavier numbers stationed at potential trouble sites or high security compounds. Covert Operatives are

industrial and political espionage agents and covert combat Operatives. Among other things, troops and covert operatives are used in the dangerous field of corporate extractions, removing valuable personnel from one corporation to another, either by defection or force.

Equipment and resources are the vehicles, technology and weapons owned by the corporation, as well as equipment it can commandeer or procure from other sources, such as governments, in an emergency. Most corporations own private helicopters and jets which can be retrofitted for rapid deployment and combat use, as well as dedicated military vehicles...commonly the AV-4 urban assault vehicle and the Osprey II V-TOL aircraft. The Osprey II is also used as a corporate transport in high-security situations. Large companies maintain a private airlift capability, usually using the Boeing C-25 heavy cargo aircraft. The C-25 can haul six AV-4s, two dismantled Osprey IIs, three tanks, or five hundred troops depending on how it is fitted. Combination loads are also possible due to the aircraft's modular interior design. It can be assumed that such things as armored limosines and high-tech site security are standard.

Some corporations have small orbital workstations for specialized zero-g production and research. These workstations consist of a number of pressurized "shacks" with no gravity of their own. The shacks are anchored together by a flexible structural framework that also supports power and life-support pods, and are normally staffed by a few dozen people and a small contingent of space troops. These stations also maintain weapons systems to repel attack from rival corporations if necessary. Workstations each have a few small pressurized and unpressurized service and transport vehicles. All corporations, with the exception of the Orbital Air Corporation rely on government lifting vehicles or Orbital Air to shuttle products and personnel to and from orbit.



EUROBUSINESS MACHINES CORPORATION

Multi-role computer and electronics manufacturer.

- **Headquarters:** Hamburg.
 - **Regional Offices:** W. Berlin, Rome, Madrid, Paris, Stockholm, Geneva, Oslo, Helsinki, London, Tokyo, Cairo, Jerusalem, Los Angeles, San Francisco, Washington, Chicago, Dallas, New York, Hong Kong.
 - **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Dr. Rudolf Muller, Bremen, Germany, holding 20.8% of total shares.
 - **Employees:**
- | Worldwide | Troops | Covert |
|-----------|--------|--------|
| 1,000,000 | 20,000 | 2000 |

Background: In the late 1990's, EBM, already the largest computer and high-tech manufacturer in the world, and one of the most significant corporations in existence, pulled off the greatest free-market hostile takeover in history. Led by master corporate raider Dr. Kurt Muller, this maneuver caused the merger of EBM with many other prominent computer companies around the world, consolidating EBM's already fearsome market power. Currently, Muller, and his two partners in the triumvirate, Ulf Grunwalder of Munich and Sir Nathaniel Poole of London, comprise the majority vote of EBM, holding 52.1% between the three of them. Their long-term goal is to consolidate as much of the world's high-tech manufacturing as possible under their label by any means.

Equipment and Resources: Dispersed among the EBM offices as dictated by need are forty-six AV-4s, twenty Osprey II V-TOL attack craft, twenty corporate jets for the use of the executive board and five heavy cargo planes. In addition, each office has two helicopters and a fully staffed clinic and infirmary. EBM's power and stature gives it access to the highest levels of military technology. EBM also has a top secret underground medical and research/training facility hidden in the Alps. EBM maintains a small orbital research facility with about thirty researchers and ten soldiers.

ZETATECH

Wetware and computer hardware and software design.

- **Headquarters:** Cupertino, California. (Silicon Valley).
 - **Regional Offices:** San Francisco, San Jose.
 - **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Bob Rosemont, New York, holding 58.8% of total shares.
 - **Employees:**
- | Worldwide | Troops | Covert |
|-----------|--------|--------|
| 12,000 | 150 | 12 |

Background: Zetatech is a typical up-and-coming high-tech company doing its best to grow and diversify. It has carved itself a small niche in the industry through the traditional methods: quality products, industrial espionage, and strategically applied violence. Having made it over the first hurdle, Zetatech is attempting to build a heavy name for itself by expanding overseas, the assured way toward success, and a high inflow of stable Eurodollars. This means encroaching on markets occupied by other companies, most of which are not inclined to share their profits. Zetatech's position as an established, growing, but small and relatively weak company make it a prime target for hostile takeover, and they must be continually on guard.

Equipment and Resources: Three AV-4 assault vehicles, three helicopters, one private jet based out of San Francisco International Airport. Each office has an emergency first aid infirmary, but only the San Francisco office has a surgery capable trauma center. The military hardware available to Zetatech is only of moderate power. High-tech personal arms, armor and vehicular weapons systems are readily available, but only limited amounts of heavier weapons are available, and usually they can not be obtained on short notice. Zetatech has no airlift capability of its own, but could arrange access to heavy lifting aircraft given enough time.

network news 54

Nationwide broadcasting service.

- **Headquarters:** New York.
 - **Regional offices:** Atlanta, Chicago, New Orleans, Dallas, Indianapolis, Denver, Arizona, Portland, Seattle, Los Angeles, San Francisco, Detroit, Washington, with subsidiary stations in most major cities.
 - **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Edwin R. Dreyer Foundation, under control of Michelle Dreyer. Located at Fifty Pines Ranch, near Santa Fe, New Mexico. The estate controls 27.9% of all shares.
 - **Employees:**
- | Worldwide | Troops | Covert |
|-----------|--------|--------|
| 78,000 | 5,000 | 750 |

Background: Network News 54 is a wavelength monopolizer, operating on the same frequency across the country. Accordingly, no matter where you go in the country, Network News 54 is on Channel 54. Despite its name, News 54 offers many diversions in addition to news. Every regional office offers a slightly different schedule to its district, with syndicated series, non prime-time movies, independent local news programs. Certain elements of the broadcasting are universal nationwide, such as prime-time series and bi-hourly national and world news shows.

Equipment and Resources: Network News 54 owns 42 AV-4s, ostensibly used as mobile news gathering and broadcasting facilities. These vehicles also retain much of their combat function. News 54 also owns 30 helicopters for weather and traffic reporting at each of the network offices, as well as for shuttling company executives, and ten corporate jets and five Osprey II aircraft. The network has standard personal equipment for its troops, but little access to military weapons of a non man-portable nature, with the exception of a few vehicles. News 54 has no airlift capability of its own.

Orbital Air



Cargo and passenger transport to Earth orbit, and maintenance of commercial orbital facilities.

- **Headquarters:** Nairobi, Kenya.
 - **Regional Offices:** Anchorage, Vancouver, Montreal, New York, Washington, Miami, Houston, St. Louis, Chicago, Denver, Portland, San Francisco, Los Angeles, Mexico City, Rio De Janiero, London, Paris, Madrid, Cairo, Sydney, Singapore, Tokyo, Honolulu and the Johnson Orbital Facility in low Earth orbit.
 - **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Antoine DuBois, Paris, holding 15.2% of total shares.
 - **Employees:**
- | Worldwide | Troops | Covert |
|-----------|--------|--------|
| 104,000 | 10,043 | 700 |

Background: Orbital Air holds a key position in the twenty-first century; with their large fleet of French-made Hermes space-planes they monopolize all orbital lifting capability, with the exception of a few governments, none of which offers comparable service. Many corporations rely on Orbital Air for transport of cargo out of the gravity well. The Euro-Space Agency's Crystal Tower L-5 colony, a massive orbital hotel complex for the ultra-rich, would be out of business without them. With all commercial space bound cargo dependent upon them, Orbital Air is in a lucrative position that it would like very much to maintain. A large part of OA's budget and covert resources is put to use ensuring that they remain the leader in orbital technology, and that the competition does not make it off the ground, literally or figuratively. Currently, their eye is on China, which is improving its commercial lift capability rapidly. Also, Euro-flight Corporation is expanding its operations, and expecting to bring orbital services on line soon. This has OA worried about its monopoly. The Johnson Orbital Facility is a transfer station for passengers bound for the Crystal Tower, where they switch from the space-planes to space transport shuttles

assembled at the OA orbital workstations, or purchased from the Euro-Space Agency.

Equipment and Resources: 35 orbit capable Hermes Scramjet space-planes, 35 corporate jets, two helicopters per office, 70 AV-4 urban assault vehicles, 15 Boeing C-25 heavy cargo jets, and 30 Osprey II V-TOL aircraft. All major offices have surgery capable infirmaries. Orbital Air is well equiped, and has access to almost all levels of military equipment. It is primarily interested in space defense and air-superiority weaponry to protect its orbital and airborne resources. In addition to the Johnson Facility, Orbital Air maintains two small maintenance and research workstations, and has a small fleet of orbital vehicles to transport crews between the facilities.



Microtech

Ultra-sophisticated mainframes and workstations.

- **Headquarters:** Dallas, Texas.
 - **Regional Offices:** Sunnyvale, California, Miami, London, Tokyo.
 - **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Stephen Lew and family, San Francisco, holding 55.5% of total shares.
 - **Employees:**
- | Worldwide | Troops | Covert |
|-----------|--------|--------|
| 52,340 | 1,000 | 52 |

Background: Microtech does one thing, and they do it well: build full-size computers. They concentrate all of their efforts into improving their mainframe computer systems, without dabbling in cybernetic computers or mini-computers. Indeed, they take pride in the fact that their mainframes and workstations are used by other companies to design those types of systems. They are to the 2000's what Cray was to the 1980's and '90's, but on a larger scale. Microtech is the industry standard. Defense agencies around the world rely on Microtech mainframes, and the Euro-Space Agency has several. With its hold on the specialized mainframe industry, Mi-

crotech is worried not so much about acquiring proprietary data through espionage as protecting itself against such theft. This is where most of its covert and military resources go, as well as a sizable amount of its own computer power. Microtech must be vigilant for external threat as well, however, as there are several larger corporations who would like to acquire Microtech, or see it eliminated in order to further the success of their own products. Accordingly, Microtech is attempting to beef up both its financial and military security.

Equipment and Resources: Six AV-4 assault vehicles, ten helicopters, two Osprey IIs and three corporate jets are dispersed among the offices. Microtech has access to sophisticated military hardware on a fairly small scale, with good amounts of personal weaponry and armor, including man-portable heavy weapons. It has no heavy, mobile armored vehicles (such as tanks), and only limited access to other vehicularly based heavy weapons. With sufficient time, however, Microtech can usually acquire whatever equipment it needs. Only the Dallas office has a surgery-capable medical center, but all of the other offices have well staffed infirmaries capable of dealing with most non intensive care needs, including trauma and illness. Microtech has no orbital platform of its own, but it occasionally ships experiments up by Hermes space-plane if zero gravity is required.

Biotechnica

Genetic engineering, microbiological and biochemical research.

- **Headquarters:** Rome.
- **Regional Offices:** London, Bonn, Paris, and La Jolla California.
- **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Nicolo Loggaglia, Monte Carlo, Monaco, holding 13.8% of total shares.

• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
36,256	1,833	124

Background: When the fuel crisis really began to affect the industrialized community in the late 1990s, Biotechnica, then a small firm with only one office, came up with the answer: CHOOH2™ (pronounced 'chew two'). CHOOH2™ (not its actual chemical formula) is a complex grain alcohol produced by genetically engineered yeasts and wheat strains created by Biotechnica. The potential of CHOOH2™ was realized almost immediately after it was introduced, and within a few years all fuel burning vehicles and power plants had converted to the new fuel. Although Biotechnica held worldwide patents, it lacked the production facilities to meet worldwide demand, forcing it to license production to several large agribusinesses and petro-corporations. These deals made Biotechnica an extremely wealthy, but still not particularly large, company. It is currently expanding, and working on its next big biotechnical breakthrough.

Equipment and Resources: Biotechnica has ten AV-4 assault vehicles, five corporate jets, three Osprey II aircraft and one Boeing C-25 heavy cargo jet, moved as needed among its offices. In addition, each office maintains two helicopters and a surgery capable infirmary. Due to the worldwide importance of its developments, Biotechnica has a fair amount of power in the political community, and it can usually obtain whatever military equipment it needs, although some items may take more time to procure than others. Biotechnica has one orbital research work-station.

INFOCOMP

Corporate think-tank and information brokers.

- **Headquarters:** Los Angeles.
- **Regional Offices:** San Francisco, New York, Washington, Chicago, Denver, Vancouver, London, Honolulu.
- **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Robert D. (Bob) Alvarez, Kapaa, Kauai holding 19.2% of total shares.

• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
9,352	400	34

Background: Infocomp provides scientific, technical and personal data pertaining to any subject to anyone who can afford to pay for it. The ultimate detectives, they pride themselves on their elite scientific and research staff's ability to unearth, cogitate, formulate and theorize. For the right price, clients can access Infocomp's huge library of existing information, or have them provide information pertaining to a subject not yet explored. Watch out—the tougher the problem, the higher the bill. . . .

Equipment and Resources: Each office has a surgery capable infirmary, an Osprey II aircraft, a private jet, two helicopters, two AV-4 urban assault vehicles, several Microtech Corp. advanced mainframes and an extensive library and information gathering network.

MERRILL, ASUKAGA & FINCH

Exclusive investment and financial counseling firm.

- **Headquarters:** New York.
- **Regional Offices:** San Francisco, Los Angeles, Chicago, Hong Kong, Tokyo, London, Paris, Munich, Rome.
- **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Howard Merrill, New York, holding 22.0% of total shares.

• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
21,926	100	10

Background: If you have money, and you want more, or you just want it safe, Merrill, Asukaga, and Finch are the people to talk to. They are without a doubt the top people in investments of all kinds, from stock to real estate to frog-farming futures. However, if you don't have a good deal of money in the first place, they aren't interested—the commission on a \$1000 investment isn't worth their rather expensive time. MA & F's high caliber of service has attracted many of the richest and most powerful people in the world. If, for some reason, they were to go bankrupt, some of the greatest powers in the world, both legal and illegal, would be overturned.

Equipment and Resources: Dispersed as needed among the offices are 15 AV-4 assault vehicles, eight corporate jets, and two Osprey II aircraft. Each office also has two helicopters and a non-surgical infirmary. Merrill Asukaga & Finch controls the finances of many powerful people, and even some small nations. Accordingly, they can command a great deal at short notice, including political favors and powerful military equipment.

WNS

World News Service™

Worldwide news service.

- **Headquarters:** London.
- **Regional Offices:** Anchorage, Seattle, Ottawa, New York, Washington, Miami, Dallas, St. Louis, Chicago, Denver, Portland, San Francisco, Los Angeles, Phoenix, Mexico City, Caracas, Rio De Janeiro, Oslo, Stockholm, Helsinki, London, Berlin, Jerusalem, Cairo, Tokyo, Honolulu, Tangier, Beijing, Shanghai, Crystal Tower.

• **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Mahmet Al Hamedi, Riyadh, holding 31.6% of total shares.

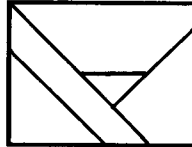
• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
215,000	7,005	644

Background: WNS keeps tabs on the world, by any means possible. Newspapers and news stations around the world pay large amounts of money to receive WNS stories via the WorldSat Network. WNS has more offices than most corporations, but most of these offices are fairly small and limited in function, intended to serve only as bases of operations for the Operatives and reporters working in an area. WNS has at least a small office in almost every major city in the world, but these are sometimes no more than rooms with a few provisions, one resident agent and a Telecom-Terminal linked to the nearest regional office. Few competitors can match WNS' information gathering capabilities, and WNS ensures that it remains at the forefront, not only through legitimate means, but also through spying, espionage, sabotage and illegal snooping of all sorts. WNS does not run any stations of its own, choosing instead to broker its information to the highest bidder. There is no shortage of buyers, as ratings-hungry broadcasters will fork over millions for exclusive rights to an especially juicy story and the included multi-media presentation package containing WNS' videos, write-ups and commentaries.

Equipment and Resources: Dispersed among the regional offices as needed are

65 AV-4 urban assault vehicles, twenty-five Osprey II aircraft, twenty-five corporate jets, and five Boeing C-25 heavy cargo aircraft. Each regional office has two helicopters and an infirmary. Only the London, Los Angeles, New York, Paris, Tokyo and Seoul offices have surgical capability. WNS has access to moderate levels of military technology, including personal armor and weapons, light vehicles and aircraft.



PETROCHEM

Petrochemical products and agribusiness. Worlds' largest CHOOH² producer.

• **Headquarters:** Dallas, Texas.

• **Regional Offices:** New York, Washington, Miami, Chicago, San Francisco, Tokyo, London, Hamburg, Hong Kong, Paris, Rome. Oil fields in Canada, Texas, Alaska, California and Antarctica. Agricultural areas in California and the Midwest and Southeast.

• **Name and Location of major shareholder:** Ellen Trieste, Crystal Tower orbital facility, holding 23.7% of total shares.

• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
338,000	30,000	2,500

Background: Petrochem Industries keeps the world running, literally. They are the world's largest producer of CHOOH₂, and control millions of acres of arable land across the United States. This land is used to grow the genetically altered wheat that is used to make CHOOH₂. (Surplus grain is shipped across the world as food.) Petrochem is also one of the largest remaining oil producers. With the oil supply dwindling, all remaining fossil fuels are used to make plastics and other synthetics. Petrochem has more fertile oilfields than any other company. All of these assets are huge, and accordingly hard to protect from other companies that would like to usurp Petrochem's wealth. As a result, Petrochem invests huge amounts

of money in protecting itself, maintaining an armed force worthy of a small country. Currently, all of the major petrochemical corporations are in a research race to come up with a viable artificial plastic base to entirely replace petroleum products. Consequently, industrial espionage is rife in the industry.

Equipment and Resources: Petrochem has vast interests to protect, and is thus fiercely armed. Dispersed among their major offices, oil fields and agricultural areas are 150 AV-4s, forty Osprey II aircraft, ten Boeing C-25 heavy cargo jets and fifteen corporate jets. Each office has three helicopters and a surgery capable infirmary. Petrochem has considerable access to the highest levels of military technology, due to their national and worldwide importance. They also have a large orbital research facility that is well protected, physically and electronically.

TRAUMA TEAM INTERNATIONAL

Ambulance and paramedical services

• **Headquarters:** Los Angeles.

• **Regional Offices:** World wide in all major Cities

• **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Carrie Lachanan of

San Antonio, Texas, holding 33.3% of total shares.

• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
16,526	350	25

Background: As one of the largest private medical firms in the world, Trauma Team provides ambulance services and paramedical support for a client base of at least fifteen million people. Equipped with top line AV type vehicles, Trauma Teams provide an essential service in the 2000's—recovering wounded clients from the field.

Equipment and Resources: Dispersed as needed among the offices are 1,305 AV-4 aerodyne vehicles, thirty corporate jets, twenty two Osprey II aircraft and four Boeing C-25 heavy cargo jets. Each office also has it's own surgical-capable infirmary.



Satellite transmission and communications.

- **Headquarters:** Paris.
- **Regional Offices:** London, Rome, Madrid, Stockholm, Bonn, Cairo, Nairobi, Brasilia, Washington, Los Angeles, Toronto, Tokyo, Beijing, Hong Kong.
- **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Raymond Rousseau, Menton, French Riviera, holding 15.5% of total shares.

• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
51,625	7,444	658

Background: WorldSat has the monopoly on large-scale satellite communications, and is responsible for the transmission of phone, military, computer and commercial data. These communications are crucial worldwide, and their disruption could be disastrous. WorldSat invests a great deal in making sure this does not happen. The satellites are even shielded against electro-magnetic pulse, although no one is really sure how well this will work. Although it is illegal, it is also possible for WorldSat to monitor any of the communications it is transmitting.

Equipment and Resources: Dispersed as needed among the offices are thirty AV-4 assault vehicles, twelve Osprey II aircraft, five corporate jets and three Boeing C-25 heavy cargo jets. Each office also has two helicopters and a surgical infirmary. World Sat's satellites are crucial to many nation's communications. Consequently, most high-tech military hardware is available to them on short notice. WorldSat has a large, well protected orbital service facility.

ARASAKA

Corporate security, corporate police and various corporate suboperations.

- **Headquarters:** Tokyo.
- **Regional Offices:** Singapore, Hong Kong, Osaka, Kyoto, Bangkok, Baghdad, Sydney, London, Hamburg, Paris, Madrid, Rome, Geneva, Helsinki, The Hague, Rio de Janeiro, Montreal, New York, Washington, San Francisco, Los Angeles, Chicago, Honolulu. Suboffices throughout the world.

• **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Saburo Arasaka, Tokyo, holding 19.9% of total shares.

• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
1,000,000	100,000	5,000

Background: If you want it protected, these are the people to speak to. They maintain the largest armed force of any corporation, although they do not maintain a particularly large amount of on-hand military heavy weapons. These troops are mostly licensed out to other firms as corporate security guards, couriers and mercenaries. They are the best trained and hardest in the business, and will follow their client's orders second only to Arasaka's. To the Arasaka corporation, they are loyal to the point of death. Arasaka is more interested in fostering its own political goals than protecting other companies, and they use their position of trust with major corporations around the world to gain inside information, contacts and advantages that will help them to realize their ultimate goal of political and economic control of Japan.

Equipment and Resources: Dispersed among Arasaka's offices are 250 AV-4 assault vehicles, 250 Osprey II aircraft, eleven corporate jets and twenty Boeing C-25 heavy cargo jets. Each office also has two helicopters, and a surgical infirmary. Arasaka's wealth gives it access to almost all levels of military technology on fairly short notice. Arasaka has a secret training facility in Hokkaido, where it trains its security troops and Operatives.

MILITECH

Arms manufacturing and distribution, mercenaries.

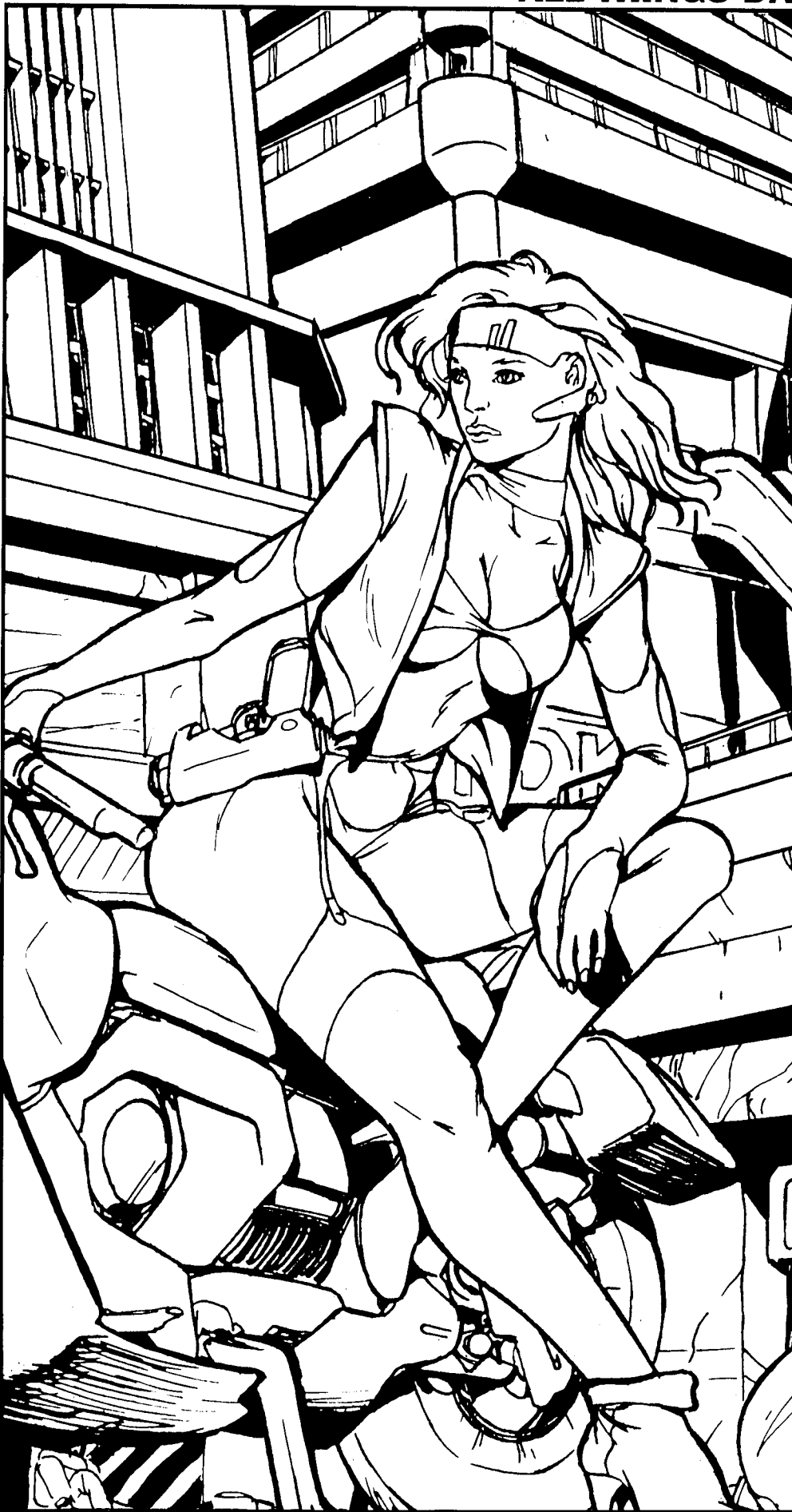
- **Headquarters:** Washington D.C.
- **Regional Offices:** New York, Miami, Chicago, Montreal, London, Rome, Zurich, Night City, Washington, Los Angeles, Toronto, Tokyo, Beijing, Hong Kong.
- **Name and Location of Major Shareholder:** Gen. Donald Lundee, USMC (ret.), Annapolis, Maryland, holding 13.9% of total shares.

• **Employees:**

Worldwide	Troops	Covert
350,000	100,000	2,031

Equipment and Resources: Dispersed among its offices and mercenary forces as needed are 200 AV-4 urban assault vehicles, 150 Osprey II aircraft, twenty corporate jets and twenty Boeing C-25 heavy cargo aircraft. (Usually, 50-75% of this equipment is in the field at any given time.) Additionally, each office has two helicopters, and a surgical infirmary. Naturally, MTI has access to large amounts of the best military technology available. MTI maintains secret training camps in Texas, the Sierra-Nevada Mountains of California, and Florida.

Background: MTI is the world's largest producer and seller of military weapons of all kinds. From revolvers to tanks to jet fighters, MTI is a major military supplier to the United States, and the United States, in turn, is MTI's largest customer. MTI will deal worldwide with anyone who has money. MTI's mercenary forces and in-house supply of weaponry make it the most militarily powerful company in the world, if not the most economically. That will come later. . . .



***"I love this place.
On the other
hand, I've also
been accused of
being a
masochist."***

—Johnny Silverhand

***"Nobody ever
leaves Night City.
Except in a body
bag."***

—Bes Isis

***"The City of the
Fallen Angels.
Not to mention
the Legion, the
Chromers, the
Gilligans, the
Inquisitors..."***

***—Lt. Strawberry
Morressey
NCPD***

***"Night
City...Ahwoooo!"***

—Unknown

WELCOME TO NIGHT CITY

Night City is a modern urban environment, complete with dark streets, filthy alleys and rowdy clubs. Where is it located? What's its real name? Not important. Night City is any big city in the world—it could be yours—late night and up against the wall.

The important thing about Night City is the feel, not the substance. It should be a place that the Referee has an immediate grasp of, allowing him to give his descriptions the proper "you are there" ambience. Night City plays best when you use a city that the players are somewhat familiar with; the recognition of street names and places juxtaposed with Boostergangs and hovering assault vehicles will make the 21st century even stranger than fiction.

But we realize some of you don't live in a major urban area. For those of you who can't just use a map of your home town, here's our own Night City to begin your adventures in.

SECTION 15 NIGHT CITY

Night City: The Overview

Name: Night City

Founded: 1994

Population: 5,000,000

Businesses: Technical, light industry, trade, electronics.

Background

Night City is a moderately-sized city located on the west coast of the United States. It has a population of about five million in the Greater Night City Area, with the majority living in sprawling suburbs to the southwest. The city itself lies on a large bay, surrounded by several small subcities and suburban communities (Westbrook, Heywood, Pacifica, South Night City).

Years of pollution, neglect and one of the most corrupt governments in the world have reduced most of these cities to cluttered, semi-deserted sprawls, with burned out homes, empty shopping malls and rampant street crime.

History

Night City was founded rather recently as cities go. Before 1994, the city was merely a clutter of unincorporated suburban sprawl between San Francisco and Los Angeles. During the Collapse, an enterprising land developer named Richard Night bought up the majority of what was later to become the Corporate Center and City Center areas. He proposed to start a new, safe, clean corporate city, free of crime and urban blight. By offering lucrative tax

packages to several major corporations (PetroChem, for example, had established drilling rights off the coast), he was able to establish a strong economic base as well as an instant population of corporate employees.

As planned, Night City was a clean, open community with rapid transit, and safe streets. Unfortunately, Night's plan went awry. In using his own advanced building techniques and materials, he excluded a number of established unions and construction firms, many of these controlled by organized crime syndicates. Four years after initial construction, the powerful gang bosses murdered Night and took over the Night City project.

Between selling contracts to their cronies, setting up drug and extortion rackets, and generally inviting the scum of the Collapse into the area, the gangs managed to turn a relatively clean, modern city into an embattled war zone. Crime, drugs, prostitution, random violence and cybernetic terrorism soon became the rule of law. By 2005, the name Night City had taken on a grim and deadly new meaning.

The Corporate Takeover: By 2009, the Corps decided they'd had enough. In lightning strikes, covert Solo squads eliminated most of the gang leaders and established a Corporation-controlled City Council. The newly elected Council, faced with chaos in the City, deputized Corporate security forces and allowed them full authority within the City limits. The Corporate and City centers were cleaned out and restored

to their pristine state. The old Harbor Mall (originally built in the 1980's), was demolished and the New Harbor Mall constructed.

The Present

Night City today is a rapidly growing urban region, still rife with urban violence and street crime, but with strong economic growth in the Corporate sector. It is the quintessential city of the Cyberpunk future—gritty, dangerous, but possessing an urban slick and stylish cool that makes it unique. As Bes Isis, Net 54 newcaster and one of Night City's most well known public figures puts it—

"Nobody ever leaves Night City. Except in a body bag."

Particulars

Political

The Night City Mayor's Office owes everything to the Corporations, and accordingly, the Corps can do anything they want in Night City. The current Mayor of Night City is Mbole Ebunike, a well-trained corporate puppet recently elected for his second term in 2020.

Public Services

Hospitals: There are two public hospitals (City Medical Center; Crisis Medical Center) in the Central Night City area, as well as another seven in the Greater Night City Area. There are at least four private medical centers in the City as well, mostly catering to cyberwear installation, bodybanking and biosculpture work.

Information: City information is provided for a nominal fee (1 eb/min) via Data Term. Data Terms are located on the corners of most (60%) City Streets, and can be used to access information, computer services, fax-mail and Net input.

Law Enforcement: Although much of Night City has been brought under Corporate control (these areas are

known as the Corporate Zone and are heavily patrolled by hired security), pockets of urban blight still infest the Marina, Harbor and Lake Park districts. Crime in these Controlled Zones is kept in check by brutal security sweeps and constant surveillance. The South City is still a seedy ruin of cheap tract housing, spreading into an area so blighted, it is known as the Combat Zone.

City Police Services: Police in Night City are scattered, poorly equipped and badly managed. Cops can often be bribed or convinced that they just don't want to get involved. The most incorruptable people on the Force are in **C-SWAT**, the CyberPsycho Squad. Determined and dangerous, these mavericks and loners are just too crazy to care about being on the take.

Transportation

Public Transportation: The Night City Transit Corporation (NCTC) provides for bus service on most major city thoroughfares. Light lev-rail transport is provided by **NCART** (Night City Area Rapid Transit), a public corporation with some private (read: Corporate) funding.

Night City Metro: The local airport, handling both domestic and international flights. Night City is on the hourly San Francisco to LA commuter run, as well as daily flights to New York, Chicago, Atlanta and Washington.

Suborbital flights are available by taking the LA commuter flight, then transferring via Orbital Air maglev train to the Mojave Spaceport.

Freeways: Night City is on State Highway 828, which runs east to connect to I-5. Ground transit to San Francisco is about 4 hours (due to road gang activity and bad roads); to LA about 6 hours.

**FOR MORE ABOUT NIGHT CITY, CHECK OUT
RTG'S NIGHT CITY SUPPLEMENT (CP3501)
AVAILABLE AT YOUR LOCAL HOBBY STORE.**



Places of Interest

Following are some of the major attractions and possibilities of Night City.

- 1 City Hall
- 2 City Library
- 3 City Museum
- 4 Hall of Justice
- 5 Marcini's: A large, expensive department store where you can find almost any luxury item.
- 6 Raven Microcyb
- 7 Microtech
- 8 Arasaka Tower
- 9 Eurobusiness Machines
- 10 Petrochem
- 11 Network 54 offices
- 12 Plaza Business Tower (96 stories of assorted businesses)
- 13 West City Tower (88 stories of assorted businesses)
- 14 Infocomp
- 15 WNS offices
- 16 Orbital Air Offices
- 17 Merrill, Asukaga & Finch
- 18 The Twilight Zone
- 19 1st Night CityBank
- 20 Euro-Worldbank
- 21 Grandmill's (large, expensive department store)
- 22 Totentanz: When the owner of this bar named his bar Deathdance, he didn't know how right he would be. A dance hall/bar housed on the top floor of an old skyscraper, this bar is well-known for a place to find Boostergangs. They all seem to congregate here, but they don't come to dance for the pleasure of it. It's considered a bad night if the body count is under twenty.
- 23 WorldSat Communications
- 24 Hotel Hamilton: A fairly modern hotel, known for its excellent security.
- 25 Highcourt Plaza Hotel: A very classy hotel featuring glass elevators, excellent service, and a 1920s decor.
- 26 Trauma Team™ Offices
- 27 Industrial Park
- 28 City Medical Center
- 29 REO Meatwagon (rival medical team) Offices
- 30 Atlantis: A classic "fern bar," known as a hangout for Corporates and Solos looking for jobs.
- 31 Jesse James' Non-Kosher Deli: While this may sound like an ideal place to eat, no food is ever served here. The Deli is a bar that was constructed in an old police station. Due to several unforeseen "accidents," you must register your personal weapons at the door and use the safe ones that are provided for you at the bar. There is a nightly contest to see who can get the highest body count in five minutes.
- 32 The Outer Limits (club)
- 33 Rainbow Nights: Rainbow Nights is more of a dance club than a bar. Its main attraction is a big dance floor that is almost always crowded. Every night there is a live band, usually a bunch of no names. They occasionally draw big acts like Johnny Silverhand and Kerry Eurodyne, but only under aliases.

- 34 Medical Technologies (a body bank)
- 35 City Police Precinct #1
- 36 Short Circuit: The Short Circuit is one of many bars in Night City. Like most of them, this bar has its regulars, who seem to mostly be Netrunners and Techies. Unbeknownst to most of the city, however, Livewire, one of the most renowned Netrunners, has a shop in a back room of the bar where he buys and sells programs for use in the Net. In addition to his trading of programs, Livewire is also adept at creating his own programs, or ones that other people order.
- 37 City College
- 38 Savage Doc's (a Ripperdoc joint)
- 39 City Police Precinct #3
- 40 Night Owl: One of the few bars that is open all night. This is a heavy security, no-nonsense bar. You come here to drink when nothing else is open.
- 41 West City Bank
- 42 Crisis Medical Center: a no-questions-asked medical center for fast patchups.
- 43 Café Chrome: a favorite Rocker hangout, complete with 50's retro decor and jukebox.
- 44 MetalStorm: A dangerous Chromer bar
- 45 Warehouses
- 46 Warehouses
- 47 Medicross Preservation: an illicit body bank, not too particular about I.D.'s or death certificates.
- 48 The Slammer: Well-known among Boostergangs as a place to settle disputes peacefully. If that doesn't work, the arena is there to settle them violently. The owner, Suds Joliet, also runs betting booths and occasionally rents out the arena for other events.
- 49 Camden Court: High security condos favored by Solos, Corps. Rent is \$3,000.00 a month.
- 50 McCartney Field Stadium: Main concert venue and home of the Night City Rangers, the local football team.
- 51 City Police Precinct #2
- 52 Wing Chang: Exclusive chinese restaurant.
- 53 La Baguette: Very trendy French cuisine.
- 54 Hari Kiri: Sushi Bar
- 55 New Harbor Shopping Mall
- 56 Grand Illusion (dance club)
- 57 The Afterlife: This bar is located in an old mortuary in Night City. Consisting of three rooms, The Ante-Chamber, the Crypt, and Hades, this bar is a favorite among solos that are currently between jobs. If you need to find armed help, this is the place to go.
- 58 Night City Fire Station #1
- 59 Lake Park Bandstand
- 60 28th St. Park (contested Boostergang turf)
- 61 28th Street Underpass (a Boostergang meeting spot)
- 62 Night City Fire Station #2
- 63 Bodukkan Performance Center
- 64 Forlorn Hope (a Central American Vet bar)

**"Sex. Drugs.
Rock and Roll.
Fully automatic
weapons with
grenade
launchers.**

**We got it all.
This is a modern
city..."**

—Ripperjack



NIGHT CITY ENCOUNTERS

Welcome to the mean streets of the City. These encounter tables are fast and nasty ways to keep your players moving, thinking and living Cyberpunk. Check the table for the time of day, then roll a percentage (two D10's, with one representing the 10's place) to determine the outcome. Feel free to alter the participants or the locale for extra variety.

DAYTIME ENCOUNTERS IN NIGHT CITY

1-2 City Police: One patrol officer, armed with AKR-20, armored in Kevlar vest. If you are wearing visible weapons or armor, he will stop you in a nice way and ask to see your identity papers. If you're argumentative, he will call for backup (3) officers to take you in.

3-8 Corporate Guards: Four corporate guards patrolling the area. Armored in vests & helmets, carrying Uzi's. If you're armed in a visible fashion, they will tell you to move on in a way that lets you know they're just itching to use those Uzis.

9-14 Nomads: Four Nomads from the Johansson Clan. Huge, rough-hewn blonde Vikings in flack vests and leather pants, carrying fighting knives and rifles. If there are attractive women in your group, they will whistle and make a general attempt at a pass. If not, they will move on.

15-20 Boostergang: Four low-level street punks in the colors of the *Metal Warriors*. They are armed with scratchers and wearing armor jackets. If your party is larger than theirs, they will avoid you. If of smaller or equal size, they will try to rough you up right on the street.

21-23 Petty Criminal: One pickpocket. His REF is 8, his pickpocket skill is +6. Armed with only a knife. If he's successful, you have lost your wallet (and all cash, cards, etc). If he fails in the attempt, feel free to beat him to a pulp. It can only improve his technique.

24-29 Solo Team: Three Solos, armed in flack vest & pants, carrying a mix of assault weapons. If you are wearing a rival Corporate uniform or patch, they will: 1-5, look you over and move on; 6-10, they will pick a fight. If you are wearing their Corporate colors, they'll ask you to join them for a drink. Roll 1D10 and take your chances.

30-33 Boostergang: Six members of the *Iron Sights* gang, armed with automatic pistols and rippers. They will hassle any attractive men or women in the party (the gang is mixed sex), shake you down for money and generally be looking for a fight. Go ahead and give it to them.

34-39 Techies: Two Techies, without weapons or armor. If you are wearing any unusual weapons or cybertech, they will stop you and ask to look. If it's removable, they may offer to trade some Skill chipware (up to the Referee's discretion) in exchange.

40-42 Culties: The *Inquisitors* are out in force on the Street. Six of them, armed with hidden nunchaku, corner you to hand out literature. If you are wearing any visible cybertech (arms, eyes with logos, etc.), be prepared to be heavily harassed and followed. If you use any violence, a minor riot may develop.

43-45 Private Investigator: You observe him/her shadowing you. The PI is armed with a heavy caliber revolver and wearing an armor jacket. If you rough the PI up a bit, you may discover that he/she thinks you are someone else.

46-51 Corporates: Two corporates from a middle level firm, headed for lunch. One is wearing an armor T-shirt under his/her suit. Neither are armed, but both carry cell phones. Roll 1D10. 1-4, they are being followed by thugs intent on robbery—if you feel altruistic or just want to score a reward, here's your chance. 5-8, they are lost and will ask directions to the restaurant (you could lead them the wrong way and mug them in an alley). 9-10, they know you from a previous encounter and stop you on purpose. Not good, probably.

52-57 Medias: A camera and interviewer team, doing random "man-on-the-street" stories. The subject of the interview will vary widely, depending on recent events and what's considered controversial at the time. If you want to be well known, this will put your face on TV screens all over Night City. On the other hand, it may alert your worst enemies to the fact that you are still alive.

58-64 Locals: Young men or women (2 to 6 total). Roll 1D10. Will be friendly on 1-5, hostile on 6-8, abusive on 9-10. No weapons or armor. These guys must be crazy.

65-70 Crazy: Some bearded, wild-eyed freak in torn rags. Roll 1D10. On 1-5, he rants at you a while, then starts to rant at someone else. 6-8, he decides you are one of the space aliens from Venus, and follows you, screaming invective. 9-10, he starts to scream, passes out in front of you, and everyone around thinks you had something to do with it.

71-75 Trauma Team: Standard 5 man team on a lunch break. Their AV is parked at the end of the corner, while their Solos keep watch. This might be a good time to make friends and spread a little "insurance" Eurobucks around.

76-81 Rockerboys: A three man band on the way to practice. Carrying real guitars and wearing leathers, no less. Roll 1D10. On 1-4, they will invite you to their gig tonight.

82-90 Posergang: Five members of the well-known *Kennedys* Posergang. Two male members look like RFK, one looks like JFK, the two females look like Jackie. If your group says anything—anything—about their appearance, their boosted hearing will pick it up and they will immediately take offense. They are wearing armor Ts under their retro-style 60s clothing and carrying Hvy. Handguns. JFK has a cyber-chrome right arm.

91-96 Security Guards: You're treading too close to the tail of an important Corporate. These guys will come back and warn you off. Flack armor, Sternmeyer 35's, boosted Reflexes.

97-00 Media Star: Famous media star. Roll 1D10. 1-6, will sign autographs if asked. 7-9, will be hostile and yell for a policeman or a bodyguard. On a 10,

he/she will take a liking to one member of the party and allow you to tag along.

EVENING ENCOUNTERS IN NIGHT CITY

1-5 City Police: Two patrol officers, armed with FN-RALs, armored in flack vests, pants. If you are wearing visible weapons or armor, they will stop you and demand identity papers. If you're argumentative, They will call for backup (3) officers to take you in. If you reach for a weapon, they'll shoot first, fill out the paperwork later.

6-11 Corporate Guards: Four corporate guards patrolling the area. Armored in flack vests & helmets, carrying Minami 10's. Unless you're a Corporate, they don't think you have any business running around their nice clean city at night. Move it, punk.

12-17 Nomads: A mixed group of six Nomads from the *Roadrunners* Pack. Wearing flack vests and leather pants, carrying fighting knives and rifles. Moderately drunk and looking for a fight. They will hassle any attractive looking men or women in your group. Face it; they want a fight. Give them one.

18-24 Boostergang: Five low-level street punks from the *Piranhas* boostergang. If you look like easy prey and have money, they'll rough you up. They are armed with Med. Handguns, knives and boosted reflexes.

25-30 Street Punks: Six Smash-heads, looking for credit to feed their habit. If you're not wearing Corporate or booster colors, they'll try to rush you right on the street. Armed with fighting knives; no armor.

31-36 Solo Team: Four Solos, armored in flack vest & pants, carrying smartgun chipped H&K MP5Ks. Boosted reflexes, boosted hearing, cyberoptics with low light, IR and targeting. Obviously up to some grey operation. If you are wearing a rival Corporate uniform or patch, they will: 1-5, dodge you and move on; 6-10, decide you are a witness and ought to be totalled right now.

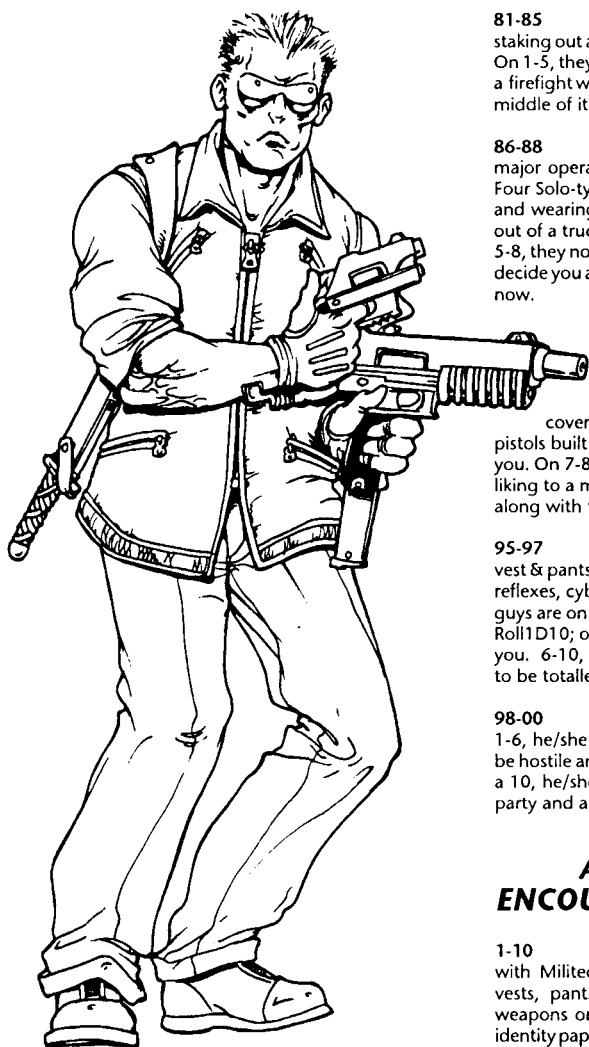
37-42 Boostergang: Six members of the *Iron Sights* gang, armed with automatic weapons, rippers, IR cyberoptics, boosted reflexes. They will hassle any attractive men or women in the party (the gang is mixed sex), shake you down for money and generally be looking for a fight. This might be tougher than the daylight crowd was.

43-44 Techies: Two Techies, with one Minami 10 submachinegun, wearing flack vests. Roll 1D10. 1-2, they are lugging a crate of tools into an AV-4. 3-5, they are working on a City system in your path. 6-10, they are walking toward you on their way to work.

45-50 Culties: The *Inquisitors* are out in maximum force. Six of them, armed openly with nunchaku, corner you for inspection. If you are wearing any visible cybertech (Arms, eyes with logos, etc.), they will proceed to beat you to a pulp.

51-54 Private Investigator: Roll 1D10. On 1-3, he/she is ahead of you, hassling an informant on the streetcorner concerning the whereabouts of a suspect. 4-7, he/she is shadowing someone ahead of you. 8-10, they will stop you and ask you whether you have seen the person they are following. The PI is armed with a heavy caliber revolver and wearing an armor jacket.

55-57 Corporates: Four corporates from a large firm, headed for the lev train station. Both are wearing armor T-shirts under their suits and carrying poly-



81-85 Medias: A camera and interviewer team, staking out a building on a hot assignment. Roll 1D10. On 1-5, they will be spotted by their story-subject and a firefight will ensue. You, of course, will be right in the middle of it.

86-88 Major Criminal: You've walked into a major operation of the notorious *Scagattalia Family*. Four Solo-type men armed with Med.& Heavy pistols and wearing flack vests, are unloading a drug cargo out of a truck. Roll 1D10. 1-4, they don't notice you. 5-8, they notice you and one warns you off. 9-10, they decide you are a witness and ought to be totalled right now.

89-94 Chromers: Four members of the *Steel Slaughter Slammers*. They are wearing armor Ts with metal spiked leathers. All have metal arms covered with chrome, with rippers and Med pistols built in. Roll 1D10—on a 1-6, they will go for you. On 7-8, they'll pass you by. On 9-10, they take a liking to a member of the party and invite you to tag along with them.

95-97 Solo team: Three Solos, armed in flack vest & pants, carrying smartgun chipped Uzis. Boosted reflexes, cyberoptics with low light, targeting. These guys are on a total black operation (an assassination). Roll 1D10; on a 1-5, if you ignore them, they'll ignore you. 6-10, they'll decide you are a witness and ought to be totalled right now.

98-00 Media Star: Famous media star. Roll 1D10. 1-6, he/she will sign autographs if asked. 7-9, will be hostile and yell for a policeman or a bodyguard. on a 10, he/she will take a liking to one member of the party and allow you to tag along.

AFTER-MIDNIGHT ENCOUNTERS IN NIGHT CITY

1-10 City Police: Two patrol officers, armed with Militech Ronin assault rifles, armored in flack vests, pants, helmets. If you are wearing visible weapons or armor, they will stop you and demand identity papers. You've got no business running around after midnight and they know it. They'll stop you and look for any pretext to make a bust. If you're wearing visible weapons, consider yourself detained. If you go for a weapon, they will shoot first and forget the paperwork.

11-22 Corporate Guards: Four corporate guards patrolling the area. Armored in flack vests & helmets, carrying FN-RALS. "What are you doing on the property after midnight? Can't have a good reason! Blam! Blam! Blam!"

23-30 Nomads: A mixed group of four Nomads from the *Wildman Pack*. Wearing flack vests, tatoos and leather pants, carrying fighting knives and rifles. As long as you stay clear of their bikes, they'll ignore you and concentrate on beating that family of Corporates to mush.

31-40 Boostergang: Five low-level street punks from the *Crazy Chicken* boostergang. They are armed with .45 automatics, knives and boosted reflexes. They're looking for 'Lacers or any other possible source of ready cash. Roll 1D10. On 1-7, you're it.

41-50 Street Punks: Four Lace addicts, looking for credit to feed their habit. Even if you're wearing Corporate or booster colors, they'll rush you. These guys don't care, and they don't feel pain. Armed with fighting knives, scratchers; no armor.

51-60 Solo Team: Two Solos, armed in flack vest & pants, carrying smartgun chipped H&K MPK-9. Boosted reflexes, boosted hearing, cyberoptics with

low light, IR and targeting. Obviously up to some grey operation. If you are wearing a rival Corporate uniform or patch, they will: 1-5, dodge you and move on; 6-10, decide you are a witness and ought to be totalled right now.

61-75 Boostergang: Six members of the *Blood Razors* gang, armed with automatic weapons, rippers, IR cyberoptics, boosted reflexes. Hassle you? Naw...they'll just torture you and listen to you scream. For fun. Afterwards, they'll sell the body to the Donor Center for cash.

76-80 Culties: It's Inquisition time! The *Inquisitors* are out in maximum force. Six of them, armed openly with nunchaku, handguns and whips corner you. "Only a servant of the Metal Demons would be abroad at this hour. Any decent citizen would be at home, asleep. Hack, slay and maim the heretic!"

81-82 Private Investigator: Roll 1D10. On 1-3, he/she is ahead of you, hassling an informant on the streetcorner concerning the whereabouts of a suspect. 4-7, he/she is shadowing someone ahead of you. 8-10, they will stop you and ask you whether you have seen the person they are following. The PI is armed with a heavy caliber revolver and wearing an armor jacket.

83-86 Chromers: Four members of the *Steel Slaughter Slammers*. They are wearing armor Ts with metal spiked leathers. All have metal arms covered with chrome, with rippers and .45 cal built in. Roll 1D10—on a 1-6, they will go for you. On 7-8, they'll pass you by. On 9-10, they take a liking to a member of the party and invite you to tag along with them.

87 Medias: A camera and interviewer team, looking for a story. Roll 1D10. On 1-5, they will be spotted by their story-subject and a firefight will ensue. You, of course, will be right in the middle of it. on a 6-10, they'll decide you're the story and follow you.

88-90 Locals: Young man or woman. Roll 1D10. 1-5, they are being beaten by four thugs from the *Blood Razors* gang. 6-10, they are being beaten severely by the *Inquisitors* for the sin of having designer eyes.

91-95 Firefight: Great. You just walked into a major altercation between the *Bradi Bunch* (a high-level Posergang that all look like refugees from an old sitcom) and the *Red Chrome Legion* (a neo-facist Boostergang). Both are wearing armor jackets and firing large caliber handguns. Rippers, cyberarm weapons and slice-n-dices are everywhere. Pick a side, or pick a target.

96-98 Trauma Team: The AV-4 hits the ground in the middle of a recent firefight. Roll 1D10. On a 1-5, the Team decides you're bystanders and ignores you. On 6-10, they figure you're part of the problem and the Solos open up with MAC10s.

99 Major Criminal: You've walked into a major operation of the notorious *Scagattalia Family*. Four Solo-type men armed with Ingram MAC 14s and wearing flack vests are unloading a drug cargo out of a truck. Roll 1D10. 1-4, they don't notice you. 5-8, they notice you and one warns you off. 9-10, they decide you are a witness and ought to be totalled right now.

00 Solo team: Three Solos, armed in flack vest & pants, carrying smartgun chipped Uzis. Boosted reflexes, cyberoptics with low light, targeting. These guys are on a total black operation (an assassination). Roll 1D10; on a 1-5, if you ignore them, they'll ignore you. 6-10, they'll decide you are a witness and ought to be totalled right now.

mer one shots. Roll 1D10. 1-4, they are being followed by thugs intent on robbery. 5-8, they think you're Boosters and will open fire at any provocation. 9-10, they not only think you're trouble, but will call for Corporate backup (see Corporate Guards, above).

58-64 Locals: Young man or woman. Roll 1D10. 1-5, they are being held up by two thugs from the *Metal Warriors* gang. 6-10, they are being beaten severely by the *Inquisitors* for the sin of having designer eyes.

65-70 Firefight: Great. You just walked into a major altercation between the *Bradi Bunch* (a high-level Posergang that all look like refugees from an old sitcom) and the *Red Chrome Legion* (a neo-facist Boostergang). Both are wearing armor jackets and firing large caliber handguns. Rippers, cyberarm weapons and slice-n-dices are everywhere. Pick a side, or pick a target.

71-75 Trauma Team: The AV-4 hits the ground in the middle of a recent firefight. Roll 1D10. On a 1-5, the Team decides you're bystanders and ignores you. On 6-10, they figure you're part of the problem and the Solos open up with MAC14s.

76-80 Rockerboys: You overtake a four man band on the way to a gig, backed by their two Solo bodyguards and their Fixer manager. Roll 1D10. On 1-4, they will invite you to join them. 5-8, they will send the Solos to "deal with those guys who are following them." 9-10, they ignore you.

SOME PERSONALITIES OF NIGHT CITY

Introducing a few people you're likely to meet at any time on the Streets of the City. These Personalities are designed to be played as general character classes.

Fireman (Fixer): Fireman is the most well known of the many local arms dealers. His main distinction comes from the fact that he supplies many of the legitimate businesses with security systems in addition to the weapons that their bouncers/hired solos use. Fireman was initially a cyber-soldier in the Nicaragua conflict, that used his contacts after leaving the service to supply his modest business. In addition to his arms dealing, Fireman is also involved in information dealing, something that makes him very popular with fixers in the city.

INT=6 TECH=5 REF=4 CL=6 LK=7
ATT=4 MA=5 EMP=6 BODY=5

Blacklist (Tech): A renegade chemical/cyber engineer from the Biotechnica Corporation, Blacklist makes his presence known in Night City in several ways. He is the man that Booster gangs see to get "personalized" cybernetics, the man that Corporations see to get viruses synthesized, and the man that the police talk to when they need help in identifying and analyzing chemicals used in crimes. Rumour has it that Biotechnica has a hit out on him for taking certain formulas that he developed with him when he left.

INT=6 TECH=8 REF=5 CL=8 LK=3
ATT=5 MA=5 EMP=4 BODY=5

Suds Joliet (Rockerboy): A retired Rockerboy who made his money on several classic 1990's albums, Suds now runs a speakeasy (specializing in his home brew) in an old warehouse. This speakeasy, known as *The Slam-*

mer, is a central meeting place for many peace talks between gangs. This is primarily due to the fact that the rest of the warehouse has been converted into an arena by Suds for non-peaceful resolutions to gang disputes. On occasion, Suds has been known to pull out his axe and play for the crowd.

INT=6 TECH=3 REF=6 CL=9 LK=5
ATT=4 MA=6 EMP=8 BODY=8

David Whindam (Corporate): David Whindam is a typical corp brown-noser, always looking for a way to get to the top quicker than anyone else. Two years ago he formed his own personal hit squad of solos known on the streets as the *Lead Messengers*. After successfully removing several people that were in the way of his making president of the local division of Biotechnica, he realized that there was a lot of profit to be made in hiring out the *Messengers*. He now "loans" them to other corporate friends of his in order to help them gain power. He has the vision of total city control once he has all of his "friends" in power.

INT=8 TECH=3 REF=7 CL=9 LK=5
ATT=7 MA=5 EMP=3 BODY=7

Strawberry (Cop): Strawberry was given his name for his naturally red hair, an unusual sight in Night City (the fact that it's natural, not the color). Strawberry is a cop who has spent all of his fifteen years on the force walking the streets of Night City. Although he has sworn to uphold the law, he also knows when to look the other way. Strawberry is a rarity in the 2000's; he cares. Instead of busting someone who is doing drugs, he generally takes them to a detox clinic, with the hope that they will beat the habit. Although he is a cop, almost everyone on the streets will go out of their way to help him out in a pinch.

INT=6 TECH=3 REF=10 CL=7 LK=9
ATT=4 MA=7 EMP=10 BODY=9

Hypo (Nomad/Booster): No one knows where Hypo came from, but everyone agrees that he is crazy. He was given his name after he opened a detox clinic in the worst part of Night City. Unlike the major detox clinics, Hypo does not charge anything for his services except for a promise that his successes will try and help someone else by bringing them to his clinic.

INT=7 TECH=2 REF=8 CL=7 LK=8
ATT=6 MA=6 EMP=8 BODY=7

Livewire (Netrunner): Livewire is a Netrunner who used to be associated with a solo team known as the *Devil's Horde*, until the team disbanded in 2011 due to a mishap in an operation that killed off everyone except Livewire and one other member. These days Livewire can usually be found in a small shop that he runs out of the back room of the Short Circuit, a local bar. It is said that he has access to any program for the right price; and if he doesn't have it, he will make it.

INT=9 TECH=6 REF=10 CL=10 LK=9
ATT=8 MA=8 EMP=4 BODY=7

Lucifer (Solo): Lucifer is the founding member and only survivor of the *Devil's Horde* besides Livewire. Known for his vicious, no holds barred hand to hand combat style, Lucifer can be bought for the right price. He generally keeps to himself, but has been known to work with Livewire on occasion.

INT=6 TECH=3 REF=10 CL=9 LK=8
ATT=10 MA=9 EMP=4 BODY=8

Athena (Netrunner): Athena is the leader of an all-woman boostergang known as the *Valkyries*. She is often found in the company of two of her "soldiers", Artemis and Hera. Beside her activities as the *Valkyrie* leader, Athena also runs the Net for a Solo known on the streets as Kestral.

INT=6 TECH=6 REF=9 CL=10 LK=4
ATT=8 MA=6 EMP=6 BODY=8

Kestral (Solo): Like many Solos, Kestral gained her combat experience in the Central American conflict. What makes her different is the fact that she

fought for a corporation that backed the losing side. Near the end of the war, Kestral saw that her side was losing and arranged to be "killed in action". After faking her death, she paid her way into a corporate solo team that was soon sent out on a suicide mission. Only her knowledge of the opposition and the place they were going to hit allowed her to escape certain death. Today she hires herself out to individuals only, having long since lost any trust in corporations.

INT=7 TECH=4 REF=12 CL=9 LK=8
ATT=8 MA=10 EMP=5 BODY=7

White Lion (Fixer): The White Lion is one of Night City's most well known fixers. She has contacts into several of the main corporations as well as the underworld of Night City. Although most people have heard of her, very few know where to find her. She likes to keep her whereabouts a secret because she sold some information that led to the downfall of a wealthy mob family, who then put a hit out on her. If someone tries to collect on this hit, they will find themselves in deep trouble as there are many people who owe their lives to the White Lion and are more than willing to protect her.

INT=10 TECH=3 REF=7 CL=5 LK=9
ATT=8 MA=7 EMP=7 BODY=7

Pythagoras (Netrunner): Pythagoras is a little bit of everything; Hacker, Netrunner, Techie. He is most well known for his abilities in adapting software that already exists, but he is not at all bad with creating his own. Although he tries to hide it, most people know that it was he that was solely responsible for the downfall of the Hiroshi Electronics Corporation after they threatened to set him up for refusing to work for them. It is this reputation that keeps other corporations from hiring his services.

INT=7 TECH=10 REF=9 CL=8 LK=5
ATT=7 MA=7 EMP=5 BODY=5

Watchmaker (Med Techie): Watchmaker is both a biotechnician and a cybertechnician, whose claim to fame

was her invention of the *Skinwatch*. After a few years of working in the corporate world, Watchmaker decided that she could make more money on her own. She now resides in Night City and does a fair amount of renegade surgery for boostergangs and corps alike.

INT=9 TECH=9 REF=7 CL=9 LK=7
ATT=9 MA=8 EMP=8 BODY=6

Nostradamus (Media): Unlike the Nostradamus of the 1400s, this one specializes not in the future, but in the past and present. He is somewhat of a recluse, living in a converted warehouse that has many defenses. Inside the warehouse lies the biggest collection of real books that are left in the City. Nostradamus uses these books along with a gigantic mainframe to compile all the information that he can. To facilitate this collection, he often hires Netrunners to acquire the saleable information that he is also known for brokering.

INT=10 TECH=2 REF=8 CL=9 LK=7
ATT=6 MA=5 EMP=4 BODY=7

Aries (Solo): Aries is the living example of a man who has been through hell and come back to tell about it. Many years ago, he was a commander for the CIA, closely associated with the Gang of Four. After the fall of the United States, he ran covert operations in Central America for a while, then surfaced in Night City in 2010 as a high priced Solo. Over the years his humanity slowly drained away until he went 'borg about a year later. After his capture, which was well publicized by the media, he underwent the braindance and is now working for the Night City Police Force hunting down other 'borgs.

INT=8 TECH=5 REF=12 CL=7 LK=5
ATT=5 MA=7 EMP=2 BODY=12

Bes Isis (Media): Bes Isis is a well known media who has a reputation for being slightly off-balance when it comes to scooping other medias. More than once, she has broken a few rules to get inside of some big story, sometimes at a cost. She now has one

chrome leg and a similar replacement for half of her chest. These replacements were necessary after she faked injury to get a story on "meat jumping."

INT=8 TECH=4 REF=9 CL=10 LK=8
ATT=10 MA=7 EMP=7 BODY=6

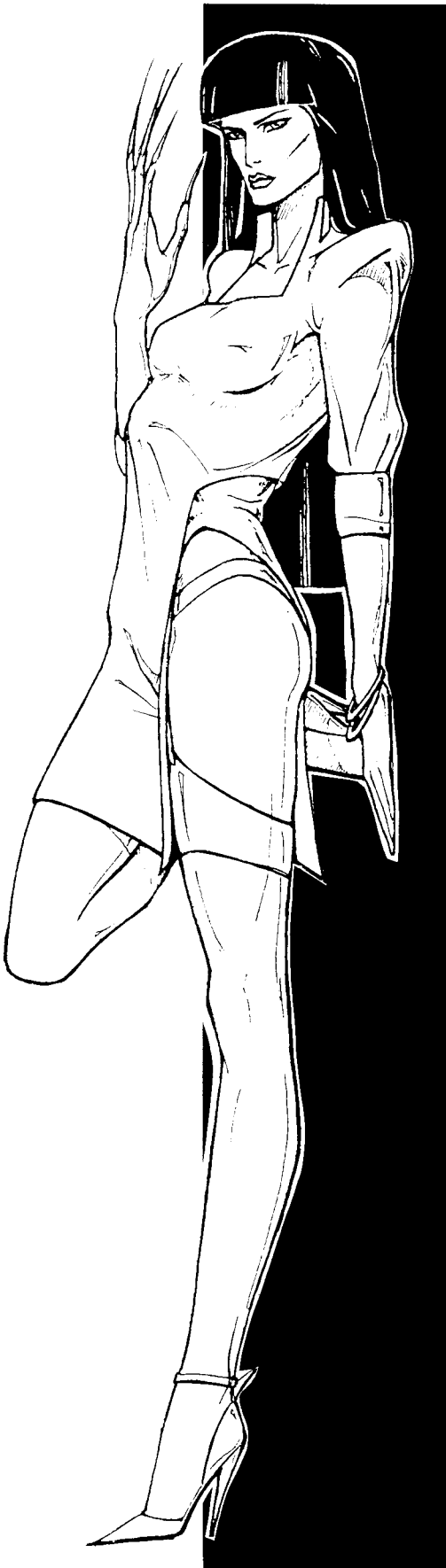
Music Man (Rockerboy): Music Man is the equivalent of Night City's wandering minstrel. He has no set home, but plays for his lodging at various bars. In addition to his music, Music Man also sells information.

INT=5 TECH=6 REF=7 CL=9 LK=5
ATT=6 MA=6 EMP=7 BODY=7

Bag Lady (Fixer): No one knows where she came from, but one day she appeared in Night City with a burlap bag over one shoulder that was full of sundry items, all of which were stolen. It has been said that she is the last person that people go to when they need something, yet she always seems to have it.

INT=8 TECH=2 REF=7 CL=6 LK=8
ATT=2 MA=4 EMP=7 BODY=2





Just another Friday night.

You pay your two bucks at the door and walk in. Over at the bar there are the usual lines, so you decide to skip the bar-front action. Feeling on top of the world, you go out to the main floor, for another night of the club life.

At first glance, the club seems like a mixing place of all types of people. Then you realize that they're all segregated. Posers at the back, trying to get noticed, your average punks in the middle, acting oblivious to their surroundings. There are Chromers bashing their heads against the walls on one side, while the Boosters are on the other, looking for trouble.

And last but not least there are the 'dorph-heads, slamming into each other at the front, next to the stage where the band of the night blares out hits of today and of the past.

They say people like Johnny Silverhand and Kerry Eurodyne got their start in clubs just like this one, but you think it's just hype. After all, people like Johnny Silverhand didn't need the clubs to make them larger than life, they were born that way. It's only Rock N' Roll, right?

Out on the Streets of Night City, there's stories going on—Street history being made. Whether it's Boosters in the alleys, Nomads on the Road, or Rockers in the clubs, there's action and trouble, everywhere you look. And the Trauma Team hovers overhead, waitin' to pick up the pieces—for a price.

Here comes a taste of the City. In your face.

"A Cool Metal Fire": Silverhand Still Can Rock

**Reprinted
From
ROCKERBOY
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From his humble beginnings in the group *Samurai*, to his first five solo albums, Johnny Silverhand has become the household word in rock and roll. With his latest release, *A Cool Metal Fire*, Johnny Silverhand is making his push to become a legend.

The album opens up as all of his solo albums have, with a rip roaring instrumental, "Dancing With My Axe," that is guaranteed to set your stereo on fire. This fast paced, no holds barred, display of guitar work is so hot that you'll want to listen to it twice.

And if that isn't enough in itself, you come to track two, "Chippin' In." This piece, like the first, is another fast paced lightning bolt of pure rock and roll. It also asks a question about today's society that cannot be ignored: If we continue the current trend of

replacing our body parts with metal, what will we have left in the end?

The rest of the album is almost typical Silverhand, with its energetic guitar playing and thought provoking

"The album takes us to the heart of our culture and allows us to monitor its pulse.."

lyrics. He does, however come up with three other songs that really stand out. The first two, "(Out of) The City" and "Flashing Lights," go so well together, both thematically and musically, that they almost seem to be one song in totality instead of two individual ones. These two songs bring out the ethereal vision of today from a non-partisan outsider that is innocent of our ways. It leaves the listener with a new way of looking at his own life,

even as it passes by at the speed of light.

The last song on the album, "Never Fade Away," departs from the mainstream sound of Johnny Silverhand and brings him into a new dimension musically. The basic rhythm is both simplistic and concise. This song makes no pretenses at being a song about today, but doesn't leave you with a gritty metal aftertaste like most of its peers. Although I'm not sure that this song really belongs with the others on the album because of its departure musically, I do know that it should have been recorded somewhere, so *A Cool Metal Fire* is as good a place as any.

Overall, I found *A Cool Metal Fire* to be more than just your ordinary, everyday record. With its driving beat and spellbinding lyrics, the album takes us to the heart of our culture and allows us to monitor its pulse.

SILVERHAND UPDATE: CLONE TOUR BEGINS:

After six months of seclusion following an unsuccessful assassination attempt, Rockerboy Johnny Silverhand has re-entered the music scene to promote his new LP. The album, *Clone Wars*, deals with recent cloning breakthroughs and the idea of bioengineered humans being created for military and industrial purposes.

Interviewed in his Night City studio, Silverhand commented, "I needed a few months to let the heat die down over the last disk. *Clone Wars* was pretty intense, and a lot of people, particularly the Biotechnica guys, didn't like the slavery implications I wrote into it. I won't say they fronted the hit on me, but hey, you've got a brain, right?"

Pretentious or Political? Seattle's Cutthroat.

Review by Jeff Daniel

"The audience seems to consist of the mindless, overpainted, underdressed children that you would find at most Chromatic Metal concerts. Each one of them is so wrapped up in their own image that they often don't seem to even know who the band they are seeing is. Tonight is a night that they will always remember though, because Cutthroat is about to hit the stage."

So reads the back cover of *Slashing Steel*, the new live album by *Cutthroat*. Some people think that these kings of Chrome are getting a little too preten-

tious when referring to themselves, but I had a chance to talk to Knifeedge, the lead singer and bassist for the band, who thinks otherwise.

Jeff Daniel: People often say that you guys are just a little pretentious when talking about yourselves. Why do you think that this is?

Knifeedge: That's easy. Unlike most Chromatic bands today, we take our roots from the old punk bands of the late 1970s and early '80s. It's not the blazing style that used to be called Speed Metal, though we do use that a lot. Politics is the driving force behind our band. It's because we are so political, that we force ourselves onto our listeners. If that is pretentious, then I guess we are.

JD: When you say you are a political band, what do you mean?

K: We view ourselves as messengers. It is our job to open the eyes of our

listeners with our music. The best eye-opening messages are in political issues and stories.

JD: Like the song "Kalakari"?

K: Exactly. Most people today don't even remember the name Hiram Kalakari, and they certainly don't remember what he did. It's songs about things that have shaped our lives that we play. We try and tell the truth as we see it, not what the public wants to hear.

JD: Then how do you explain the success of "Kalakari"? As of today it is currently number four on the EuroRadio top ten.

K: You got me. If we had known that it would be such a hit, well, I don't know. Maybe we would have done something different to promote the album. Though I suppose it's really not going to matter since I still think that the average person is not going to know who the f**k Kalakari was.

JD: Getting back to your political motivation, how do you justify "Ginsu Lover" as being political?

K: Easy, I said we had our background in politics, not our entire lives motivated by it. But if you listen very closely, you will find out that it is a political song of sorts. "Ginsu Lover" is not about a sexual lover, but rather a member of a Boostergang who is overenthusiastic about using his Ripers. It's guys like the Ginsu Lover who make our streets unsafe to walk at night.

JD: What's next for Cutthroat? Slashing Steel is being called a new innovation in the music industry, how do you intend to follow it up?

K: You got me. When we released a live album of entirely new material, we expected to have our diehard fans buy it and that was it. Now the damn thing's gone and sold over two million copies. I expect we'll decide what's next for us after we tour.

—JD

DESTINY: STILL ON THE EDGE, STILL FIGHTING THE WAR

"Fifty years gone by / Since we heard our nation's cry / Fifty years gone by / Since we all watched you die"

It is lyrics like these that make *Destiny* one of the most provoking bands of our time.



Jessie Moore of Destiny

Their new hit, "Song for John (Fifty Years)," is not only filled with political rhetoric, but also reminds us of a time when America was still great.

Since their debut album, "Walking the Skies", *Destiny* has consistently provided the listening public with songs that hit close to home. Bandleader Jessie Moore explains, "We didn't always used to be political. In fact, I didn't even care about anything other than making money until ten years ago. All I wanted was the fame, and all the benefits that came with it. Now times are different. It seems all I want now is to get my messages across."

But fame and fortune did elude them for many years until they got their big break opening for the now defunct *Cowboy Panzer*. It was on that tour that the audience really started to notice their music.

"I think it was the fact that *Cowboy Panzer* was so big and political. I found out that we were going to open for them on the tour and all of a sudden I knew that our music had to change. I must have written thirty songs on that tour, some of which were eventually worked into our set."

Despite the growing interest that

Jesse was showing in political issues, the band continued to produce other songs as well.

"I can remember the first time we went into the studio after the C.P. tour. I had all these songs that I wanted to record, but the group started right in on this bubblegum tune called, 'Input Out.' I was furious. I mean, here I was with this great message to sing and all these guys wanted to do was talk about bad relationships."

"It was about then when I threatened to quit. Thinking back on it now, I can understand why the band didn't think I was serious. I must have threatened to quit six times in the first nine months of our existence. And all the time I was using those threats so I could get my own way. I really was a spoiled brat.

"It took me about five months before I convinced them that I was serious. By then we had all ready recorded "My Baby Left Me For A Short Circuit". Pleading with the band, I convinced them to start over, using the stuff I had written on the tour, instead of stuff like, "Input Out". When it was all over, some ten months after we trashed the stuff from "My Baby", we had recorded, "Dinner With Himmler".

It was that album that attracted so much attention from the critics. They called it the new political feeling of the 2000's. The fame and fortune that *Destiny* had been looking forward to had been found.

Their second album after the *Cowboy Panzer* tour gained them even more notoriety. So much that they were able to tour as a headliner instead of a backup band. *Destiny* drummer, Timemaster, recalls:

"It was a big change. I mean one

day your opening for some big name group. Then you're a big name group. I can still remember the difference in the fans. One day you're slogging through an old number, listening to the fans yawning, and the next the fans are going wild.

"I remember this one gig we did on the *Cheyenne Mountain* tour when this sleek looking Chromer comes up to me and offers to jack in. This type of thing never happened as an opening band."

After the release of *Cheyenne Mountain* the band drew some flack from the Europeans. In fact, the album was banned for a while in several countries overseas.

"I can remember that", says Time-master. "Jessie was crushed. She was so into her new political mood that she got depressed that the entire world wasn't hearing her message. But it wasn't the Europeans we had to worry about. Back here in the United States we had several corporations, who shall remain nameless, who wanted our heads on worldwide news.

"More than once on that tour we had our backstage crew and roadies, which included a couple guys who used to be professional wrestlers back in the '90's, toss some people out who wanted to do something other than give us praise."

The band still has some problems with fans. Two times on the last tour there were fans arrested for trying to break into the tour bus. And on more than one occasion there have been young women claiming to have been attacked by band members.

"Yeah, I know all that stuff. But what really gets me is that all our real fans know that the two posers arrested were 'dorped out and looking for a place to recycle. As for those "rape" attempts, those are just corporations trying as best they can to get us out of the spotlight. Our true fans know that we are all involved in permanent interfaces."

Destiny. A band fighting for the truth. In a struggle against corporations that don't want to hear the truth, all they can do is hope to survive.

NOMADS: TWO VIEWS FROM THE ROAD

BY JAMES NERDWELL

The McCains: Farmers on the Run

Bud and Martha McCain tried to hold onto their land, but the Agri-Corps were determined to remove them. Even after the Agri-Corps bought the local bank so they could foreclose on their property, the McCains were steadfast in their resolve to remain on the land that had been in their family for generations. Then came the "bad luck"—their eldest son perished in a car "accident", their daughter made an addict by Corporate drug lords.

Then came the plague. Within twelve hours, all of the cattle and the poultry were dead; the crops, withered husks. The McCains left their land, promising to someday retake what was rightfully theirs. It was a dream they shared with many others.

Over years, the McCains have formed a new family, a family of the homeless and the dispossessed. They

came on foot, on motorcycles, in fleets of R.V.s. Under the leadership of Bud McCain, they formed a roving community, known as the Huskers to outsiders due to their Corn Belt roots. Travelling the roadways of America, finding work where they can, setting up camp when they are able, moving on when the locals can no longer tolerate them, the Huskers have a common goal—to someday retake their land.

Labeled as terrorists for their bold strikes against the industries which have rendered them homeless, the McCains prefer to think of themselves as honest folk turned freedom fighters. The Huskers have long memories. Those who befriend them have an ally for life, those who anger them have a dangerous foe. Will the McCains retake their stolen homeland? Time will tell. But with every new atrocity committed by the Agri-Corps, their numbers grow.

The Crazy Quilts: Mercenary Brotherhood

The Central American Wars were hard on the soldiers who fought in them. Harder still was coming home. The cities were urban wastelands, unsuited for raising a family. Homes, towns, whole cities had disappeared off of the maps, victims of progress.

These young soldiers returned to an America in which nothing was sacred, and everything was for sale. Many found that they were unwelcome relics of the past. With nothing else to turn to, many of these dispossessed combat men and women turned to the only support network they had, each other; and the only profession they knew, soldiering.

Recruited from all over the country, the Crazy Quilts are one such group. Together, they formed one of the many offshoots of Nomad culture, the mer-

cenary brotherhood. Named for their colorful uniforms, a ragtag collection of fabric scraps roughly forming a camouflage pattern, they sell the one commodity they have left in a ruined world; their honor and fighting skills.

The Crazy Quilts hire themselves out, whether singly or in small battalions. Many act as bodyguards, others hire out as freelance mercs, corporate extraction forces, or as hit men and assassins. The Crazy Quilts place honor above all else. You can be certain that they will never turn upon their employers, never sell out, never back down, and never desert a comrade.

The Crazy Quilts consider themselves the last bastion of professional integrity in an otherwise chaotic society. It is this uncompromising reputation which has made the Crazy Quilts a powerful and respected force in this *Cyberpunk* world.

NIGHT CITY
TODAY

December 17, 2020

Volume CCVI, No. 46

REPORT

Walter Pickering's Night City
StreetsStreet Direct
With The
Blood Razors

Dateline Night City—The City's never really dark, not for those who live and die in it. A relentless neon circuit of steel and glass. Night in Night City is a hot pulsing thing. You feel it coursing through the wacked out veins of drugged up dorph heads, high on Lace and Slam. See it in the cookie cutter stares of pale faced posers, just out from under the knife. But no matter what your kick is, you're probably not experiencing it alone. You belong in the City, or you die. People congealing together like spattered blood, moving to a thousand different songs.

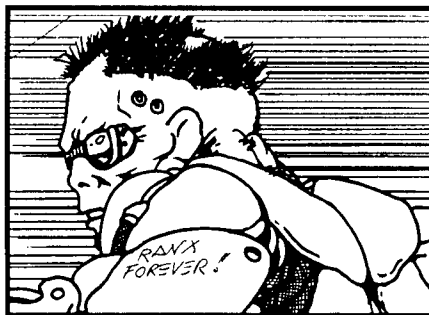
You hear the Blood Razor's song only once, and you never forget. I'll never know why a group of Boosters like the Razors let me run a night with their pack; maybe I caught Hack Man, the Booster chieftan in a good mood. It was party time: Hack's kid brother was getting his claws.

Just a short brief for you folks out there in the burbs; you've probably never heard of these Booster boys before. Here in the City, they're as common as crud on the sidewalk. Gangs like the Razors have fused cyberwear and violence into a deadly form of street fashion that has been claiming the

Cont. Pg. 219

BOOSTERGANGS: No Street is Safe

A Special Report



By Mikuru Ponsumisu

There's a fire on the Street, engulfing your neighborhood. Fueled by cheap designer drugs, cheap cyberwear, and cheaper automatic weapons, the fire of gangsterism once again threatens to annihilate Night City.

In the past two weeks, random shootings have escalated by fifty percent; yesterday, two innocent bystanders were gunned down in a hail of weapon fire as they walked down to the corner FoodMart. Their crime: walking through a section of *Crazy Chicken* turf during a gang dispute.

Gangs. They're your neighbors. They're your kids. You need to know these guys and be ready for them. Because in Night City, no street is safe:

Bradi Bunch: The *Bunch* is an extended family gang which protects runaway children. A few older "adults" run the gang and protect the turf, while the younger members steal, and deal for family support. Extended families are territorial and fiercely protective of their members.

Red Chrome Legion: The Legion is a *skinhead* gang; young males united around a certain hate group ideology. Uniforms, flags and militaristic slogans are the rule. The Red Chromers

will attack anything that they think isn't "right" (read: just like them).

Steel Slaughter Slammers: A typical *chromatic metal* gang. Chromer gangs like centering activities around their favorite rock bands, interpreting song lyrics as orders from their heroes. Chromatic rock gangs are into totally senseless, random acts of violence as a means of expression.

The Gilligans: The *Gilligans* are a typical *self defense* gang; in this case, militant gays who are tired of being attacked by groups like the *Red Chrome Legion*. They are relatively peaceful, as long as you stay off their turf (the Marina district), and leave them alone.

The Kennedys: The *Kennedys* are a typical *posergang*. Posers adopt the clone look for protection (one Kennedy looks just like another), identification and impact (twenty JFKs are a pretty scary sight). These gangs center on recreating their own bizarre interpretations of their heroes; for example, the *Kennedy's Hyan-nisport Weekends*, where all four hundred members descend on a location for a week-long orgy of destruction.

Metal Warriors: The *Metal Warriors* are a *combat gang*, with their activities centering around a type of "warrior's code". Elaborate combat rituals, ranks, and body armor are all part of the mystique. Combat gangs are dangerous, because once they declare a war on someone, they never give up.

Piranhas: The *Piranhas* are a typical *party gang*. They party, drink Smash, take (and deal drugs), and mug people, all as part of a "just because" lifestyle. To these guys, the Party is everything.

Inquisitors: The *Inquisitors* are a *cultie gang*; like the hate gangs, they center on a specific ideology, in this case, religious. The *Inquisitors* think cyberwear is blasphemous, and think nothing of tearing it right out of your body. They consider this "saving" your soul.

From Pg. 218

lives of more than forty citizens a week. The average Booster is an amoral technophile. Hardware and Wetware are the meat and drink of the Booster, and they'll do anything to get it. Arson, robbery, muggings, assassinations. If there's money in it, enough for another small boost at a blackmarket clinic, the Booster will take to it like chrome on a pair of mirrorshades. It's easier every time, they say. As more and more hardware's grafted, sockets drilled, and chips implanted, the Booster sinks further into his psychoworld machine-altered chaos. The best of them become the ring leaders, the worst are killing machines, riding on the edge of cyberpsychosis, ready to flatline themselves and everyone around them for that last big score.

Worst of all, Boosters travel in packs.

Maybe it was my arm, the one I lost in Lima, that endeared me to the Razors' top brass. It was an old model, military, and the dull steel and chipped plastic put me on their level. They had shackled themselves in an old warehouse, off of the main sprawl. In twos and threes they filtered in, screaming and shouting over deafening hardcore street rock. A few grabbed oiled rags and started cleaning their claws, fresh blood from a bunch of posers looking for action. Hack Man sat on his plastic throne, staring out through gunmetal eyes at the graffiti-covered walls of the nest. Dorphed up, he wasn't in the mood to answer questions. Only when his brother staggered in was there a flicker from behind the stone cut face. Metal arms crossed over armored chest, he popped his claws. A signal for the rest.

They came at Hack Man's bro from all sides, animal cries tearing from their throats as claws popped from housings in fingers. Steel and flesh monsters, pushed on by drugs music, hardware, and each other. The kid bared his teeth as the first pair made their pass, striking home, rending bloody tears in his flesh with a sur-

geon's skill. He didn't fight, didn't run, didn't cry out. Soon his arms, legs, chest were covered with thin lacerations. Knees buckling, he fell to the floor. I watched with facinated horror as the pack pounced on their prey, kicking and biting. In minutes, it was over. They dragged the broken kid before his older bro, throwing him before their chieftain's feet.

"Get up," the Hack Man snarled.

The kid pushed himself up to his knees, stared out into nowhere. "It hurts," he muttered through swollen lips.

The kick sent him sprawling across the floor of the nest. "Life hurts," said Hack Man over the jeers of his gang brothers. "You were born into a world of pain. If you don't like it, just leave now. Go outside in the gutter. Curl up and die. We welcome pain. We are pain. But we armor ourselves. Look around you. We are the city. Use your claws to hurt. Be one of us and pain won't touch you. You become the pain." He rose from his chair. "Are you ready to become the pain?"

He forced himself to stand, blood painting the floor a greasy red. He turned to the nearest Razor and struck him in the jaw with a leather gloved fist. The Boosters roared their approval. The answer was yes.

They stormed out of the building, claws exposed. They carried the kid on their shoulders. They would work their way across their city, heading towards a waiting ripperdoc, slashing and burning everything in their path. The cops stayed far away; no overtime bonus is worth messing with a Blood Razor initiation.

The hospitals would report thirteen casualties from the mayhem that night, all so that a fifteen-year-old kid could get his claws and join with his brothers. Before I left the nest, the Hack Man, cooling his jets with Smash, asked me what I thought of his family.

I popped the cassette out of my arm and stowed it in my bag. He could read about it on the Net, just like the rest of you.

—Walter Pickering, News 54



my life with several sharp blades protruding from their hands. These weapons, which are illegal, go by the street name of "Rippers," and, judging by their looks, I would estimate that they will do just that to human flesh and bone.

The gang's initial hostility stopped cold when I firmly told them that killing me, or even refusing to let me accompany them, would result in immediate stoppage of funds provided by Arasaka. It is my impression that the members of this gang hate their own humanity as well as other people's. This is further reinforced by my observation that the gang members that are held in the highest esteem are the ones that have the most metal meshed with their bodies. In my judgement, the members of this gang can easily be controlled by our organization by simply controlling their money supply to buy new cybernetics.

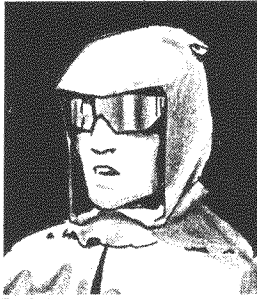
The week I spent with the gang proves to me another theory that I had postulated: The gang not only hates humanity [which, in itself could be reasoning for its existence], but also likes to hurt, mutilate and kill others for what would seem to be the pure pleasure of it. These two factors lead me to the conclusion that the members of "Iron Sights" are all suffering from cyberpsychosis, and terminating our ties with them in the near future may be the best solution for all parties.

- Rachael Tyroll 9/1/20

GANG VIOLENCE ERUPTS ON NIGHT CITY STREETS

By Bes Isis

In the early morning hours seventeen youths were killed in yet another Boostergang confrontation. Street sources say that a group of the Iron Sights gang were gathered at a bar known as Rainbow Nights when they were confronted by the red-robed Inquisitors. After a brief argument, fighting started, and when it was all over there were seven dead Inquisitors and ten dead members of the Iron Sights.



When we finally were able to reach the leader of the Inquisitors, who has asked that his name be withheld, he had several things to say about today's and other related incidents.

"In the midnight hour, when the sound of footsteps on the pavement strikes fear within your heart, the Inquisitors will be there to judge you. Tonight's example, the attack on the heretics known as the Iron Sights, is just the start of a new order that is coming to be. A new order that will be led by the Inquisitors.

"I stand here before the public not to preach of impending doom, but rather of judgment. Judgment that will be rendered by the Inquisitors. For most of the public, they have nothing to fear, but there are some out there that should think about their sins, and how they will soon be punished for them.

"To further the impact of this statement, I need only point out the case of the heretical members of the Iron Sights. They, like anyone else who has molded unnatural machinery into their God-given flesh, will be struck down to the last person by the Inquisitors. If that is not clear enough, then let me rephrase it: if you have no metal infused with your body, you are safe. If you have voluntarily undergone such blasphemous melding, then beware. The Inquisitors are here to judge you."

Although he would not reveal his identity to the public, the head of the Inquisitors is thought to have some older, no longer believed, religious background, which can be seen as the cause for his slightly different views on today's society. Whatever his reason may be, the head of the Inquisitors has given his warning to the people of Night City.

On an ending note, it must be pointed out that the chief of police for Night City was reluctant to answer questions regarding his plans for controlling the Inquisitors, and other gangs that threaten the citizens of this city. In fact the only thing we could get out of him was, "No comment."

Sound familiar?

First Person

One Night with the TRAUMA TEAM

**Rich "Meatball" Cramer M.D.,
Dispatcher for Lifeline Trauma Inc.,
Night City Branch #23**

**Transport: P&W modified A.V. 4E
Impact rated to threat level 7
Crew: 5: 2 Med, 2 Solos, Driver/
Gunner**

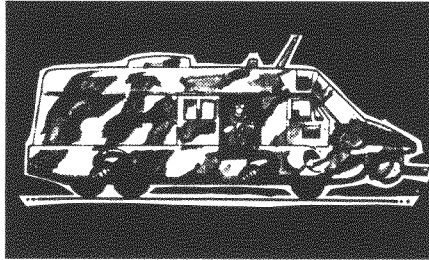
6:30 : Early call. Responded to warehouse district. Patient victim of Booster skirmish. Open chest. Trauma to liver, pancreas. Two collapsed lungs. Blood PH four over norm. Patient flatlined. Unable to revive. Removed model K-100 cyber-arm with combat options for compensation. Suggest placing half of resale into company Christmas fund as per norm.

9:47 : Broken card alert at Hari Kiri Sushi restaurant. Corp patient found choking on piece of squid. Administered swift slap to back and dislodged foreign object. Read patient list of response charges. Patient became hostile and threatened lawsuit. Added surcharges. Patient pulled firearm, forcing Solo to fire in self defense. Patient revived and brought to Med Center. Suggest cancelling account after payment of bills.

11:23 : Solo down on grounds of Raven Microcyb Inc. Corp security became hostile and refused to allow extraction procedures of patient, claiming first rights due to Corporate Espionage Act of 2009. No one in team had ever heard of the Act, and in accordance with standard procedure, we continued with extraction. Raven Inc's. lawyers should be in contact concerning deaths of six security personnel who were in path of

AV-4 upon departure. Patient revived and charged extra for ammo costs and company lawyers fees.

14:15 : Firefight in inner city. Two



broken cards. Upon arrival discovered a team from R.E.O. Meatwagon Inc. in process of loading carded patients onto their unit. Following company policy on "meat jumping", we warned them off over loudspeaker. R.E.O. team opened up with small arms fire. Team R.N. Chestly Whitestone took the initiative and released napalm canisters. Resulting explosion cost lives of both the patients and the R.E.O. team. However, Nurse Whitestone's quick thinking saved company's and team's reputations. Suggest that we sue R.E.O. Meatwagon for costs of patient accounts and munitions expenses.

15:55 : Broken card call at Grand Illusion Dance Hall and Bar. Subject patient one Rockerboy, Kerry Eurodyne. Patient was in good health, but was under assault of young female fans. Dispensed teargas and waded into the fold. The grateful Mr. Eurodyne billed the cost of extraction and a new set of clothes to his studio's account and gave us a healthy tip. Since the teenyboppers seemed to enjoy the free-spirited chaos, I doubt the company need worry about lawsuits from irate parents.

16:30 : Team members attacked in bar during rest break between calls; shotgun-wielding Booster attempted robbery. Criminal was dispatched by team security leader, Jazz Tobias. Criminal flatlined from small arms fire and set off cybernet Lifeline response. Unable to revive. Suggest forfeiture of advance fees on account along with all personal effects. Due to amount of cyberware on patient, it is possible that she was in first stages of cyber psychosis.

17:40 : Net call to alley behind Night City chapter of Elks Lodge. Patient identified as DMS Vid actress Samantha Horn. Apparent overdose on mixture of 'Dorph and Slam. Patient revived. Dispatcher instructions followed to return patient to DMS studios. Team ambushed while on approach vector to DMS pad by three AV-4s bearing R.E.O. Meatwagon markings. Took evasive action. Main stabilizers holed during fire exchange. DMS anti-air defenses opened up at range of 300 yards scattering R.E.O. vehicles, one of which crashed over the financial district during retreat. Patient delivered after payment of hazardous duty fees and the promise of a night on the town with the chief surgeon. Have taken the liberty of placing all Lifeline teams on Class I alert. Counter all R.E.O. personnel and vehicles "with extreme prejudice". See supplemental report on incident and vehicle damage.

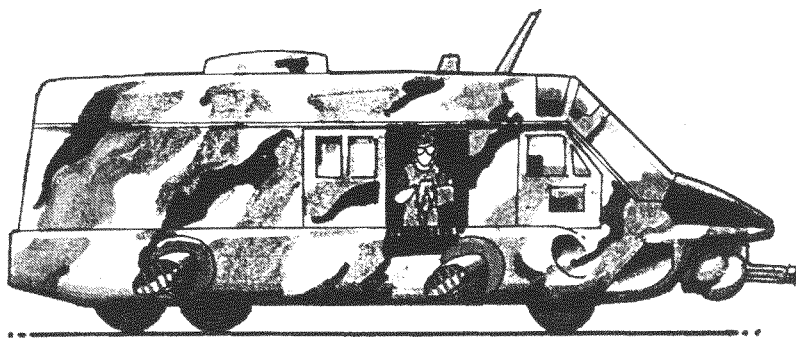
19:00 : Finished shift and returned vehicle to pool. Overtime and hazard duty pay logged with dispatcher. Team placed on two day paid layover while repair of vehicle in progress. Heavy weapons issued from Lifeline armory. Fixers contacted to deal with R.E.O. personnel. Team will remain together until incident blows over. For emergencies, contact team via Net passcode "Stitch In Time".
...End of Report.End of Report.

SCREAMSHEETS

IN THE 21ST CENTURY, THERE'S A LOT OF WAYS TO GET THE WORD. BUT THE BEST IS FROM A SCREAMSHEET— A COMBINATION FAX-NEWSPAPER, DIRECT LINKED TO THE DATABASES OF THE WORLD MEDIACORPS.

SOMETIMES A SCREAMSHEET IS JUST INFORMATION; A CHEAP THRILL FOR THE BRAINBURNED. BUT SOMETIMES, THERE'S ANOTHER STORY; A DEEPER MEANING LURKING LIKE A SHARK JUST UNDER THE SURFACE; A SCRAP OF DATA THAT LEADS TO A NEW ADVENTURE, JUST AROUND THE TURN OF A PAGE.

HERE ARE TEN VISIONS OF THE EDGE.



SCREAMSHEETS

WRITTEN BY: MIKE BLUM

ART DIRECTION: JANET PIERCY & TED TALSORIAN

DATABASE: WORLD NETWORK NEWS & NETWORK 54

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NIGHT CITY TODAY

SEPTEMBER 29, 2020
VOLUME CCVI, No. 28

PETROCHEM REACTS TO BIOTECHNICA PGE ANNOUNCEMENT

Dallas, TX – An unnamed spokesperson for Petrochem provided a dramatic statement for reporters and industry analysts subsequent to Biotechnica's disclosure of the new PGE enzyme. "We believe that 6 months is not enough time for proper tests to be done on this engineering product. The possible biohazard is enormous, especially considering that the Russians produce 10% of the world's wheat and corn. If some unexpected side effect were to diminish or eliminate their agricultural output, massive famines could result."

MIDWEST ROAD CONDITIONS TODAY

SPONSORED BY PETROCHEM

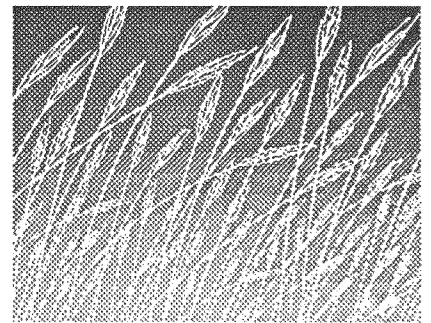
"Without Petrochemicals, life as we know it would be impossible..."
[excerpts]

...Interstate 40 eastbound closed near Fort Smith, Arkansas for bridge repairs...traffic on Interstate 35 is slowed by a southbound nomad convoy in Lyon county, Kansas...U.S. 81 near Enid, Oklahoma has been closed due to a toxic waste spill-route not likely to be opened today...up to one hour delays on eastbound Interstate 44 near Tulsa due to road work...slow going on the Indian Nation Turnpike south of Henryetta due to smoke from a fire at a tire dump...severe flooding reported in several Gulf states, and along the Mississippi River...acid hail reported around Omaha...highway sniper incidents ongoing at Fort Worth have halted traffic...drifts of migrating mutant catfish reported on roads west of Shreveport...

BIOTECHNICA ANNOUNCES IMPROVED PLANT GROWTH ENZYME

La Jolla, CA – In a dramatic announcement today, officials of Biotechnica revealed the development of a new plant growth enzyme (PGE), which promises to boost production of grains and cereals by 10%. The enzyme, developed by researchers working here at the Biotechnica Research Facility, will be undergoing formal tests by the USDA soon. Biotechnica expects the PGE to be in distribution by next year.

Stock analysts expect Biotechnica to rapidly gain in value; agriculture giant Petrochem is expected to drop, (see page C-30)

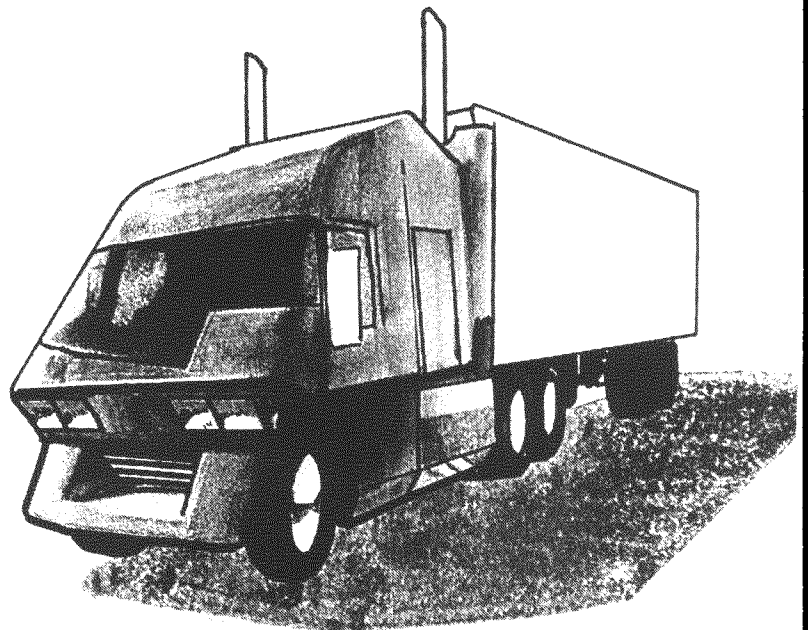


EYE ON THE MARKET:

Night City Today Examines
the Best in Available
Equipment.

**Today: The Yakurichi-Ural
BR70 Heavy Transporter**

With: Full Cyber interface •
Nav System with NAVSTAR®
Guidance Package • Radar •
CB Radio • Sleeper cab for
two • Powerplant: Rolls Royce
CB40V • 5,800 HP • 110
highway/130 boosted.



Scenario 1:

Open Highway

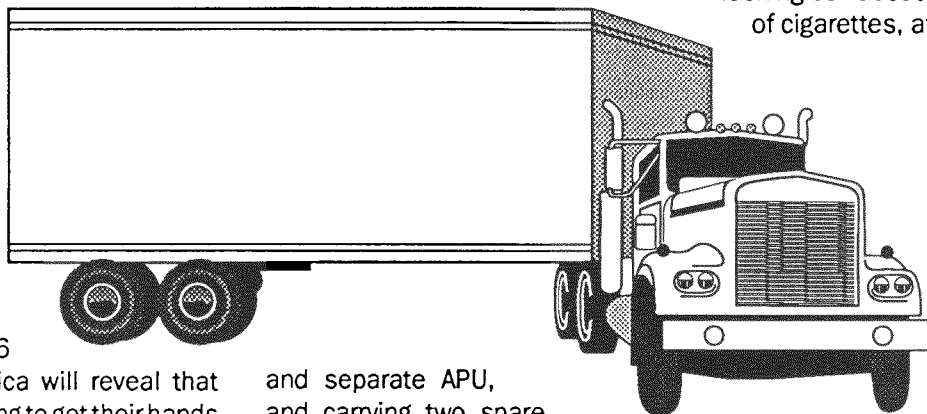
Players' information

The players, while on the West Coast, are approached by Biotechnica about driving and escorting a tractor-trailer rig loaded with PGE and test items from their site at La Jolla, to a USDA facility in near Nashville, TN. The team would be required to cover 1900 miles in 36

hours. Biotechnica will reveal that Petrochem is trying to get their hands on some of the PGE, and the team should expect trouble. In the Mid-western states, where Petrochem owns vast pieces of the landscape, the corporation can pretty much do what it wants.

The tractor is a Yakurichi-Ural BR70, with a cyber interface, nav system, CB radio, radar warning receiver, 2 zero/zero ejection seats, automatic fire extinguishers, road surface sonar for the active suspension, hazard warning/auto braking radar in the grille, air conditioning, stereo system, sleeper cab, winch, and 70 SP kevlar fibreglas body, with 30 SP polycarb windows. The power plant is a Rolls-Royce CB40v turbo-compound 64 liter V-12 variable geometry free piston engine acting as gas generator for 4 modified Teledyne CAE J402 turbojets, burning a mixture of nitro-doped high octane gasoline, meta-alcohol, ether, and acetone; a tank of inhibited red fuming nitric acid is available as a boost oxidant, for up to 25 minutes. Max rated (unboosted) at 5,800 shaft horsepower; normal fuel capacity 1200 liters.

Top speed is 110 mph on highway (130 boosted), 40 mph off-road (50 boosted). Length 8m, width 3m, height 3.1 m. Four extra saddle tanks provide about 2100 miles range total. Total cost, if you want one, is about 120,000 eb. The trailer is a Freyhilf armored van body (90 AP), with an alarm system, airconditioning



and separate APU, and carrying two spare tires (which will also fit the truck). Various repair tools are in workboxes on the tractor. A hatch has been installed on the top of the sleeper cab.

The team will also have the use of two anonymous Toyo-Chevrolet sedans as scout/escort vehicles. Each of these has been fitted with a CB radio and "police interceptor" performance options (treat as 'sportscars'). However, neither is armored.

The cargo consists of 20 plastic drums of plant growth enzyme, 280 sacks of hi-yield fertilizer, and 2 crates of test instruments.

The team members will receive 1000 eb each at the destination if the cargo is delivered intact.

Ref's notes:

Biotechnica is using the players' team as a decoy. The PGE in their truck is actually an early experimental version that went subtly wrong. Biotechnica is hoping that Petrochem will a) be diverted away from the real

shipment, and b) if the fake PGE is stolen, Petrochem will waste a few months figuring out what it is. To further this goal, Biotechnica has fitted the tractor with a satellite transponder, and will leak the location of the truck (through independent netrunners and cutouts) to Petrochem once or twice during the run. The transponder is an anonymous-looking box about the size of a pack of cigarettes, attached under the

dashboard. Thus, the characters can expect to be intercepted a couple of times by cars, helicopters, roadblocks, corporate troops, etc.

If the armor over the fuel tanks on the Yakurichi-Ural tractor is penetrated, the remaining fuel in that tank may self-ignite. Five of the tanks contain the gasoline/alcohol/ether/acetone portion of the fuel, 300 liters each tank; the sixth tank contains 300 liters of red fuming nitric acid.

The real shipment is being sent by entirely different methods and routes, guarded by Arasaka hired mercs.

Biotechnica will grudgingly pay the characters if they successfully reach Nashville, however. Nobody wants a reputation for shafting solos, after all.

NIGHT CITY TODAY

October 6, 2020
VOLUME CCVI, No. 29

>CRIME
>NIGHT CITY STALKER
>RECENT: 3 WEEKS : NIGHT CITY

BRIGHTMAN RELEASED FROM PRISON

Night City, CA – After spending 17 years in prison, Joshua Brightman was released yesterday at the end of his sentence. Suspected of being the “Night City Stalker,” Brightman was never convicted of any of the 32 murders committed by the Stalker. His was imprisoned for kidnapping and attempted murder, after a widely-publicized trial. Many believe, however, that Brightman is indeed the Stalker. The former electronics store manager is now 39 years old.

Threats against Brightman’s life have already been received, and his stated intent of returning to Night City has already alarmed citizens’ groups. Police spokespersons, however, were unconcerned, stating, “We deal with cyberpsycho every day who make the Stalker look like Santa Claus. I expect Mr. Brightman will find the streets are a bit tougher than he remembers.”

In related news, Federal prosecutor Mel de Costa verified that charges will not be brought against Brightman under various Federal firearms statutes, as the statute of limitations has expired. Brightman was found in possession of a sizable arsenal at the time of his arrest, but charges were not pressed at that time. “The

State of California dropped the ball on the prosecution of Brightman,” said de Costa. “We were assured at the time that he would be convicted of multiple murder charges with special circumstances, and so did not go ahead with the weapons charges. By the time the trial ended, our resources were spread pretty thin in various Central American “International Drug-Lord Statute” prosecutions, and so a case was never made.”

>BRIGHTMAN
>RECENT: 2 WEEKS : NIGHT CITY

SUSPECTED “STALKER” BUYS CYBERLIMBS

Night City, CA – This reporter has learned that Joshua Brightman, recently released from prison, and suspected of being the “Night City Stalker,” has undergone extensive cybernetic replacement surgery in the last few days. The exact nature of his enhancements are unknown, but he has spent over \$3000 on hardware alone.

Night City police spokesperson Claude Maxwell would only com-

ment, “As long as Brightman doesn’t purchase any illegal cybertech, we can’t touch him.” When asked if the NCPD planned to monitor Brightman’s cyberware purchases, Maxwell replied, “No comment.”

>CRIME
>MURDER
>NIGHT CITY
>CURRENT : CURRENT :

CRIME BEAT

The consolidated crime report for last week reads as follows: 72 murders, up 2 from the same week last year; 190 attempted murders, down 6; 590 felony assaults, up 12; 15 kidnaps, up 1; (see page C-6)



**WATCH NEWS 54 WITH
DONDRE WHITFIELD
8:00 ON CHANNEL 54.
THE
MAXIMUM
INFORMATION
CHANNEL**

WANTED: persons with experience in archaeology for work on a corporate research project. Preference given to specialists in early British Megalithic sites. Top \$\$\$\$. Contact Hudson Assc. 1-212-555-6798

BODY IMAGE
When only the Best will do...
1-417-555-8900

Interfaced.
The Master Hackers
For all your NET Security Needs.
Contact DF 562-128, code 1226,
for a free evaluation.

Scenario 2:

Back from the Penalty Box

Players' information

The characters are approached by Carole Medina, a small time fixer, who needs protection. She has recently gained some evidence which would prove that Joshua Brightman is indeed the Night City Stalker. She is trying to get Network News 54 and the World News Service to bid on this evidence, but this will take a day or two for the deal to go down. In the meantime, she is worried about both of the corporations trying to get something for nothing, and also worried about getting a visit from the Stalker. She will pay 500 eb each for up to 6 characters to keep her safe for two days. The characters can choose where to set up their "safe house," as long as it is within either the Downtown, South City, or Charter Hill areas. Each of the news corps will want to send someone around to inspect the evidence before bidding.

Medina herself is armed with a short-barrelled .357 Magnum revolver.

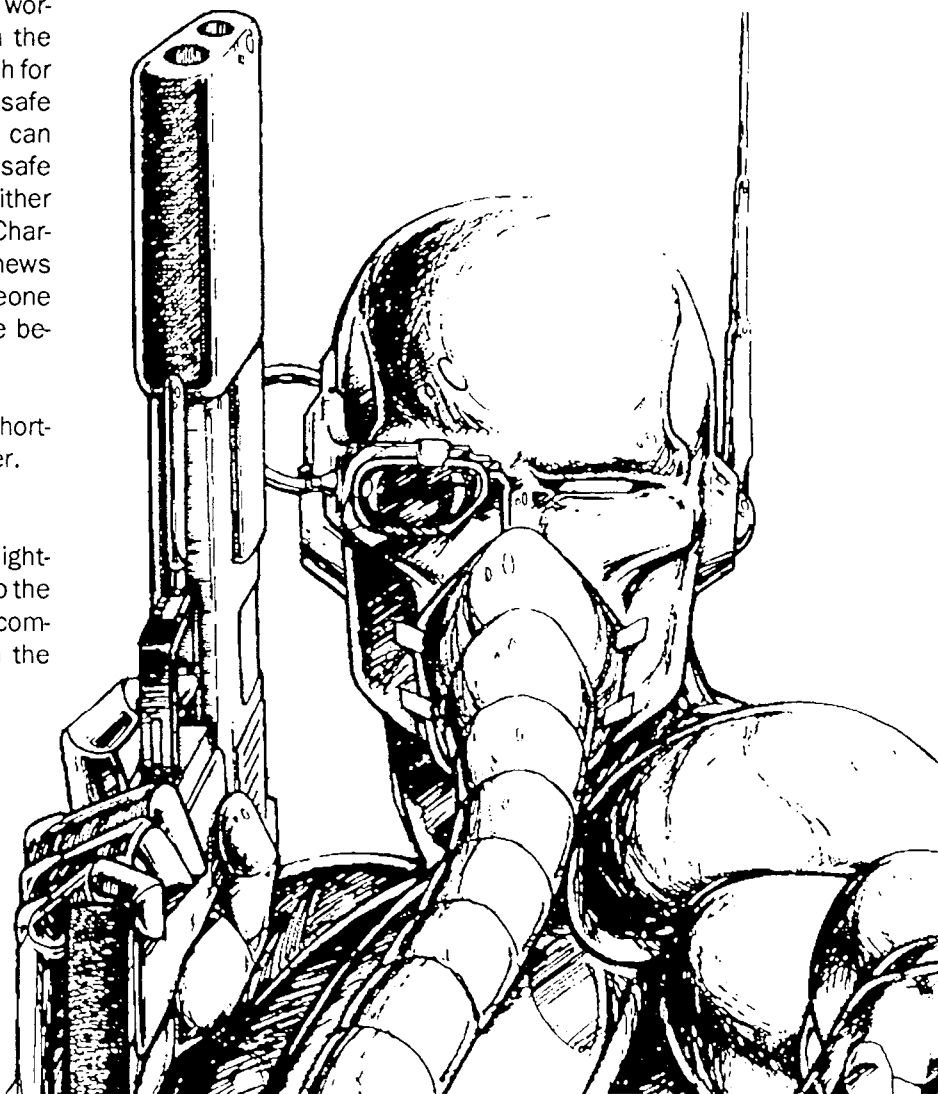
Ref's notes:

Brightman is sure enough the Night-stalker. He has already armed to the teeth and then some, and has committed a couple of murders in the

past week. He was a tech freak before he went to prison, and has followed the development of cyberware with a calculating intensity. He has gone all-out on cyberware purchases: bodyplating, cyberlimbs, pretty much every kind of legal and illegal cybertech. He does not suffer from cyberpsychosis, as such: he was a psycho long before cyberware was available. Brightman is preternaturally stealthy, and delights in "spooking" his victims before he finishes them. He has a very good knowledge of electronics of the more simple kind: phone and power lines, for example. As the Stalker, he carries a good supply of big guns and knives, and wears black coveralls and a balaclava.

The two news corporations will each send, at different times, an investigator over to view the evidence Medina has gathered (a shoebox full of gruesome photographs). For the next 18 hours or so, the two corporations bid and maneuver. Eventually, late in the evening of the second day, one corporation will put up the winning bid; an executive for the other, in a fit of spite, will call Brightman and tell him where Medina is, and why he should pay her a call.

Six hours will pass while payment details are arranged and the corporation sends over a team to collect the evidence. During that time, Brightman will strike...



NIGHT CITY TODAY

October 13, 2020
VOLUME CCVI, No. 30

REPORT

MEDIA: DMS CRACKS DOWN ON COMPETITORS

Los Angeles, CA — In the wake of FCC's "La Rosita" ruling, Diverse Media Systems has gone after uncensored competitors with vigor. Lawsuits, jamming, ECM, and physical harassment have all been employed in an aggressive effort to counter the 'independents' programming. Other mediacorps have also taken advantage of the new loosened rules, but only DMS has gone to the acceptable limits...some would say past them.

In this article, we will examine the latest actions by DMS, and try to uncover the reasons (cont'd page C-2)

>KRAB

>RECENT: CURRENT: LOS
ANGELES

JOSH CARBONELL MAKES WAVES IN THE OCEAN

Media renegade Josh Carbonell is tweaking the nose of the corporate bigwigs at DMS again! His pirate station KRAB, operating off of an old

oil platform in the San Pedro Channel, has broken several major stories lately; two of those stories showed DMS's own reporters in a very bad light. In the "Imperial Valley Genetic Scandal" series, KRAB reporter Julian Morales revealed that DMS's own investigators were involved in the coverup of a major biohazard waste site. In his own "A Deeper Look" series, Josh himself has done follow-ups on stories run by DMS and Network 54; DMS particularly came out looking foolish. KRAB has also become a fad favorite music station in LA, as well.

Josh attributes his success to "sex, drugs, and the worst taste in music west of the Rockies. I let my DJs do their own programming, and expect my reporters to kick (cont'd page C-15)

>MORE:

CHIPPING AWAY

Since the summer of 2011, Elay residents have been exposed to dangerous radiation — specifically, the transmissions of pirate radio station KRAB. The station produces a signal strong enough to reach 37 million Angelenos — though it has also been off the air for intervals of up to a week. The wild and woolly mix of political rock, "unconventional" news, and other unexpected programming elements have made this station the street box favorite. DJs Montjoy Singh, Renee Dillon, and (see page C-15)

>CALHUA-MEXICA

>RECENT: 2 WEEKS: LOS
ANGELES

BOOSTERGANG TRASHES INDEPENDENT RADIO STATION; 3 KILLED

Early this morning, a local boostergang raided a small pirate radio station, operating as Radio Free Burbank, and destroyed their studio and mobile units. Three people, including the station's owner, Mark Springfield, were killed. The station, which had been operating on various FM channels, was noted for its unique musical choices, and hardhitting investigative reporting. Local police had no comment as yet on the attack.

The station had been broadcasting by stealing airtime on corporate station transmitters, using sophisticated computer infiltration techniques. They had no transmitter of their own.

The boostergang, identified as the Calhua-Mexica gang, has been linked in the past with the DMS mediacorp. However, corporate spokespeople denied any knowledge of such a link. Representatives of the Calhua-Mexica gang, when contacted by this reporter, gave a rambling statement which seemed to indicate they felt generally insulted by Radio Free Burbank, and had decided to take action on their own.

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Scenario #3:

Pirate Radio

Players' Information:

The characters are recruited by KRAB's Josh Carbonell to guard his studios and staff from DMS and their thugs. He fully expects to receive a visit from the Calhua-Mexica gang in the near future. He will pay 100 eb a day, each day, plus room and board, for at least a month's work. You also get to pal around and get stoned (off duty) with a bunch of cool DJs, underground media personalities, and visiting musicians.

The actual KRAB studio is on a barge, several kilometers from the old oil rig which carries the KRAB transmitter. There is a tight beam microwave link from the barge to the oil rig, and all of the KRAB correspondents use cell-phones to call in their stories. Josh does not have a lot of faith in this system keeping DMS from finding his studio.

The barge is in the middle of a raft-city, covering nearly 50 square miles, which floats just off the shores of Los Angeles. The residents are poor, homeless, ethnically disadvantaged, undocumented, and/or avoiding the law. Nearly 120,000 people live out here, on old barges, small ships, pontoons, jury-rigged rafts, and just about anything else that floats. There are twisting, narrow "canals" of open water running through the raft city. The Coast Guard has long ago given up trying to disperse this mess, and content themselves with keeping the rafts out of the sea lanes and harbor. The Rafterers are essentially another variety of "Nomads" for *Cyberpunk* game purposes, though the raft-city does not wander around.

At any time, there will be at least a dozen NPCs on the KRAB barge: Josh, 3 Techs who maintain the massive kluge of radio gear at the station, a couple of Medias who act

as producers/writers/sound engineers for the station, a Rafter cook, a couple of DJs or reporters (more Medias, or possibly Rockerboys), and some underground media/music personality here for an interview (or possibly to help Josh defend the place), along with his or her band (and possibly a groupie). Most of these people will be armed with various light pistols.

The Techs have mounted a couple of low-light cameras on the barge mast. A warren of rooms has been created out of sheet steel in and on the barge; the decor is best described as "funky."

A couple of speedboats and a 'utility' outboard owned by the station are normally available for travelling around in the raft-city, or to Los Angeles.

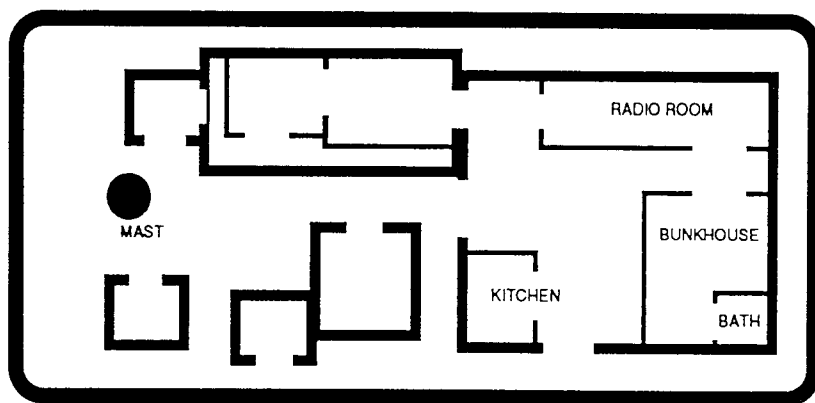
The Techs, Josh, and some of the Media-types normally play lots of poker at night.

Ref's Notes:

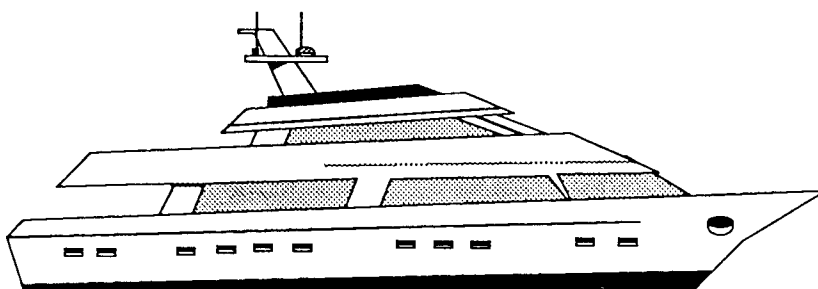
DMS will indeed find the actual location of the studio within a few days, and will send their goons the Calhua-Mexica gang out to destroy it. They will arrive in 6 stolen speedboats, and a stolen Bell-15 Airogyro. Each boat will be carrying 3 boosters, the Airogyro only 1. Lots of automatic weapons, a couple of grenade launchers, and a few Molotov cocktails will round out the bad guys weaponry. The booster in the gyro will play 'bomber.' All of them have reflex boosters and smart guns, at least; other cyberware is certain to be installed.

The Rafterers around the barge may join in and help the players, if things seem to be going poorly; they have no love for the boosters, and Josh has been a good neighbor.

If the players manage to repel the assault, Josh will offer them occasional employment as 'backups' for his reporters.



THE BARGE



NIGHT CITY TODAY

October 20, 2020
VOLUME CCVI, No. 31

BOOBYTRAPPED CYBERWARE ON THE STREETS!

Night City – In a bizarre twist on the problem of black market cyberwear, this reporter learned today of a flood of sabotaged cyberware which has been unleashed in this city. Apparently sold to unsuspecting boosters, these prosthetics contain chips programmed to cause violent incidents.

No pattern has yet been detected to the reason for these incidents. Several boosters have strangled themselves with their own cyberarms; others have fired on police cars or patrol officers (with less reason than usual). Some have been driven into cyberpsychosis with alarming speed, and others found dead with no apparent cause. Few of these incidents have been investigated fully by the police until recently.

Few boosters have survived their rebellious cyberware; none were willing to talk to this reporter. It is believed that the cyberware involved was purchased on the street, and outwardly at least resembles various cheap popular brands.

REWARD FOR BRINGING DOWN SABOTAGE CHIPWEAR DEALER!

Night City (AP) – In an unprecedented announcement, the Night City PD, the heads of three major boostergangs, and an association of local street clinics revealed a

reward fund for "bringing to justice" the persons responsible for the sabotage cyberware being sold in Night City. The fund, standing currently at 5000 eb, was contributed to by the Police Benevolent Association, the major boostergangs, and several street clinics. Detective Arnold Heller, speaking for the PBA, said, "The patrol officers feel there are enough risks to working the Combat Zone, without these human time bombs on the street. We are hoping some responsible citizens can help us put an end to this problem. Of course, people should be aware that this is a hazardous situation, and act accordingly." Representatives for the clinics and gangs endorsed Detective Heller's comments; "Razorface," head of the Grimmers, added, "Yeah, what s——d said, goes for us, double."

Night City DA Bernard Moon, when



BERNARD MOON

asked about this apparent invitation to "vigilante justice" by the Night City PD, said, "Naturally, we have to carefully enforce any laws broken by anyone, even while doing a public service. However, it is also true that there is considerable leeway for my office to decide which cases to prosecute. Our caseloads are already staggering! Without committing myself to anything, I can certainly say that any mitigating circumstances would be taken into account before a decision was made on whether to file charges.

"As for the reward offer, there are certainly precedents at both the state and federal level for such action."

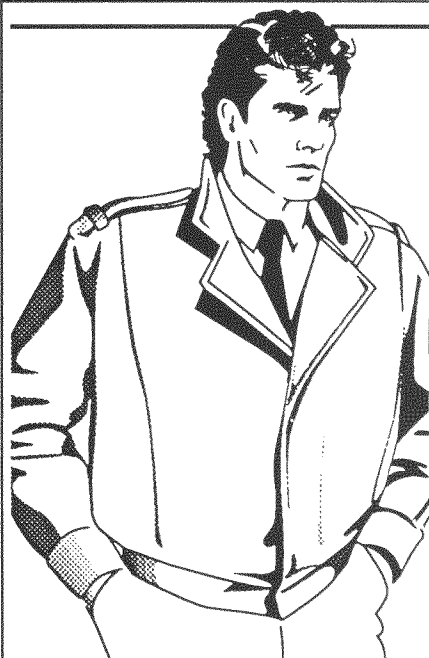
BODY IMAGE
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GANG VIOLENCE ON RISE IN NIGHT CITY

Several major battles have taken place between Night City boostergangs, all related to the sabotage chipware being sold in the streets. Some of the battles were caused by accusations of complicity in the distribution of the corrupt cyberware; others were apparently provoked by the cyberware itself. So far, 27 gang members, 8 bystanders, and 3 Night City policemen have been killed in these incidents.

In response to this violence, the anti-prosthetics group, the Inquisitors, has been staging protests at City Hall Plaza, calling for stricter enforcement of black-market cyberware laws.

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Scenario #4:

Armed & Dangerous

Players' Information:

Here is a chance for the players to make some bucks, without an employer watching over their shoulder. The reward offer seems legit, and the characters would stand to gain some friends in the gangs, on the police force, and in the small clinics: not the worst friends to have.

Of course, first you have to find the dealers.

Ref's notes:

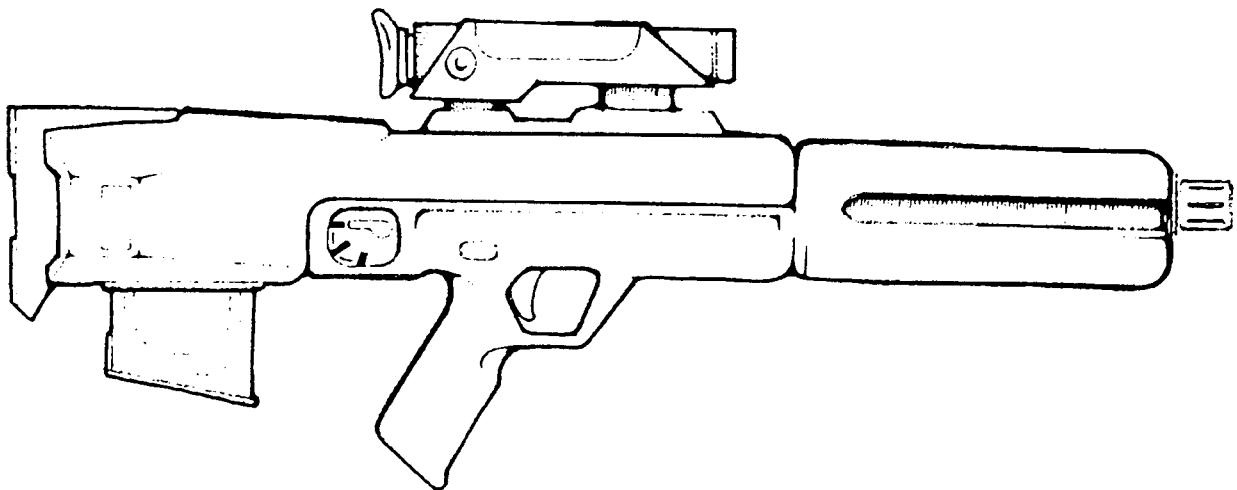
For most of this scenario, the players will be using lots of Stealth, Shadowing, Human Perception, and lots and lots of Streetwise.

The sabotage chips are being made overseas, installed in standard cheap cyberware, and brought into Night City by the Inquisitors. They then sell the cyberware (at a loss) to boosters, who do most of the actual "retail" distribution. The boosters involved, mostly members of the

"Barons," have realized what is going on; but being particularly nasty boosters, don't really care as long as they don't get caught.

Eventually, the characters should be able to get the time and place of a meeting, where some of the "Barons" will meet their mysterious suppliers, and hand over cash for cyberware. The characters may want to bust up the party right there, in which case several of the suppliers will turn out to be Inquisitors in mufti. Or, they can follow the suppliers around, and catch them with their unsavory pals at whatever dive the Inquisitors call home. Either way, lots of heavily armed people will be mad at them for a short while; some will have lots and lots of cyberware, some will have none at all. 10,000 eb in cash and 10,000 eb worth of black market cyberware are being traded; most of the cyberware is sabotaged, but the money is fine.

Once the police and boostergangs have been informed of who is really responsible for the problems, the characters' troubles will be over. For the "Barons" and the Inquisitors, the troubles will be just beginning . .



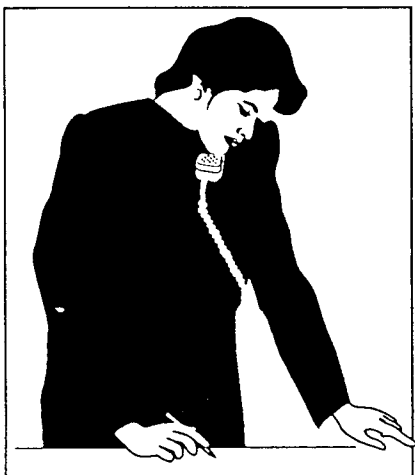
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NETWORK 54 ANNOUNCES CABLE AMNESTY PROGRAM TO END SOON

New York – Network News 54 announced today that, at the end of their 60 day amnesty program, they would be taking “harsh measures” to deal with illegal hookups. When asked about what these measures might be, company spokesperson Andrea Kugel replied:

“We will go after these people using every legal tactic available to



ANDREA KUGLE OF NET 54

us. These people are not paying their share; their neighbors should realize that. We estimate that if all of the current illegal hookups were converted to legal, paying hookups, rates to consumers could be decreased by as much as 12%!

“Our amnesty program is very simple. You just pay the standard 50

eurobuck connection fee—that’s it. Our installers are certainly under no pressure to disconnect — we would rather have happy paying customers. But if we have no other recourse, we will disconnect illegal or delinquent hookups as fast as we can.

“If you don’t want to reduce your rates, all you have to do is sit there. But if you want the possibility of lower rates, call our toll-free number 1-700-555-3465.”

REPORT

MEDIA: CAN NETWORK 54 DEAL WITH CABLE HIJACKING?

By Ed Andersen

In the wake of the announcement by Network News 54 of the upcoming end of their amnesty program, we have uncovered some interesting statistics. In a similar program undertaken last year by the City of New York, which owns it’s own cable system, the cost of the program exceeded the new income brought in by formerly illegal subscribers. In addition, 18 city cable employees were killed while disconnecting homes from the cable net; 3 persons were killed by cable employees returning fire. 20% of the disconnects were later discovered to be legitimate, paid in full cable accounts.

As most of these disconnects occur in poor neighborhoods, the disconnection teams are exposed to great risk to life and limb from gang activity in those areas as well.

In light of this, can Network News 54 really claim that our neighborhoods will benefit from this program? In our opinion, an extended amnesty program would better suit the public interest, and (cont’d page C-14)

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Cable Employee Killed By Video Pirate

Night City, CA – An employee of Night City Cable, a local subsidiary of Network News 54, was killed yesterday while trying to disconnect an apartment in the South City district. The employee, Renee Wong, was pronounced dead on arrival at City Medical Center, having suffered multiple gunshot and stab wounds. The three other members of her disconnect team were also admitted to the hospital; one remains in intensive care, while the other two are in “fair” condition. Police have a suspect, Charlton Ompa, age 30, in custody. Mr. Ompa, an unemployed theater usher and a veteran of the Central American Wars, has plead not guilty to the charges of murder with special circumstances, attempted murder, possession of unregistered firearms, possession of explosive devices, assault with intent to do grievous bodily harm, possession of illegal cyberware, and resisting arrest.

Apparently Mr. Ompa objected to the Night City Cable team cutting his illegal hookup while he was watching the National Laser League playoffs.

BODY IMAGE

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